

Rel 102 The Historical Reliability of the Bible

Numbered Transcript

REL 102 • Wesley Huff

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Lecture 1: Old Testament Canon

At a glance — Huff introduces the Bible's influence and the Old Testament canon.

- 1.1 The Bible is the most influential book in Western civilization, shaping what we refer to as the modern Western world. We're going to be talking about the historical reliability of what we call the Bible. But there are some complex issues that we're going to navigate over the next few days, going through its history, its textual reliability, and its canonicity.
- 1.2 Because the Bible is not one book as much as it's 66 books. Sixty-six books written over a period of about 1,600 years on three different continents by close to 40 different authors in three different languages. And so there's complexity to that. And there's also a caveat. There's a caveat that if you are holding a Roman Catholic Bible, you have 73 books. If you're holding an Eastern Orthodox Bible, those differ between 76 and 81 books. And the fullest canon in the history of Christianity is the Ethiopian church that boasts 88 books.
- 1.3 So, there are going to be issues that pertain to even the books that we're discussing. We're going to navigate a little bit through what that history is, the reception history of the biblical books.
- 1.4 But let me just start off with a question, because should the Bible's history cause us to doubt its reliability and authority? What I mean by that is that despite dates, despite times, cultures, people's languages, and data that we're going to be discussing over the next few days, I would argue that the Bible's history should cause us to appreciate its authority and inspire us to read it and study it more.
- 1.5 Not everybody agrees in my field of formal academia. Let me just start off by giving a foil to that. Kristin Swenson is the associate professor of religion at Virginia Commonwealth University. She says this, "Considering that we don't have one original and undisputed Bible, but rather a collection that evolved over a long period of time for which evidence is copies of copies, not all which agree with one another. How can I, as a person, believe in it, much less live by it?" There's a granting that we look at the data, but in all sorts of fields, we come to various conclusions. What I'm going to be presenting today is the opposite of what Dr. Swenson there is prescribing, in that when we look at the data, I think we can have confidence to believe it, much less live by it.
- 1.6 But before we do that, let me start by defining a few words, because these are words that exist in the ether—but I want to make sure that we're understanding, when I'm using them, what I mean by them—and that is canon and apocryphal.
- 1.7 Canon comes from the Greek word "canon," which simply means a rule or a list. It was actually a stick in ancient antiquity that was used to measure things. It was a measuring rod. As time went on, the word just became synonymous with the standard, the

standard by which you measure something. We can understand this. We have canons, we have Star Wars canons and Lord of the Rings canons, and we have apocryphal material within those particular fields as well. But a canon is an exclusive list of authoritative books for our topic today that reflects which books an author recognized as the peculiar divinely inspired scripture.

- 1.8 And then apocryphal, which simply means obscure or doubtful or secret, apocryphon in Greek, is that which is outside of the canon. So it doesn't necessarily equate to it being, say, heretical within an ancient Christian understanding. Apocryphal literature just ranges between really wild and really crazy, and we'll talk about that a little bit later on when we get into some of the Gnostic literature, and is simply talking about orthodox material, small-o orthodox, that which bears the right teaching, but was simply not recognized as that which had the same level of authority.
- 1.9 This word had various meanings. You can see here that this is the ending of a particular writing which uses in its name the word apocryphon, and that's simply according to the [Secret Book of John]. This is the end of the Secret Letter of John, which was found in the Nag Hammadi Library in 1945. It was part of a collection of a whole host of different documents. The end of the [Secret Book of John] then goes into the Gospel of Thomas, which we're going to be talking about a little bit later on. But that just simply means that this was a word that wasn't necessarily taboo in the ancient world. Some of these groups even used this word to describe their own literature, defining it as secret or unknown. That was key, especially to the Gnostic literature.
- 1.10 Let's go to the fourth century. Augustine of Hippo says this, "But who can fail to be aware that the sacred canon of Scripture, both of the Old and New Testament, is confined within its own limits, and that it stands as absolutely in a superior position to all later letters of the bishops, that about it we can hold no manner of doubt or disputation whether what is confessedly [contained] in it is right and true."
- 1.11 So, you have there a very high statement of authority. This is the fourth century. Granted, we're 400 years down the road from when these documents are actually written. But you have someone like Augustine, who is reflecting on this, and he's saying that the canon of scripture has the authority that bears more weight than the writings of early Christian leaders, bishops, and individuals who are high within the ranking of the church. There's a status that it owns that is clarified as being above.
- 1.12 Likewise, as I said before, different canons have different lists. There are different reasons in the reception history of these books to that. That's a little bit hard to see, but right there on the screen is the Old in an Orthodox Bible, in a Roman Catholic Bible, and in a Protestant Bible. There are differences within each of those. But these differences are reflective in the Old Testament, not in the New Testament. Part of the reason for this is simply because though we have a Bible that looks like this today, all the books bound in a single document, that wasn't true throughout history.

- 1.13** Throughout history, these books circulated as scrolls and as codices, as books, but independent of one another. This was the reality for a long period of time within what we think of as the inception of early Christianity. But also in Judaism, you would have a Torah scroll, which encompassed the first five books of Moses. But then the other books—the prophets, the writings, the Psalms—those would be separate. This was mainly due to the fact that it is very costly and arduous to produce these materials.
- 1.14** So, it's not really until you get to the fourth century, with the decriminalization of Christianity in [313], when Constantine produces the Edict of Milan, this edict of tolerance that decriminalizes a number of fringe religious groups, including Christianity. Then you have the monetary backing of wealthy individuals, least of which includes Constantine himself, producing documents where you can put all the books into one book. But that is a very costly endeavor. I'll talk about that a little bit later on, what the actual monetary cost of those types of things is.
- 1.15** For the purpose of this morning, I want to go through three different time periods that pertain to the canonicity, the putting together of the books of the Old Testament throughout history that are relevant.
- 1.16** How did we get here? Look at the period before Christianity, look at the period during the 400 years of early Christianity, and then we're going to skip about a thousand years from then on to the Middle Ages and the Reformation period. The relevant data that we're going to be looking at are canon lists, Jewish and Christian canon lists, where, though the books are circulating as independent scrolls and books, they put together these lists of: "Okay, these are the ones that we think bear authority as divinely inspired scripture." We're going to be looking at ancient statements, how particular individuals actually treat this literature. We're going to be looking at manuscripts, these physical documents that bear the actual text of what are referred to as both canonical and apocryphal. We're going to be looking at citations and quotations of various individuals.
- 1.17** If we start in that first 400-year period, what we see there is that this is pertaining to the ancient Jewish canon. Leading up to the first century and the time frame of someone like Jesus, can we look at the data and can we see how early Jews are actually understanding what they describe as scripture?
- 1.18** One of the most important witnesses to this is a guy named Josephus. He comes around at the end of the first century, the very beginning of the second century. In a number of his writings, he says things like this, "For we have not an innumerable multitude of books among us, disagreeing from and contradicting one another, as the Greeks have, but only 22 books." Then he says in a different letter that these books, this scripture, is what is laid up in the temple. Now, that could very well mean that there are physical copies that are within the four walls of the temple. But it also could just be used as a statement of understanding that the temple, as the house of God, is that which confines what God has revealed to them.

- 1.19** Now, I want you to notice—but we're going to clarify this in a moment—you're going to be seeing a number of numbers with the Jewish statements about what they consider scripture. Josephus here says 22. There's another writing that comes around the first century, 4 Ezra [Esdras], and it says, "Make public the 24 books that you wrote first and let the worthy and the unworthy read them, but keep the 70 that were written last in order to give them to the wise among your people."
- 1.20** What 4 Ezra is doing is differentiating this category of these 24 books and these other 70 writings, which are probably Jewish writings, historical writings, philosophical writings, these 70 esoteric writings, but a 24 canonical list. So, what do we see here? Because I have a Protestant Bible up here, and my Protestant Bible has a list of 39 books in its Old Testament. Why do we continue to see the Jews listing 22 or 24?
- 1.21** Actually, the 39 books in my Protestant Old Testament canon are the same books that 4 Esdras and Josephus are listing. They're the same books; they're just ordered differently. So the 22 counts double books like 1 and 2 Samuel, or 1 and 2 Kings. It has all the 12 prophets in one book. It combines Ezra and Nehemiah, Judges and Ruth, and Jeremiah and Lamentations as one book. And then the 24 simply separates Ruth and Judges and Lamentations and Nehemiah.
- 1.22** Part of the reason for this is that certain Jewish ancient writers who are very interested in numbers and the influence of numerology want to coincide the number of Hebrew books in the Old Testament with the number of letters in the Hebrew alphabet.
- 1.23** There are 22 letters in the Hebrew alphabet. One of the reasons why you keep seeing 22 is because there's a correlation. Actually, we see later early Christian writers who are then defending the 22, outright specifically saying this, that there are 22 just as there are 22 letters in the Hebrew alphabet. Now, interestingly enough, there are reasons why these are even grouped together. The 12 prophets can fit on one scroll. So, in the range of how long you can make a scroll, the 12 prophets all fit there comfortably. So they just grouped them together like that.
- 1.24** We also see an ancient bipartite reference. In the Dead Sea Scrolls, which are a collection of documents that come really between the third century BC and the first century AD—and there's some qualification here. The Dead Sea Scrolls are often referenced in a way that doesn't actually reflect what the Dead Sea Scrolls are.
- 1.25** The Dead Sea Scrolls are a library. They're a library of documents that were found along the northwest side of the Jordanian-Israeli border today. But if we say, "Well, this was in the Dead Sea Scrolls; therefore," we're making a leap in logic because the Dead Sea Scrolls have a lot of documents that are all together but are not necessarily from the same groups and were never understood as a single grouping of text within the ancient world. We do need to be careful in that this is more understood as a library that we in the modern world have collected together because we found them along the same reference point in Israel and Jordan.

- 1.26** One of these, the Dead Sea Scroll 1QS, comes from the Qumran community, which we think is largely responsible for a good portion of these writings. The Qumran community was a sectarian group of Jews known as the Essenes. Now, a lot of what we know about the Essenes is because Josephus writes about them. But they were a group that had removed themselves from Jerusalem, from the regular practice of temple worship there, because they saw it as compromised, particularly by the connection of the Romans. They had rejected the temple worship there. They had rejected the priests and the scribes that existed within Jerusalem at that point.
- 1.27** They'd gone out into the desert in this area of the Qumran Valley, and they had developed a very devout and a very stringent religious community, a very small community. It wasn't very big, but they produced a number of material. In it, they reference in some of their literature, which, by the way, the Dead Sea Scrolls includes a lot of the Old Testament.
- 1.28** When I talk about the Dead Sea Scroll, specifically when I talk about the textual evidence for the Old Testament, we'll look at that. But also a lot of literature that's not necessarily scripturally biblical. And part of this is this particular document.
- 1.29** And in it, it says, "Just as he commanded by"—and then he gives a list—"the hand of Moses and the hand of his servants and prophets." And so within a number of the Dead Sea Scrolls, in terms of the outlining of their own religious practice, they themselves stipulate this ancient bipartite reference. What they deem as authoritative scripture is that which comes from the hand of Moses and the hand of God's servants, the prophets. And so, although we're not given specific lists by the Qumran community of what they do and don't consider scripture, we see these sorts of references that we can parse out and give us a frame of reference.
- 1.30** There's another book that comes from the second century BC, and that is the prologue of Sirach. And it says, "So my grandfather Jesus"—we need to stop here for a second. This is not the Jesus you're probably thinking of. Jesus, Yeshua—Joshua was a popular name in the ancient world, a very popular name in the ancient world. This is a Jesus that existed a long time before the Jesus that we're thinking of. But this individual, he says, "So my grandfather Jesus, who had devoted himself to the reading of the law and the prophets and the other books of our ancestors."
- 1.31** Now, modern Jews today will call their Bible—don't call their Bible the Old Testament. That's a Christian understanding that comes really in the second century. The first person to coin the term was an individual named Melito of Sardis in the second century. But they refer to it sometimes as the Hebrew scriptures.
- 1.32** But more often than not, you're going to have Jews refer to it as the Tanakh. The Tanakh is an acronym, T-N-K. The Torah, the Nevi'im, and the Ketuvim, the law, the prophets, and the writings. This is what is encompassed in a modern, say, devout,

Orthodox Jewish Bible. You can ask your Jewish friends, "Have you read the Tanakh today?" They hopefully will give you an answer.

- 1.33 But this is how the Jewish Bible, in the time after Jesus, starts to come together in a single document. But we see this going right back to the prologue of Sirach, the law, the prophets, and the other books. We start to see this delineation. Even before the time of Jesus, we can point to examples of where the solidification of the 22 or 23 or 39, depending on how you divide them up, start to come together.
- 1.34 Okay, but what about the Dead Sea Scrolls? Let's talk about this a little bit specifically. The Dead Sea Scrolls have all our Old Testament books minus Esther and potentially Nehemiah. There's some debate about that. But they have numerous copies of other books, Jubilees, the Enochean literature, the Community Rule, and many others.
- 1.35 Now, what should we make of that? What should we make of the fact that, though all the Old Testament books are found, we don't find something like Esther? Well, we also need to look at how the books are quoted. Interestingly enough, Genesis is never quoted amongst the Dead Sea Scrolls. In the other literature, when they're drawing up commentaries and things like that, Genesis is never quoted.
- 1.36 Now, does that mean that the Qumran community or the group of sectarian Jews that produced the Dead Sea Scrolls didn't believe Genesis was scripture? Well, unanimously, no. Of all the books that are debated within ancient Judaism, everybody's pretty clear that Genesis is in that list.
- 1.37 But it's not that Genesis is not found. Copies of Genesis are some of the most numerous. But in the Jewish literature documents that frequently quote scripture, they don't quote Genesis with the designation as "as scripture says." I'm going to be very specific when I talk about quotations.
- 1.38 When I'm looking for a quotation, I'm looking for that preface of "as it is written," or "as scripture says," or "as the spirit inspired," or "as the spirit of God spoke." I'm going to be very specific with that. So though there might be allusions to Genesis, we don't have this very specific—easy for me to say, the designation in the beginning of that.
- 1.39 Now, Esther and Nehemiah's lack of existence among the Dead Sea Scrolls, do we therefore conclude that it has a non-canonical status? Well, no, because that's an argument from silence. And there's no dispute about Genesis's scriptural status. So once again, we can see that as an argument from silence. But what do we conclude from that? Well, the absence of evidence is not evidence of absence.
- 1.40 Let me give you a different example of this. Marco Polo was an incredibly influential geographer and ancient chronicler. Marco Polo, traveling from Italy into Asia, never once mentions the Great Wall of China. Now, do we conclude then that the Great Wall of China did not exist in Marco Polo's day? No, that would be silly because we know it

existed. Just because we think people should mention things doesn't necessarily mean they ought to.

- 1.41 In terms of an argument from silence, when we look at something like the presence or lack thereof of something like Esther, we need to make sure that we're careful with the conclusions that we draw from that. A lot of these documents are upwards of 2,000 years old. It could be that the books of Esther just didn't survive, or there could be other reasons why they didn't include it.
- 1.42 Esther is more of a controversial document within ancient Judaism specifically because it's the only book of the Hebrew Bible that doesn't include the formal name of God, YHWH—Yahweh, the divine name. It's never used once. Now, God is referred to in a secondary way throughout Esther. God is assumed, but the divine name is never found within Esther. Sometimes the ancient Jews would reference that in saying it's in a bit of a different category.
- 1.43 So, we have these quoted books. Exodus, Proverbs, Numbers, Isaiah, Leviticus, and Jeremiah are the most quoted books within the Dead Sea Scrolls. But we can jump over from ancient Israel over to Egypt because we have a writer, Philo of Alexandria, who is a very influential ancient Jewish writer. He quotes from the Torah thousands of times, but he does not quote from all of the Jewish canon. So based on his citations of scriptural books, is it reasonable to assume that he is in agreement with Josephus and has the 22- or 24-book canon that is not long after referred to as the Tanakh? Maybe. Interestingly enough, though, he never once quotes from the books that are later referred to as the Apocrypha or the Deuterocanon in terms of these books that make their way into the Roman Catholic Bible. But once again, we need to be measured in our conclusions drawn from that.
- 1.44 We can look at the New Testament because the New Testament is a collection of 27 books that come from an outpouring of the Jewish community. The earliest Christians were Jews who believed in Jesus as their Messiah. It's useful to look at even how they reference their Old Testament books because we see the 13 most quoted books being some of the most important books within the Old Testament.
- 1.45 But not every book from the biblical Old Testament is quoted even in the New Testament. Song of Solomon is never quoted in the [New Testament]. Interestingly enough, the book of Joshua is never quoted in the [New Testament]. Now, the book of Joshua is mentioned, like I said before, but with the strict criteria of a direct—"it is written," "scripture says," "inspired by the Spirit," these sorts of things—Joshua is never quoted. And so the New Testament doesn't quote every book of the Old Testament.
- 1.46 The New Testament doesn't quote the Apocrypha, though—the Deuterocanon, those books that are in the Roman Catholic Bible—but it does allude to them. 2 Maccabees 6:7 is alluded to in Hebrews 11. There's this chronicling of faithful Jews who have stood up for the faith, and there's an allusion to a story in 2 Maccabees where the Jews are

standing up against the Greeks, and they're being persecuted for that. And Jude does quote Enoch 1:9.

- 1.47 So if we look at the quotation data, we see something very interesting in that it's ranged. We have a range of data within the books that are quoted and that aren't quoted.
- 1.48 Though we continually see whenever the Jews write and talk about how many books are specifically in their canon, we see this 22 or 23 number. And though those are never listed overtly, because of the tradition that carries on into the first century and onward, it is reasonable to assume that those are the books that eventually make up either what we see in the Tanakh or what we see then adopted within what eventually makes it into the Protestant canon of the 39. So we have a range of data: Dead Sea Scroll quotes, Dead Sea Scroll comments, Philo's quote, and then the New Testament's quotes.
- 1.49 But the next 400 years are also relevant. The next 400 years are interesting because as Christians start to develop their own canon, as they look at, as I said before, being Jews who believe in Jesus as the Messiah, as they look at this tradition where you have these covenant promises that God makes, and then the understanding in ancient Judaism being that when God makes a covenant promise, then that carries over into written texts. The texts are the definitive marker of the promises that God makes.
- 1.50 So, when you have Jesus come along and He is understood to have fulfilled certain prophecies, He's understood to bring that new covenant that people like Jeremiah, in Jeremiah 31:31, predicted when he said, "I'm going to make a new covenant with my people. I'm going to write my law on their hearts." Jesus comes and he does things like ratifies that at the Last Supper, on the night that Jesus was betrayed before his crucifixion, he says, "This is the new covenant in my blood." And so there's this understanding: "Okay, we have the covenant. Where are the written texts?" And so there are discussions that come up with that.
- 1.51 But there's also reception history that they're trying to flesh out about what books they consider scripture prior to Jesus. There are a few conversations that go into this in the next 400 years. This is primarily Christian conversations, but also a number of Jews weigh in on this.
- 1.52 The primary criteria is looking at the date of a book, when it was written. Is it a book that has Hebrew inclusion? In other words, when you talk to the Jews, are they saying, "Yes, this is unequivocally inspired scripture. This is the word of God." Then the Christians are also looking at wide acceptance. Is it widely understood as holding that authority? Then there are secondary criteria which are debated, things like, is it written in Hebrew? Because some books that are involved in these conversations are actually written in Greek.

- 1.53** Now, if we go back to Josephus, in the writing that I referenced before Against Apion, says, "Five of these books"—talking about the 22—"are the books of Moses." Can't get any clearer than that. "The prophets, after Moses, wrote the history of what took place in their own times in 13 books, and the remaining four books contain hymns to God and instruction."
- 1.54** Then he says something very interesting. He gives a timeline of when these fit. "From Artaxerxes to our own time, every event has been recorded, but this is not judged worthy of the same trust." In other words, what Josephus is saying is, from the time of Moses and his death to the time of Artaxerxes, which is the period of, if you know the book Esther, that's in the Persian period, the time of Artaxerxes. Josephus says that's the timeline we're working with. Anything before Moses is disqualified. We don't consider anything scripture before what he codifies in the Torah, the first five books. Anything after the time frame of Esther and Artaxerxes, that's out, too.
- 1.55** This seems to be reflective of the Jewish understanding, at least in the Pharisaical tradition that we find in this time. That is the list that encompasses the 39-book canon that has been crystallized. These are the texts from the death of Moses to Artaxerxes. That's from the time of Moses to the time of Esther, anything claiming to be written before or after, they're not considered scripture.
- 1.56** Now, interestingly enough, you have writings that are in great contention, like Enoch. There are actually three books of Enoch—1, 2, and 3 Enoch—all of which contain a collection of books in and of themselves. Just as this Bible that I have up here is 66 books, something like 1 Enoch, which is when we typically refer to the Book of Enoch, we're usually referring to 1 Enoch, itself has a number of books that are included in it.
- 1.57** There are two hypothetical dates for Enoch. One is the pre-flood era, that this actually comes from Enoch. Now, I think that that is highly improbable. But if people are arguing, "Well, it's before Moses," Josephus says, "Well, then it's out." And we just don't consider it scripture. Now, what's more likely from the internal data is that the Enochian literature comes after the time of Artaxerxes in the Hellenistic period. We know this for a number of reasons. It uses Greek timekeeping. There are certain references that it alludes to, which indicate that it's written in this period.
- 1.58** But either way, whether you want to argue that it's really, really old and it was saved on the Ark or something like that, or you want to argue that, no, it actually has these data points of coming from, say, the third century BC, Josephus says it still is disqualified. There's a very clear timeline.
- 1.59** Now, Athanasius in the fourth century says, "Who has made the simple folks believe those books belong to Enoch, even though no scripture existed before Moses?" We even have later Christian writers who are commenting on this, saying that there are some people who are simple-minded, and they're reading Enoch as if it's scripture. He says this is silly, because if you're claiming it's written before Moses, who said that

anything written before Moses was ever considered scripture? The Jews never thought that way, and we never have thought that way.

- 1.60** One of my favorite writers from the ancient world, Gregory of Nazianzus, in the fourth century, also says, "Receive these books of the rather ancient Hebrew wisdom. I have set down the ancient 22 books corresponding to the letters of the Hebrew." Once again, there you have this allusion. The Hebrew alphabet has 22 letters. Gregory of Nazianzus is saying, within the Hebrew inclusion, this is very important. You have this correspondence. He argues, specifically in the fourth century, that's what the Old Testament, what the Christians start referring to as the Old Testament scripture, is.
- 1.61** Later on, you have Augustine. You have Augustine, and he is looking at wide acceptance. Where someone like Gregory of Nazianzus or Athanasius, these early Christian writers, are arguing for reception by the Jews, and they're arguing for date, Augustine has a little bit different of a criterion. Where Augustine would maybe get along with Gregory of Nazianzus quite a bit on something like Christology or Trinitarian doctrine, Augustine differs with Gregory of Nazianzus in his understanding of the Old Testament. He says, "The most expert investigator of the divine scriptures will apply this principle to the canonical scriptures. To prefer those books accepted by all Catholic churches to those which some do not accept. As for those not universally accepted, he should prefer those accepted by the majority of churches and by the more authoritative ones to those supposed by fewer churches or by churches of lesser authority."
- 1.62** In other words, Augustine wants to count noses. He wants to look at what most people think is scripture rather than the data points that some of these other individuals are looking at and going back and saying that we have these statements. Paul, in the Book of Romans says that the Jews were entrusted with the oracles of God. This is one of the lines of argumentation that early Christians used for that 22, 23 or 39 list. We know, at least to some degree, what those were. We have these allusions of these bipartite or tripartite Tanakh understandings.
- 1.63** But Augustine says no, we need to widen that. We need to widen that because there's literature like the Maccabean literature or like Judith or like Tobit that is widely read throughout the churches. So, the wide acceptance is one of the criteria that Augustine uses and argues against people like his compatriot Jerome, who is arguing for a shorter canon.
- 1.64** So, if we look at some of these things, we have this primary data, but we have disagreements. We have disagreements because individuals like Jerome are arguing against individuals like Augustine. Jerome is responsible for eventually translating what is referred to as the Latin Vulgate. I'm going to talk about that when I talk tomorrow about the history of the Old Testament.

- 1.65** The Latin Vulgate becomes the Bible of the church for a thousand years. Jerome is commissioned to translate the Hebrew Old Testament and the Greek New Testament into Latin because people aren't reading Hebrew, and they're not reading Greek anymore either. They're primarily reading Latin. But Jerome is very specific, and Jerome is an incredible linguist. Augustine, not so much. He even, in a number of his writings, says, "I can't read Hebrew and I can sort of read Greek."
- 1.66** But Jerome, Jerome is a master of the languages. When he's putting together a number of his writings, he has lists. He says, "Just as there are 22 letters with which we write in Hebrew, so 22 scrolls are reckoned." Once again, you have that argument, 22 letters in the Hebrew alphabet. He lists the Wisdom of Solomon, Sirach, Judith, Tobit, 1 and 2 Maccabees as—and he uses the term "apocrypha." He says they're explicitly outside of the canon for faith and doctrine.
- 1.67** Now, it's interesting, in the ancient world, our term canon is exclusive to the scriptural books, but there are actually understandings of early Christians saying that we have two canons. We have canons that are for faith and doctrine, and then we have canons that are for edification and encouragement. Nobody in the ancient world, none of these early Christians is saying don't read this stuff. They're saying that you should read this stuff. It's very pertinent to understanding, particularly the time frame leading up to Jesus. It can lend understanding and credibility to even some of the background of Jesus and the disciples.
- 1.68** But, Jerome says that these are apocrypha. They are outside of the canon. Now, Augustine disagrees when he lists his books in the same writing I quoted with him on the advocacy of the church as the originator of the canon; he lists the apocryphal books Jerome notes as included within scripture. So they have a disagreement.
- 1.69** Now, I am biased. When I answer the question: Who's right?, I think Jerome is right. I think Jerome is right based on the data. The reason I say that is because we can look at the antiquity of the provenance of lists.
- 1.70** There's a very interesting individual in the second century, Melito of Sardis, who gives us our first official canon list. Melito, who I said before is the originator of the term Old Testament itself, in writing to an individual named [Onesimus], he writes and uses this term Old Testament, the Old Covenant. He has a list of Old Testament books that he writes out. It includes all of the books of the Jewish canon, the Protestant canon, but he doesn't include Esther. He doesn't. There might be various reasons why he doesn't include Esther, but he doesn't. But he has 38 of the 39. If we're looking at antiquity, if we can go to our earliest, the infancy of canon understandings, Melito is listing our earliest canon list, and he has the 39.
- 1.71** In saying who is right, I would say that being biased, admittedly, I would say that Jerome is right. But it depends on your understanding of how you understand reception history. If the church has an authority that you deem being able to actually give the

books of the Bible, then that reception history is relevant. In a Roman Catholic understanding, the reason why, even though data in terms of its chain of custody in going as early as we possibly can, is on the evidence of the 39 books in the Protestant Bible, if your understanding of reception history is that the church has an infallible right to also deem certain books as authoritative, then that plays into the question.

- 1.72** That's what Augustine is arguing. Augustine is certainly a heavy hitter, arguably the most important writer after the apostle Paul within the early church period. Then once again, we go to Paul. He says, "Then what is the advantage of the Jew? Or what is the value of circumcision? Great in every respect, first of all, that they were entrusted with the oracles of God."
- 1.73** Now, one of the most definitive canon lists that we get is Athanasius in the fourth century. In his Festal letter, in his Easter letter, he writes, "These canonical books are the springs of salvation. There are other books but have been prescribed by the ancestors to read. Nevertheless, believed, the former books are canonized, the latter are only read, and there is no mention of the apocryphal books."
- 1.74** Now, he's actually using the term apocryphal in a different way. He's using it in terms of the other literature that comes in the New Testament. For at least this purpose, we have to differentiate between pocrypha: formal, which are these books in the Old Testament; and apocryphal literature: what Athanasius is referring to here are things like the Gospel of Thomas, Gospel of Mary, Gospel of Judas.
- 1.75** But what he's outlining there is specifically that there's this system. You have the canonical books: that's the canon for faith, for practice, for doctrine. Then you have these other books that are to be read, but they are not scripture. Then you have a bunch of other literature that's too late and too crazy.
- 1.76** Jerome says, "I, therefore, just as the church reads the books of Judith and Tobit and the Maccabees, but does not receive them among the canonical scriptures, so also let her read these two volumes." He's talking about the Wisdom of Solomon and Sirach. This is actually in his preface to his commentary on those books. "For the edification of the people, not for the authoritative confirmation of ecclesiastical doctrine."
- 1.77** Jerome is saying there—there's this very important delineation that he stipulates: the tripartite division. Christians distinguish between their books: canonical, authoritative for doctrine; readable, good for edification, not for doctrine; and then apocryphal, good for nothing, not to be used. That's apocryphal in the term in the New Testament sense. You have canonical, you have readable, and you have apocryphal.
- 1.78** Even for a long time, Protestants would publish the Apocrypha as the Deuterocanonical books that are referred to as scripture in the Roman Catholic Bible in printed Bibles. In 1611, when the King James translation is printed, it had a section between the Old and New Testaments that were labeled Apocrypha and had those books. Most of the English Bibles that predated the King James, like the Bishops' Bible or the Geneva Bible

or the Great Bible or the Matthew Tyndale Bible, all had those books in a list. So it wasn't that these were totally removed and that they had no use and they were just, "Don't read these." Protestants for a long time had the understanding that these are actually useful. These are good. They're just in a different category than what we understand as scripture.

- 1.79 We've covered 400 years before Jesus, talked about some of the statements that we see from Jews, the 400 years after Jesus, and the statements that we see from both Jews and Christians. Well, what about the period about 1,500 years later? What happens when you get to the discussions that are happening within the Protestant Reformation? Those are some of the most fiery of the conversations that happen in regard to where we actually get the divide between a Protestant Bible and a Roman Catholic Bible.
- 1.80 The Eastern Orthodox go off on their own. The Eastern Orthodox develop a theology that is a little bit more esoteric and less analytical. The divide between the East and the West over time parses out in these ways where there's no real formal list within the Eastern Orthodox canon. They're more comfortable with having various lists of books that range from 73 to, like I said before, 81. Then you have in the Ethiopian Tewahedo Orthodox Church, you have 88.
- 1.81 Just as a side note, I'm not going to go in-depth on that, but basically what happens is that Syrian missionaries in the fourth century go down to what is now referred to as Ethiopia, but at that time was understood as the Kingdom of Axum. They bring with them a whole bunch of Christian literature. They bring the Greek New Testament, they bring a number of books from the Greek Old Testament, and they bring some of these other writings that are included within the Greek language.
- 1.82 The Ethiopian Church, as they're converted, as they become after the Armenian communities, the second official Christian nation, they really say, "We're a little less concerned with the conversations that are happening up in the East and West, north of us. We're just going to put everything in a single book." That's as far as we can parse out. That's just what they do.
- 1.83 It's interesting if you go into the Middle Ages, this is an amazing document called the Complutensian Polyglot, which is a mouthful. But the Complutensian Polyglot was put together by the cardinal responsible for the Spanish Inquisition. This is not a guy who is light on heresy. He is very clear on what should and shouldn't be understood within Christian understanding, and if you disagree with him, he might kill you. He puts together his own book of the Bible, the Complutensian Polyglot.
- 1.84 Interestingly enough, he has Hebrew, he has Latin, and he has Greek. It's interesting, he makes this particular argument that he puts the Greek in the middle and the Latin and the Hebrew on the side, and he actually says, this is because Jesus was on the cross and He had two [thieves] on either side of it. The Latin and the Hebrew are inferior—sorry,

he has the Latin in the middle. The Greek and the Hebrew are the inferior ones. They're like the thieves on the cross. The Hebrew might be the thief who eventually asked Jesus to recognize him when he comes into His own. We may not use this argument today, but he says that the Latin is the Jesus text. Everything else, though, he's including it, he's using it for reference, make sure you're reading the Latin, primarily.

- 1.85** Now, in the preface to the Polyglot, he says this, "But be sure that there are books outside of the canon which the church accepts more for the education of the people than for the sanctioned authority of ecclesiastical documents." The books that he outlines are the other books of what are now understood as the Roman Catholic Apocrypha.
- 1.86** In 1517, this is the same year that Martin Luther nails his 95 Theses to the Castle Church door in Wittenberg, prior to really the moving point of the Reformation, you have very influential, very senior individuals within the church who themselves are looking at the reception history of the Bible and they're saying, the 66 books are the core. There are other books. People debate them. People understand what they are. They're good for education. But the cardinal differentiates them as not being that which is inspired scripture.
- 1.87** I think this is a very important note to make: that some of the strongest interlocutors against the Protestant reformers were actually on their side when it came to what is and isn't scripture. They disagreed about a lot of other things vehemently, but that wasn't necessarily one of them.
- 1.88** Eventually, Luther, in the Leipzig Disputation says, "In all of scripture, there is no recollection of purgatory, because the Book of Maccabees, since it is not in the canon, is effective only for the faithful, but not succeed against the stubborn." This is the section of the disputation at Leipzig. This is when Luther is getting himself in trouble with the church. He's pulled over to Leipzig, he's interrogated. He actually thinks it's going to be a debate. He thinks in the spirit of discussion, he's going to be able to plead this case. He basically stands in front and they say, "Denounce these things as heresy or you're in trouble." He's caught off guard. He's questioning some of these things.
- 1.89** Part of that is one of the main issues of the 95 Theses, if you're familiar with it, is the issue of indulgences. During this particular time in the church, there's an understanding that your soul, when it goes into purgatory, this intermediate period before you can go into glory to burn off minor sins, that you can pay the church in order to have either time for you or family members removed from purgatory.
- 1.90** It's very political and very messy at this time because the pope, Pope Leo X, is utilizing this particular doctrine of the church in order to finance the rebuilding of St Peter's Basilica in Rome. It gets very complicated and very messy. Luther is seeing this happening. He's seeing because he's a professor, but he's also a priest in Wittenberg.

And so he's seeing some of his congregants giving everything they have, their life savings, in order to get family members out of purgatory.

- 1.91** He writes these 95 Theses and he says, "If the pope has the ability to remove time off of purgatory or get people out of purgatory, why doesn't he just do it? Jesus died on the cross for us. If the pope has this ability, shouldn't he be as the vicar of Christ, the one who is able to do and want to do this?" He argues in part of this argument, he starts to question purgatory. He starts to question purgatory and he says, "The only proof text that we have for purgatory, as far as an overt statement, is from books like Maccabees." If we look at Maccabees, he says, "It's disputed. Not all of us consider it scripture." On that basis, he says that it's effective only for the faithful, but not succeed against the stubborn.
- 1.92** Now, when he publishes his own Bible, when he translates it into German in 1534, he includes not only the Old Testament, but he also includes a section of the Apocrypha. He's very specific. In the beginning of this, he said, "Apocrypha, that is, books not considered equal to holy scripture, but which are still useful and good to read." This continues to be the theme in a long time in the Protestant Reformation.
- 1.93** Going back to Cajetan, "These books are not canonical, that is, they are not regular for the establishing of the matters of faith. However, they are able to be called canonical, that is regular for the edification of the faithful as able to be received and secured in the canon of the Bible according to this."
- 1.94** Now, what changes? Because this is 1532. Cardinal Cajetan is pretty comfortable saying, "These books are not scripture. There's these other books, they're debated, they're not scripture." How do we go from that to the Catholic Church eventually publishing 73 books and saying, "This is it. No discussion." Well, what changes is between 1532 and 1546, we have the Council of Trent.
- 1.95** The Council of Trent in 1546 kicks off, and it is a Counter-Reformation movement. The Protestant movement is robust. It's growing throughout the [former] Roman Empire. Churches are seeing this, the official churches are seeing this as a threat. They call an ecumenical council. It's very slow and small at first, but then it grows. They actually let the Protestants come. They say, "You guys can come and discuss, but we won't let you vote on anything." Actually, at first, the Protestants were like, "Well, no use in that." Eventually, they do come, but it's a little bit later on.
- 1.96** But one of the first things that is discussed in the Council of Trent in the first year in 1546 is the canon of scripture. In it, it says this, "But if anyone receive not as sacred and canonical, the said books entire with all their parts as they have been used to be read in the Catholic Church and as they are contained in the old Latin Vulgate edition, and knowingly and deliberately condemn the traditions aforesaid, let them be anathema." So though you have councils like the Council of Florence that is previous to this, listing 73 books as authoritative, they never attach an anathema on it.

- 1.97** What is an anathema? Well, it's a formal statement of saying, "You believe this or you go to hell." And so at this point in time at the Council of Trent, though it stands in a long line in a history of the 73 books actually being listed, never before has this very strong delineation been assigned to it.
- 1.98** A number of years ago, 10, 15 years ago, the Vatican actually released a bunch of documents that were written and put together during the time of the Council of Trent. When these things started to go out into the academic community to be read and studied, we have writings from this lesser-known individual, Bonuccio, who is there at the Council of Trent, and he expresses a lot of uncomfortability with this particular statement at Trent. He says, "The council should not try to resolve questions long disputed among reputable theologians." He basically says, "Guys, it's a relevant question. It's a relevant debate. It's one that we can discuss. But by placing an anathema on it, now you're binding the conscience of people who otherwise don't believe this. You're binding the conscience of some pretty influential cardinals within the church at that time."
- 1.99** We have the records in Trent itself of people saying, "We don't really think that this is the right action to take." But the Counter-Reformation is so strongly against the Protestants who, very early on, said, "Listen, we're going to cut out all the chaff. We're going to stick with the core. Everybody agrees on the 66. There's a lot of noise about everything else. When we look at it, we don't think that there's a relevant argument going back into the chain of custody of antiquity for these other books. Therefore, it's the 66 for us."
- 1.100** And so part of the Counter-Reformation movement, very early on, maybe reactionary, maybe that's an overstatement. What they do is that they then push back on the reformers by saying, "You don't think those are scripture. We think they are. And if you don't believe it, you're going to hell." It's a very strong statement with the anathema.
- 1.101** Now, that being said, you still have— this is a King James Bible. You still have—you can see there in the middle— the books of the Apocrypha. Maybe you can't; that's very small. You have the Old Testament books listed, and then you have the books of the Apocrypha listed, and then you have the books of the New Testament listed.
- 1.102** Now, my Bible here today doesn't have that. There's a reason for that, and that is simply because at a certain point, Protestants started to go, "Well, we just want to put the books that we consider scripture in the Bible." Now, is that the right decision or the wrong decision? I don't know. I'm actually fine. I have a number of Bibles that include the Apocrypha, and I'm fine with it because I think it actually gives relevant information towards what is going on there. But at a certain point in time, particularly in the early [19th] century, you see a movement there where Protestant Bibles start to move away from including the Apocrypha between the Old and the New Testament.

- 1.103** Nonetheless, what we see there is we see a long and storied history of the Old Testament canon. We see Jewish information, we see early Christian information, and then we see the later conversations going on throughout the history of the church. But there's a lot of data. There's a lot of data to be sifted out. At the end of it all, what we can say is that there is a relevant conversation that's happening that gives us, at minimum, a core of what we can say the Jews considered scripture, Christians throughout the ages have considered scripture, and at minimum, that core, that center is the 66 books with discussions about how we deal with the other literature and how that factors into the conversation.
- 1.104** But you've been very patient with listening to a lot of information, so thank you very much. Yes.
- 1.105** When thinking about the reliability of scripture, how does that relate to authority? Are those so connected? Are they synonymous? Are they distinct topics?
- 1.106** Yeah. I mean, they're interconnected, though different theological delineations. Canon, in one sense—and I'm going to be talking about this when I get into the second lecture with the New Testament canon; this is a little bit of a spoiler—is that there's a theological canon conversation and a historical canon conversation.
- 1.107** When we talk about the New Testament, one of the things that the early Christians are doing is they're both looking at, at the end of the day, who has an infallible understanding of the canon? God. Because he knows what he has and hasn't inspired. In that, there's a theological conversation about how do we understand something that bears the authority of a "thus sayeth the Lord" statement, or it bears the authority of someone who is being, as Peter says, that men were carried along as they were inspired by the Spirit. The historical one is one that's a little bit easier to tease out because we can actually sift through the data.
- 1.108** The theological one is one that exists more on theless of a historical conversation. But authority is still relevant because, at the end of the day, canon is a recognition of authority. We want to recognize that which bears the authority of what we believe comes from God, which is what the Jews and the Christians were doing. So, we want to make sure we're not recognizing something that doesn't have the authority and therefore inappropriately or heretically including that.
- 1.109** This gets teased out a little bit more, and we'll get into it with the New Testament, when you have documents that are being written and erroneously being ascribed to apostles. They need to tease that out a little bit more and do their homework and say, "How do we tie this to either someone who knew Jesus or someone who knew someone who knew Jesus?"
- 1.110** When we're looking at the canonical criteria, are there other forms that you didn't use that you would give credence to?

- 1.111** I didn't talk too much on the language conversation. I just said this is a secondary conversation. It is relevant in terms of the historical time frame. If you have documents that have no Hebrew progenitors or appear to be written in Greek specifically, then that puts them in a category of a time frame where the Jews themselves were saying, "We don't have any scripture written here."
- 1.112** That becomes a very relevant conversation that some people give weight to, other people not so much. But this is especially relevant when you talk about the Enochian literature. We have no Hebrew copies of the Enochian books. They exist in Aramaic and in Greek and in Coptic and in fragmentary sections. That is a secondary criterion. But the main criteria were the ones that I outlined and which were discussed far more.
- 1.113** Now, I didn't touch as much on, say, what Augustine capitalized on, where he says church reception—if we all agree the catholicity of the conversation, kata, meaning "concerning," and holos meaning "the whole" in Greek. Catholic simply means universal. If we can find more people than not saying Maccabees is scripture, then the church recognizes that as scripture. Now, that bears weight with some people and absolutely no weight with others.
- 1.114** When you get to the Protestant Reformation, they reject that outright and say, it's less about an argument from numbers and more about an argument from antiquity and that God gave these particular documents to the Jews. Now, wrapped up in that is an implicit anti-Semitism which develops within the Middle Ages, too. So not everybody is even seeing that as a relevant argument. Why be on the side of the people who crucified Christ?
- 1.115** But when we look at individuals like Jerome, he's very interested in that conversation. He's very interested in the languages and in what the Jews are actually saying is scripture. He reports that he, at one point, even goes back to Jerusalem and he discusses with the rabbis to see, "What are you considering scripture?" Now, he eventually does include those books in the Latin Vulgate, but there's some complications with that because he appears to have been at least coerced to some degree by the pope, the bishop of Rome, to do so.

Lecture 2: New Testament Canon

At a glance — The New Testament canon.

- 2.1 Okay, so we've run through the Old Testament. Now let's talk about the New Testament, because once again, we have this problem: 66 books written over a period of 1,600 years on three different continents by close to 40 different authors in three different languages. But part of that collection is the books that are the ones that follow what we were talking about just previously. These are the ones that are exclusively written in Greek. While you have Old Testament writings that are in Hebrew and some sections in Aramaic, the New Testament is exclusively in Greek.
- 2.2 Now, part of this conversation that I want to flesh out is not just the process by which the New Testament authors were recognized and how the early church composed what we eventually come up with as the 27-book catalog of the New Testament, but also the fact that there are other writings that come in the time frame after Jesus that are capitalized on in modern society quite a bit. Over the last couple of decades, we've seen an increase in people saying things like, "I want a new version of Christianity, and the way I'm going to get there is by actually changing the books in the Bible."
- 2.3 A case in point is the scholarly piece of work, sometimes known as The Da Vinci Code. Now, you might be thinking it's a piece of something. Scholarly might not be the preface of the term. But The Da Vinci Code capitalizes on this particular motif—that you have other books.
- 2.4 There was a documentary done by the BBC a number of years ago that had the narrator say things like, "Well, when I was growing up, if I had read the Gospel of Peter and the Gospel of Thomas and the Gospel of Mary and the Gospel of Judas, I would have a very different picture of Jesus today. If the Gospel of Judas had won out, I might think that he wasn't the bad guy. If the Gospel of Peter had won out, I might not even think that Jesus was crucified at all. If I saw that the Gospel of Mary won out, then maybe we'd be hailing Mary as the first pope, not Peter."
- 2.5 I want to address that, but I want to address the fact within the context of the early Christians also seeing some of these other pieces of literature and how they sifted through them.
- 2.6 Ariel Sabar, a reporter for The Atlantic, in an article in 2016 said, "After Constantine converted the Roman Empire to Christianity in the fourth century and church leaders began canonizing the small selection of texts that formed the New Testament, Christians with other views were branded as heretics."
- 2.7 Now, there's some truth in that, but not entirely. Constantine did not convert the Roman Empire to Christianity. He converted eventually, if we're taking the early reports at face value. But it was actually [Theodosius], after him, a different Roman Emperor,

who made Christianity the official religion of Rome. It was true that Christians were canonizing small selections of texts, but by the Council of Nicaea in 325, by the time of Constantine, that conversation was almost exclusively over with.

- 2.8** In fact, the issues of the Council of Nicaea, when they assemble to address theological divisions, both the side that they're arguing against—with an individual named Arius, who's a North African preacher—and then the other side are using scripture as their defining source. It's not that someone is coming and saying, "Actually, the Gospel of Thomas says this." At that point, the Gnostic literature had its heyday and was dying out.
- 2.9** The Gnosticism of the second and third centuries was almost completely gone. It was never really that big to begin with. But by the fourth century, you have these theological disputes at this first council, this first ecumenical council in 325. But they're using, utilizing, and referencing scripture as their authority. They're just disagreeing on interpretation. Once again, talking about our definitions: canon being our rule and list, and apocrypha being that which is doubtful, obscure, or secret.
- 2.10** As we go further on, I want to take us back to a particular date and a particular place, specifically 1945 in Egypt with a character named Muhammad Ali. Now, our Muhammad Ali, the boxer, wasn't doing much in 1945. But in 1945, you have a traditional story of a couple of Bedouin farmers led by this individual named Muhammad Ali, who go out into the Nag Hammadi region of Egypt, and they're looking for what is essentially fertilizer.
- 2.11** At this period of time, it's actually related to the fact that since the cotton industry collapsed with slavery emancipation in the United States, cotton in Egypt boomed. During that time of the Emancipation Proclamation and the downward trend in the sale of American cotton, Egyptian cotton became in high demand.
- 2.12** Farmers were now in need of increasing their yield. What they would do is they would go out into the desert, and they would dig up a particular form of fertilizer, which is called sebak, which is really the remains of ancient cities. As the cities get buried and squished, the phosphorus and the different chemical compounds that remain in them are used as fertilizer.
- 2.13** Muhammad Ali and his group go out into the desert. They're digging, they're looking for fertilizer. But what they find is a jar. They find a very large earthenware jar. The traditional story is that they have a disagreement about whether they should break it open because some of the group think it could be full of gold, but some other individuals in the group think there could be a genie in it who will curse them. Apparently, this was a true story.
- 2.14** They take it back to their city or their town, a place not that far from the Nag Hammadi desert named al-Qasr. They eventually do break it open. No genie, no gold. It's just full

of books. It's full of scrolls. It's full of documents from an ancient group who had buried them there.

- 2.15** Part of the story is that they use some of these documents—they burn them to cook bread. Others are thrown into a stable where they're used to pad the goat excrement. Some of these have simply been lost. But what eventually is categorized from these pieces of literature is what we now know as the Nag Hammadi Library.
- 2.16** This story really didn't make any waves in 1945. There was a lot more going on in Nazi Germany. World War II had just ended, and there were many things that were happening in Europe and the Pacific theater. Not many people were paying attention to a [farmer] in the backwaters of Egypt.
- 2.17** But eventually, these documents get into the hands of antiquity dealers and then into academics, and they start to—when they're sifted through—find writings that we actually knew by name from early Christians but didn't have documentation for. Chief of which, the most famous one of the Nag Hammadi Library is the Gospel of Thomas. I'll go into a little bit of detail about the Gospel of Thomas. But what this started to do is it started to bring up questions about the canonicity of the New Testament.
- 2.18** If you have other writings that have the names of individuals like Thomas or Mary or Judas or Philip—what does that do? How do we then parse out what should be considered the Bible and what shouldn't? How do we find the actual credible source information for someone like Jesus of Nazareth?
- 2.19** As I said before, this question of canon has both a theological and a historical sifting out. Within the New Testament itself, we see language of deliverance and redemption. In places like John 1:41, it says that in that time, the Second Temple period, when Jesus is living, it says specifically they're looking for the Messiah. There was an expectation that this individual, who was predicted in the Old Testament, was going to come and rescue God's people. That timing was imminent. Luke 2:38 talks about the redemption of Jerusalem being close. Luke 2:25 about the consolation of Israel. And Acts 1:6 refers to this time period as the restoration of the kingdom. In other words, the Jews within early Christianity did not view the story of the Old Testament as complete.
- 2.20** N. T. Wright, the New Testament scholar and theologian, puts it this way. He says, "The great story of the Hebrew scriptures was therefore inevitably read in the Second Temple period as a story in search of a conclusion."
- 2.21** Though you have these statements by individuals like Philo and Josephus about what the canon is, that doesn't then preclude there being more, because there was going to be this time when the Messiah, the anointed one, the Mashiach, was going to come. In that time, the expectation was that there would be some documenting of that.
- 2.22** First-century Judaism, as well as early Christianity, as I said before, was covenantal. When looking at the writings leading up to the first century, an interpretation of what

can be referred to as covenantal categories is seen very strongly. The Jewish people understood the actions of God through the lens of his historic covenant promises.

- 2.23 What's interesting is that when we get to the earliest Christian communities and the writings, this theological covenantal mind frame crosses over. New Testament scholar Michael Kruger puts it this way: "The acts of Jesus circulating in the kerygma"—that's just a term that refers to the oral Jesus stories—"and recorded in the gospels were framed in the context of Jesus bringing with him a new covenant." The Last Supper was understood as a covenantal meal, as Jesus describes. Zechariah understood the coming of his son, John the Baptist, as the fulfilling of God's covenant and the coming Messiah, in Luke 1.
- 2.24 Paul describes the ministry of the apostles as being ministers of the new covenant in 2 Corinthians 3, alluding to the making of a new covenant with his people that I referred to previously in Jeremiah 31:31 and so on. There are many examples of this in the text of the New Testament that we can read.
- 2.25 The Old Testament idea of covenant was linked with the written text representing the terms and arrangements of that covenantal promise. Therefore, the early Christians themselves were immersed in covenantal structure and mind frame. And so because of that, it's not hard to imagine that the new covenant, the new promise that was established and understood through Jesus, also was received with written texts. These Christians, by virtue of their Jewish heritage, would have naturally seen the promises manifested in conjunction with written scriptural books.
- 2.26 So in other words, they understood: the promises of God, written text. Jesus is said to have established a new covenant. And so the organic question is, where are the books? Where are the books that codify the covenant? It wasn't necessarily a question in response to something as much as it would have been a much more organic, much more natural, much more grassroots establishment of "We're Jews, the Messiah has come, covenants are followed by written text."
- 2.27 We even have some statements in the Old Testament of prophets being given a word from God, and he says, "Write this on a scroll, inscribe this on a tablet." And so they simply go, "Where are the books?"
- 2.28 Early Christians, when discussing this, particularly the gospels, are not confused about what is and isn't in view. Irenaeus in the second century says, "But it is not possible that the gospels can either be more or fewer in number than they are, for since there are four zones of the world in which we live, and four principal winds, and the cherubim, too, were four-faced."
- 2.29 Now, let's be honest, this is a weird argument. But this is an argument that in the ancient world holds weight. Like I said before, when you had the Jews arguing for 22 books because of the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet, the understanding is still that numbers are significant. And so individuals like Irenaeus and others look for fours

throughout the Old Testament, and they see that four has an influential connection. And so in the argument of someone like Irenaeus, when he's arguing against groups like the Gnostics, he's saying, "Listen, guys, there can only be four because we see this number four being influential."

- 2.30 What are the gospels that Irenaeus names? He names and refers to and quotes Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, those books that are associated with those early Jesus community writers.
- 2.31 A contemporary of Irenaeus, a guy named Theophilus, writes this: "Concerning the righteousness which the law enjoined, confirmatory utterances are found both with the prophets and in the gospels because they all spoke inspired by one spirit of God." This is a very strong statement. It's a strong statement because he is ascribing the same level of inspiration when a prophet stands up saying "thus sayeth the Lord" statement to the gospel authors. Now, of course, there's a different prescription in understanding of inspiration. The gospel authors are not being given a more divine dictation message like the prophets were. But the connective tissue is still inspiration, that which comes from God and holds divine authority to bind the believer in a message that actually has some divine authority.
- 2.32 What are the gospels that Theophilus names? He names Matthew, Mark, Luke, and Thomas. Just kidding. He names John. Now, I say that as a bit of a joke, but also, it's very interesting because we have a number of these lists.
- 2.33 Nobody confuses that. We never get one list where someone says, "Matthew, Mark, Luke, and Thomas, or Matthew, Judas, Luke, and John." There's never another thrown into the mix. The Christians were very clear, very early on, when we're talking about the biographical material that goes back to Jesus, this is it. End of story.
- 2.34 Part of the reason for that was that they had a chain of custody, that they knew who the disciples of Jesus were, and there were individuals who were said to have been trained under the disciples, disciples of the disciples themselves. And so when you talk to individuals in the early church, the reason why they're not confused is they're saying, "This is what was handed to us. This is what was given to us as that which was handed down by the apostles themselves."
- 2.35 When Jesus is said to have appeared to his disciples after his resurrection, he breathes on them, and he gives them the spirit, there's an understanding that they then possess authority that is given to them by Jesus. And so their testimony and witness of that is then that which is codified in the New Testament gospels.
- 2.36 Other ancient Christian writers, Clement, Origen, and a very important writing called the Muratorian Fragment, which comes from the second century, which is another one of our early canon lists, all are very clear and say things like, "There are four and only four gospels under heaven."

- 2.37** There are only four canonical gospels alone and unquestionable under the heavens. This is pretty overt. New Testament scholar F. F. Bruce put it this way. He said, "One thing must be emphatically stated. The New Testament books did not become authoritative for the church because they were formally included in a canonical list. On the contrary, the church included them because she already regarded them as divinely inspired, recognized their innate worth and general apostolic authority, direct or indirect." There's this line of succession of the recognizing of the books within this early church period. They're not confused about what that is.
- 2.38** And though there are some discussions about other books—I'll mention those in a minute—the gospels, the fourfold gospel canon: Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John—and the letters of Paul, respectively, are not argued about in the early Christian communities. In fact, they're referenced as that which is inspired. There are some questions about others, but the whole point of this is saying there's this recognizing that is going on when they're saying, "What are the books that ratify the covenant?" It's particularly and specifically the fourfold gospel canon and things like the writings of the apostle Paul.
- 2.39** At the exact same time, like I said, there does need to be some criteria that is fleshed out in order to differentiate from something like the Gospel of Thomas and the Gospel of John. The way that they did that was that they had three basic criteria. Apostolicity, does it come from an apostle or someone who knew an apostle? Orthodoxy, does it represent right teaching and/or is there embellishment? And Catholicity, is it accepted in the universal church?
- 2.40** When we look across the broad spectrum of Christianity—which is not actually that big at this point in time—do we see these particular things outlined? First and foremost is that apostolicity reigns supreme. The early Christians were very concerned: "Can we tie it to someone who knows Jesus or someone who knows someone who knows Jesus?" If we can't, whether it is even Orthodox or Catholic, then it's out.
- 2.41** J. I. Packer, theologian and cleric, said it this way: "The church no more gave us the New Testament canon than Sir Isaac Newton gave us the force of gravity. Newton did not create gravity, but recognized it." So, saying the church gave you your Bible is like saying the letter carrier gave you your mail.
- 2.42** It's true. He did, right? But in one sense, the truth of it doesn't necessarily mean that the mail carrier is the progenitor of the mail, the originator of the mail, because the letters you receive were written prior to and maybe even despite who the particular man or woman that is carrying your mail is. The same understanding can be applied, I think, to the New Testament.
- 2.43** Yes, the church is not insignificant in this time period in the conversation. It's very significant. At the exact same time, what they were trying to do was to boil down inspiration. They would say, "This is not an inspired list of books." They would say, "This

is a list of inspired books." In one sense, and this is the historic Protestant position, what the canon of scripture is, is a fallible list of infallible books.

- 2.44** In the same way that when Moses comes down from Mount Sinai, Moses is a fallible individual, and yet he is given infallible communication from God on Mount Sinai. That doesn't mean that he's wrong. That doesn't mean that he's untrustworthy. But Moses was fallible. He was not an infallible individual. But when he communicates the law that is imparted to him by God, and he lays out that to God's people, that message is infallible.
- 2.45** The early church is not infallible, creating an infallible rule of this. My index, my table of contents, isn't inspired, but the books that are listed in my table of contents are inspired. I don't think it's a problem to say, and I don't think the early church was wrong in a perspective of saying this is a fallible list of infallible books because they are recognizing that which is infallible.
- 2.46** Were there any of the other books in these conversations that almost made it? The answer is yes, there were. I'm going to go through a few of those that are both in contention and in discussion—as in, we're discussing these because we know that these have no level of reliability. The number one and two contenders of books that may very well have made it into the New Testament in this early church period are ones you may have never heard of. It's not the Gospel of Thomas, the Gospel of Peter, or the Gospel of Judas. It's a letter called The Shepherd of Hermas and the Epistle of Barnabas. Now, not to be confused with the Gospel of Barnabas, which comes from the Middle Ages and is an out-and-out forgery, but the Epistle of Barnabas.
- 2.47** These are two books that are very early, have early attestation, and are very popular. Now, I mentioned the Muratorian Fragment before. The Muratorian Fragment is one of our earliest canon lists. In fact, in its canon, it names 22 of the 27 books of the New Testament as, without debate, scripture. But then it comments on Hermas. It comments on the Shepherd. It says, "But Hermas wrote the Shepherd very recently in our time in the city of Rome, while Bishop Pius, his brother, was occupying the chair of the church in the city."
- 2.48** What's going on here? Well, if we're looking for the gold standard of someone who knew Jesus, or someone who knew someone who knew Jesus, the Muratorian Fragment writes and says, "We know this guy. We know who the author is. He's around right now in the second century, and we know who his family is. We know his brother is the Bishop of Rome." In that sense, it fails the major criteria of apostolicity. Even though very popular, even though very edifying, encouraging for the early Christian community, it doesn't have anything that's overtly heretical, they say it doesn't have that tie into the earliest Jesus community, and so they remove it from being a major contender.

- 2.49** The second is also true, the Epistle of Barnabas. But the problem with the Epistle of Barnabas is that you have early Christians looking at this and they say, "Okay, we have these conversations." This early church writer Eusebius says that this other guy, Clemens, might have thought that the Barnabas that the letter was named after might be the companion of Paul mentioned in the book of Acts, but he can't be sure.
- 2.50** And while there is direct connection of individuals saying, "Listen, I studied under the apostle John. He wrote the Gospel of John." Where you have this far-flung ambiguity, the early Christians are looking at that and they're saying, "We can't be sure of this. There's no strong connection about who this is." This Barnabas character that's tied with the authorship of this is anonymous.
- 2.51** And so though it is very popular, though it is orthodox, the early Christian community says, "There is not the reliability, there's not the chain of custody, there's not the provenance that we can tie reliably." And so, therefore, we do not recognize it as having the same level of authority.
- 2.52** But those are really the only two that are genuinely in contention. All the others are a little bit more out there, but let's talk about them. The Gospel of Thomas. The Gospel of Thomas is not a gospel in the way that you might think of it. There is no birth, life, death, resurrection narrative. The Gospel of Thomas is a sayings document. It's 114 sayings of conversations back and forth between Jesus and his disciples, specifically with Thomas as the key and special disciple.
- 2.53** This is something that's important to understand when we're talking about Gnostic literature. The Gnostics were not a unified group, and I'll explain what I mean by Gnostic. But sometimes we hear about the Gnostics. The Gnostics is an umbrella term that categorizes different groups at different times, and they disagree with one another.
- 2.54** If we look at their particular preference literature, if the Gospel of Thomas is true, the Gospel of Philip is problematic because either Thomas was Jesus's special guy who he whispered all the secret sayings to, or Philip was. But those two documents are pushing back on one another as to who the key figure in the early Jesus community was. It's always in juxtaposition to what the canonical gospels say with individuals like Peter, James, and John being the core. It's always in contention to that.
- 2.55** So not a gospel in the narrative format, and it's a list of 114 sayings. It also has this Gnostic flavor to it that I mentioned. So what is that? Well, in historic biblical Christianity, salvation is something that is done for us, external to us, based on the finished work of Christ. According to the Gnostics, salvation is not something outside of you, it's something inside of you. It's not just that Jesus is divine, you're divine, and you have to unlock that divinity and become enlightened via secret knowledge—the Greek word for knowledge being *gnosis*, which gives them their category title. That's why we refer to them as Gnostics, because despite a lot of their disagreements, they all have

this idea that there's a spark of divinity in each of us. We unlock that divinity by the secret knowledge.

- 2.56** That's what Jesus is doing. Jesus's ministry in the gospels is very public. Jesus's ministry in the Gnostic literature is very private. It's very secretive. He's whispering little sayings and things. Some of it is almost incomprehensible. If you read something like the Gospel of Philip, and I would encourage you to go out, read some of this stuff, and you're scratching your head and going, "I have no idea what's being said," that's on purpose. Because the idea is, if you were enlightened, you'd get it.
- 2.57** There's almost these contradictory statements, these weird things that are being said in the Gnostic gospel literature. The point of that is, if you understood it, you would be the enlightened one. Because you don't understand it, you haven't got there yet.
- 2.58** But this idea, this philosophical system, only comes into its fruition in including Jesus in the second century. It comes from the east. It's encompassing different Zoroastrian and maybe even some esoteric Eastern ideas from India. But it comes, and as it moves, it's by osmosis collecting individuals that fit into its system. Jesus becomes just the number one of these individuals that fits into the Gnostic system.
- 2.59** But it is almost exclusively a second-century development. Any time we find a Gnostic flavor, it's a pretty good indication that this is coming too late, that we can pinpoint it to a time frame where the people who are being talked about—Peter, Mary, Judas, James, Jesus— are dead and have been dead for a while. In one sense, it's appropriating them.
- 2.60** In the titling, you'll notice—and we'll talk about this a little later in the week when I talk about the historic Jesus—but the gospels themselves, if you were to take off the title on the biblical gospels, the gospel according to blank, you may not know who that author is. This is what we call formal anonymity. Because the gospel authors from the biblical accounts are not trying to shoehorn authority in by saying, "I'm Peter, I'm the guy, I'm the guy who Jesus really likes." No, the purpose is to talk about Jesus.
- 2.61** Whereas when you read some of these Gnostic gospels, they're very clear. The Gospel of Peter, at the very beginning and the very end, says, "Hey, I'm Peter. I'm not Peter. I'm the Peter thinking about, Don't forget I'm Peter." Because it's trying to incorporate a credibility that it doesn't have.
- 2.62** Interestingly enough, we find the opposite in the biblical gospels. They're not trying to really convince you of who they are. They're letting the evidence of who Jesus is, his teachings, and the historical information that it's including speak for itself. But the Gospel of Thomas and some of this other gospel literature also has certain components to it that are very problematic in terms of early Christian teaching.
- 2.63** Let me share with you the last line of the Gospel of Thomas, Logion 114. "Simon Peter said to him, 'Let Mary leave us, for women are not worthy of life.'" — we're on a good

start — "Jesus said, 'I myself shall lead her in order to make her male, so that she too may become a living spirit resembling you males. For every woman who will make herself male will enter the kingdom of heaven.'" Amen. Let's pray, right?

- 2.64** The early Christians are reading this stuff and they're going, "No, we know that doesn't make sense. We have the information that was passed down to us from the apostles. It ain't that." They're very clear on this.
- 2.65** In fact, time and time again, in the Gnostic literature, it's interesting that Jesus doesn't appear almost at all like a Jewish rabbi. He sounds like a pagan mystic. Now, what's more likely: that the first-century Galilean Nazarene individual named Jesus of Nazareth was a pagan that later individuals tried to make into a Jewish rabbi? Or that Jesus, based on geography and time frame and cultural understanding, was a Jewish rabbi whom later individuals, to make him sound more palatable for a Gentile audience, turned him into a pagan mystic? Well, I think it should be obvious.
- 2.66** It's the latter. Because that was more palatable. It's easier to make him sound like a mystic, make him sound like a pagan, and have people who are steeped in things like Platonic thought and maybe even some of these undercurrents of Gnosticism. That's easier to swallow. But the early church looked at stuff like this and they said, "No, we're not going along with that."
- 2.67** Now, let's also talk about the Gospel of Peter, because the Gospel of Peter, unlike the Gospel of Thomas, is a document that has more of a narrative to it. What's interesting about the Gospel of Peter is the Gospel of Peter seems to be trying to remedy issues that it sees the gospels in the Bible having.
- 2.68** One of these is that the gospels in the Bible, the canonical four, do not actually tell you what the resurrection looked like. Everybody shows up after the fact. The first people to show up are women. Now, women in the ancient world were not deemed as very reliable witnesses. So the Gospel of Peter appears at face value to have a problem with this, even though— and this is the pushback on that line of argumentation—it would have been the women who would have gone to the tomb to deal with the body. That's true. It would have been the women. But why do the canonical gospels specifically outline that the women are the first eyewitnesses if it wasn't true, given that they were not deemed reliable eyewitnesses in either a Greco-Roman or an ancient Jewish, unfortunately, cultural context?
- 2.69** Well, the Gospel of Peter seems to have an issue with this. So, instead, not only does it have the camera rolling on the resurrection, but it has all the right people in the right place. It has Jewish and Roman officials camping out in front of the tomb.
- 2.70** Now, there are a host of, a range of issues with this, chief of which is that the high priest on the eve of Passover is not going to be camping out in front of a dead body. This shows a complete ignorance of Jewish ritual and ceremonial cleanliness customs. But it's trying to say, "We have the right people. The right people are here." And so the

stone rolls away, Jesus comes out, and Jesus is gigantic. Jesus is like head in the cloud, super Jesus. Then the cross comes out of the tomb. They don't tell you how the cross gets in the tomb, but the cross comes out of the tomb and the cross, the floating cross, is following Jesus, and it's talking, it's prophesying about what Jesus will do.

- 2.71** Now, I don't need to be too obtuse in saying that this is embellishment. It's embellishment, but there's also a specific reason that Jesus is this 90-foot-tall super Jesus coming out of the tomb. That's because the Gospel of Peter is a docetic document.
- 2.72** Docetism was a form of ancient Gnostic thought that denied that the physical body had any redeemable qualities to it. Following ancient Platonic philosophy, there was a dualism that existed. The physical is bad, and the spiritual is good. This is why, if you read the book of Acts, when Paul is preaching on Mars Hill at the Areopagus, the Jewish philosopher—or, sorry, the Greek philosophers are actually tracking with them to a certain point until he drops the word *anastasis*, resurrection. And then they go, "We're out." Because the idea of coming back in a physical body is nonsense if you believe that the physical body is evil. The whole point is to get out of this meat prison that your spirit, which is the good part of you, is trapped in.
- 2.73** This was swallowed hook, line, and sinker by individuals like certain Gnostics who were Docetists. They had no problem with Jesus being God. They were like, "We're on board." They had a problem with Jesus being a man. They denied the incarnation fundamentally because Jesus can be divine, but he can't be physical.
- 2.74** In the passion narrative of the Gospel of Peter, Jesus is okay on the cross because he's not really there to begin with. He's not really being crucified. He's just being—He's appearing to. The Greek word *dokein*, from which we get the word docetism, means "to seem." He's not really there. He's just seeming to be there.
- 2.75** We see a number of things from the ignorance of Jewish culture, trying to remedy issues that shouldn't be remedied to begin with, and this Gnostic, Platonic, docetic idea that the early church looks at this and they have very little problem saying it's not scripture. It fails the criteria.
- 2.76** Not only that, but we can also look at the manuscript evidence. Now, we do need to have a caveat to this. This is not a slam dunk, but I think we can say that we have 60 manuscripts in whole or in part from the second or third centuries of the gospels. So 12 copies from Matthew, 18 copies from John. Those were easily the most popular in the ancient world. Some of these are almost 2,000 years old, so the fact that we have any of these is pretty phenomenal, with honorable mention going to documents like Luke and Acts, and Revelation and Hebrews. We can see that these copies are quite numerous in the ancient world, and they're very widespread.
- 2.77** The disclaimer to this is that counting the number of manuscripts is not a total bulletproof argument. The number of manuscripts doesn't mean in total and definitive

ways that these books were in and that others were not. There are books that were viewed as canonical that we have very few manuscripts for. An example of that would be Mark. But as a whole, looking at manuscript remains does give us a picture as to how Christians viewed these books. What this all shows is that early Christians were prolific producers of texts, and they valued these.

- 2.78** In comparison, where you have 60 manuscripts, in whole or in part, from the second or third centuries of the 27 books of the New Testament, we only have 17 manuscripts in whole or in part from the second to the fourth century of any Gnostic document, the most popular being the Gospel of Thomas and the Gospel of Mary, Gospel of Peter and the Protoevangelium of James.
- 2.79** However, Thomas, we have three fragments in Greek from Oxyrhynchus, Egypt, and then we have the Nag Hammadi one, and that is the most numerous one by far. Three small fragments of the text in Greek, one whole copy in Coptic, and that's it. Then we have two of Mary and one of Peter.
- 2.80** These were not numerous. We need to not overstate our case when we pit the Gnostics as the people against the early Christians because they were pocketed, they were geographically located. And though the Christians are rebutting them because they're spreading false things about who Jesus and the apostles were, they're not overly popular across the ancient world.
- 2.81** At the exact same time, because there were these letters floating around, that's why we have some conversations about some other documents. I mentioned the Muratorian Fragment has 22 of the 27 books. The reason why some of those other books were held off on for a little bit longer, books like 1, 2, 3 John, 1, 2 Peter, James, and Jude, is because you had so many books floating around associated with those individuals.
- 2.82** If you have an Acts of Peter, and an Apocalypse of Peter, and a Gospel of Peter, and then two letters, 1, 2 Peter, the early Christians are going, " We actually need to make sure we know what Peter wrote. Let's do the homework to try to follow the paper trail back to Peter." That's what they do. That's why it takes a little bit longer for the dust to settle on some of these other books. Not because they were rejected and then there was a vote or something at some council or some group, but because the early Christians were trying to do their due diligence. They want to know if Jude wrote Jude. They want to know if James wrote James. They want to know if John can be tied to 1, 2, and 3 John. This is three letters. And so that's what they do.
- 2.83** The New Testament scholar Larry Hurtado put it this way, "The low number of apocryphal manuscripts do not justify any notion that these writings were particularly in favor and that whatever circles used these writings were likely a clear minority among Christians in the second and third centuries." Like I said before, something like

the Gospel of Thomas, we only have four fragmentary pieces of evidence for it as an actual document.

2.84 And we see a development even in the fragments of the Greek text from Oxyrhynchus leading up to the Coptic version in the fourth century in a way that we don't see with the other manuscripts—I'll talk about this when we talk about the text of the New Testament. When we look at the text of the fragments from Oxyrhynchus that are in Greek, and then we compare that with the sections that are relevantly connected in the Nag Hammadi library, we see a textual development. We see a drift in the things that are growing in the text. We can go across the board with all of the Gnostic gospels, the Gnostic literature.

2.85 Whereas the 27 books of the New Testament, I would argue, sit pretty comfortably within the first century. When we're talking about the Gospel of Peter, the Gospel of Mary, the Gospel of Judas, what we're talking about are documents that were written after those individuals were dead and are appropriating the names of those individuals in order to put sayings on the lips of Jesus that he did not say.

2.86 So, those nonbiblical gospels fail because not only can we not connect the internal evidence like that of named correspondence, but we know that they're written in times when the falsely attributed names on them, when Mary, when Peter, when Judas, when Thomas, were long dead. Then the question is, what are the only books that have the credibility? Unsurprisingly, it's Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. Pretty much full stop. We'll talk a little bit more about internal criteria a little bit later and the witness of the biographical material for the historical Jesus.

2.87 But I'm going to circle back because I mentioned a BBC documentary where the narrator in the documentary said things like, "If the Gospel of Mary had won out, this is the way that I would have understood Jesus, or if the Gospel of Philip had won out, this is the way that I would have understood Jesus." I actually think he's right. I think he's right. If we had those other books in our Bible, we would have a very different picture of Jesus. If the list looked more like Matthew, Thomas, Peter, and Judas, then Christianity today would look very different.

2.88 But that's the wrong question. Let me illustrate why that's the wrong question by telling you a parable. It's a parable, although it's a true story, about a platoon of American soldiers in, I believe it was 2011, in Afghanistan.

2.89 One day in Afghanistan, the small troop of American soldiers found themselves involved in an exchange of gunfire with a small group of Afghans. The skirmish goes on for days. It's a gun battle with seemingly no end as each side keeps firing shots at each other in the other direction. However, the group on the Afghani side are not Taliban. So, the American soldiers are actually not entirely sure why they are being shot at.

2.90 Finally, the lieutenant in charge has an idea. He says, "Why don't we just ask them? Why don't we just ask them why they're shooting at us?" So he signals a ceasefire, and

when the shooting stops, he slowly walks over to the Afghans and asks, "Why are you shooting at us?" And they say, "Well, you're on our land, and you're not paying rent." He says, "Okay, that's fine. We'll pay rent." And so the Afghans say, "Great. I'm glad we got that sorted. However, there's another group over there. And when we stop shooting at you, they're going to start because they also think you're on their land and they want you to pay rent."

- 2.91** So, the lieutenant asks, "Are they able to tell them if there's an area that nobody thinks is theirs that they won't have to pay rent for?" The Afghans point to a place 180 meters away, 600 feet. The Americans, the squad, pick up their equipment, move 600 feet to the left, and the shooting stops. That was all it took. It's the smallest move that results in a surprisingly big gain.
- 2.92** The question is not whether there were alternative books that told alternative stories of Jesus. There are. They're quite numerous, quite diverse. The question is, what are the only books that give us an accurate picture of going to the early Jesus community? That's what I, as a historian, want to know. If I'm trying to figure out who these early Christian people are, who this guy Jesus is, I'm going to go to the source material that ties me in the closest time frame to Jesus. I'm going to want to look at source material that ideally is early and eyewitness.
- 2.93** So, when we hear about Gospels of Thomas and Judas and Peter and Mary, we don't actually need to know all that much about those actual documents. It's maybe good to know some of the source material to say when Thomas says, "Every woman who makes herself male will enter the kingdom of heaven," that that's a little bit ridiculous.
- 2.94** At the exact same time, sometimes all we need to do is pick up our camp and move 600 feet to the left and say, "What are the books that get us closest to the time frame of Jesus? What are the books that get me to someone who knew Jesus or someone who knew someone who knew Jesus?"
- 2.95** Very clearly, when we look at the early testimony of who Jesus was and who the community that was closest to him were and where the source material, the literature for that particular fact, comes from, we get the 27 books that we call the New Testament, particularly the gospels, the biographies of Jesus, Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, who are associated with the eyewitness community—Matthew being a disciple, John being a disciple, Mark being closely tied to Peter, and Luke being closely tied to Paul. That's what we, as historians, ought to be doing, even in spite of the diversity of literature and the assumed names of individuals who are appropriating the names of apostles and close figures of Jesus. Thank you.
- 2.96** How was the order of the books determined?
- 2.97** Yeah, very good question. The order of the books, it's interesting. Very early on, you have the canonical list breaking down into the way that we have it today: Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. And one reason for that is because the early church appears to

almost unanimously think that Matthew was written first. There are various reasons for that, but by the time you get to Augustine, he's very clear in saying, Matthew wrote. Then Mark was a shorter version; it was a paraphrase of Matthew. And then Luke and then John.

- 2.98** We actually get the books of the New Testament ordered differently when we start to see them put all in one single document. There are various reasons for that. But by the Middle Ages, you have the list that we have in our New Testament today solidified as the way that people are doing it, mostly because what they did is they grouped the gospels and then Acts, which is the follow-up.
- 2.99** Interestingly enough, Luke and Acts are written by the same author, or at least claimed to be written by the same author. They're probably understood within their earliest period as one single document, so like part one and part two. But you can only fit functionally so much text on a scroll. The upper limits of what can functionally be put on a text or be put on a scroll in the form of text reach their zenith if you put all of that on— I think, if I'm remembering correctly, Luke is like 22 feet and Acts is 24 feet. You can't go longer than that. One of the reasons why it's probably split up into two is simply because of form and function. It's just not reasonable to extend those longer.
- 2.100** But the gospels are grouped together very early. Though these documents floated around independently, we do have some early collections in the late second century. We have two documents. They're referred to as Papyrus 46 and Papyrus 45. One is a collection of the gospels all in one unit, and the other is a collection of— it would have included, we think, all of the Pauline letters in one unit.
- 2.101** Now, some of it is missing. Interestingly enough, that unit includes Hebrews, which is the only anonymous book in the New Testament. But whoever put together that particular grouping associated—which wasn't uncommon— associated Hebrews with Paul.
- 2.102** But you get the groupings of the gospels and then the Pauline epistles, and then what I refer to as the Catholic epistles: Peter, John, Jude, James, and then Revelation. Though they're sometimes put in different orders, the vast majority of the time, we see them falling in the numbering system that we find in Bibles today. Revelation is always last.
- 2.103** Where would you put Revelation in terms of dating? Because I know there's— especially in the Reformed community—there's some who date it early. I was just wondering where you put the dating.
- 2.104** Dating is tricky because none of the books of the New Testament come with formal dates. Sometimes we find in the ancient world that things will actually be dated. That's not true for any of the New Testament documents. Where we are hypothesizing about where they fall in the spectrum of the first century is, to some degree or another, an estimated guess.

- 2.105** Now, it is a good estimation on the whole, but I think the question is always, does it fall before 70 AD or after 70 AD? The reason for that is that you have the Jewish-Roman Wars, where at a certain point in time after Jesus, in around 66 AD, the Romans are sick of the Jews uprising. They go in, and they fight a number of battles.
- 2.106** Then eventually in 70 AD, Vespasian and Titus march into Jerusalem, sack it, and destroy the temple. The question is—this is a pretty clear marker on the timeline—is something falling before 70 AD or after 70 AD? Part of that question is, do the documents that we're looking at seem to be aware of this particular instance?
- 2.107** Part of the argument for late gospel authorship in broader scholarship is that Jesus predicts the destruction of the temple. If Jesus predicts the destruction of the temple from a secular perspective, you can see how someone would say, "Well, that was written after." Jesus says, "This thing is going to be leveled. Not one stone is going to be left on another." Then that happens. Obviously, someone is writing afterwards, and they're fulfilling the prophecy that Jesus makes about the destruction of the temple.
- 2.108** Now, that precludes Jesus actually being able to prophesy the destruction of the temple. It's one of a number of reasons why the gospels are dated either before or after 70 AD, because the gospel authors don't seem to mention it at all. It actually might—although once again, arguments from silence, we need to be careful—actually might be relevant to saying Jesus predicted this. "Look, it happened."
- 2.109** Other writings appear, too, and Revelation is one of these. There are certain texts in Revelation that seem to indicate that the temple is still operating. I wouldn't say that those are definitive.
- 2.110** I would actually hold to a late dating of the Gospel of John, mainly because the early church evidence, people in the early church testify to John living a very long life and then writing the gospel very late in the 90s AD. However, there are some sections in the Gospel of John which seem to indicate that he uses the present tense for certain architectural features of the temple, which seem very odd if the temple is destroyed. So, if people are arguing for an early date on John, what they use is some of the ways that internally John actually talks about things like the temple in the present tense, assuming that the temple is still there. You can go and look at the portico, you can look at how many columns it has that John mentions.
- 2.111** But something like Revelation, you're right, in, say, the Reformed theological community, there's an understanding that certain things that are written within Revelation are then fulfilled in the destruction of Jerusalem in 70 AD.
- 2.112** I'm very cautious on trying to date any of these things. I would say all of the New Testament are first century. I would put actually the gospels very, very early, and I would put John late. But I hold that with a very loose grip.

- 2.113** I'm fine with being wrong on that because I think as long as it's in the first century, it's still within the time frame of the eyewitness community. You're still getting things that are written down that could be read, heard, understood by those who were actually there.
- 2.114** Though most people died very early, we do have accounts of people living to being elderly. John is said to have lived a long, long time. There's an individual in the early church who, while he's being taken away to be martyred, he says that he's followed God [86] years. We also can look at actually gravestone inscriptions from Greco-Roman antiquity and see that people actually did live a long time, occasionally.
- 2.115** But in terms of Revelation, I think personally, yeah, I would put it pre-70, but I don't think that blows up all of my theological presuppositions, though I think that that is most likely the case.

Lecture 3: Textual History of the Old Testament

At a glance — Textual history of the Old Testament.

- 3.1 Okay, so we're finishing off the day talking about the textual history of the Old Testament. We're going to be starting off tomorrow with the textual history of the New Testament, but we're going to be discussing, finishing the day with a little bit of a synopsis of the textual history of the Old Testament. So hopefully, I haven't thrown too much at you throughout the day.
- 3.2 But I think this is a really interesting and fun—I'm biased—conversation because it has to do with maybe even some things that you have seen in larger religious visual contexts. This is an image, particularly the one on the farthest left, that I see all the time around Christmas. It's a picture of Eve and Mary, and they're consoling one another. If you notice, the serpent is wrapped around Eve's leg, and Mary is stomping on the head of the serpent. This is common throughout Roman Catholic iconography history. You'll see this time and time again of Mary trampling on the serpent.
- 3.3 However, this is based on a misunderstanding and mistranslation of the Old Testament. Let me exemplify it by showing you two different translations. One is the English Standard Version, and one is the Douay-Rheims Bible.
- 3.4 The Douay-Rheims Bible is the official Roman Catholic translation, and it's translated not from the Greek and the Hebrew, but from the Latin Vulgate. The ESV, which is translated from the Hebrew, says, "I will put enmity between you and the woman"—this is talking about the serpent who's deceived Eve in the garden—"and between your offspring and her offspring. He shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel." However, if you notice in the Douay-Rheims Bible, it says, "I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and thy seed and her seed, she shall lie in wait for her heel."
- 3.5 Now, the reason for this is due to a translation difference in the grammar of what the gender is in that text. The Latin Vulgate appears to have gotten the Hebrew translation incorrect and ascribed the seed of the woman being a female that would crush the serpent's head. Whereas the Hebrew and even the Greek translation of the Hebrew Old Testament, which is the major stream of what we refer to as the Septuagint, has the male pronoun there.
- 3.6 These are the things that I want to dig into. The textual history of the Bible and how something like the Vulgate comes into fruition.
- 3.7 Let me also say, I preface the first talk with giving a forward rebuttal and acknowledging that not everybody agrees. We will look at the data and we will come to different conclusions. Timothy Law, who is a research fellow at Oxford, says, "To be candid, before the Bible, there was no Bible, nor was there any way of knowing how the final version of the individual books would appear."

- 3.8** He says, "We have seen repeatedly that the Septuagint"—that's the Greek translation of the Old Testament—"and especially the Dead Sea Scrolls offer proof that the Hebrew Bible was not fixed before the second century CE." We've already looked at the canon conversations. I would say that there's actually evidence to the contrary of that.
- 3.9** But we do have to acknowledge that there are people out there who will say within the realm of the textual history, they will look at the same data and come to different conclusions. How do we come to the conclusion that I'm going to argue for?
- 3.10** Well, I would say we're going to look at two specific questions. We're going to look at whether the text of the Old Testament was fixed or fluid. Was there a fixed text prior to the second century AD? And what is the evidence on either side of a fluid versus a fixed text? We're going to talk about readers and scribes' concern. Were the scribes within antiquity who were responsible for copying the Bible, concerned with seeming accuracy or lack thereof concerning the available copies? How concerned were they about getting things right, about accurately copying? And once again, we're going to follow these on a timeline.
- 3.11** We have the third century BC to the second century AD with the Dead Sea Scrolls. We have the second century to the first century BC with the Samaritan Pentateuch. Then we have the ninth century to the 11th century with the Masoretic Text. These are some of the biggest evidences for the Hebrew Bible in particular.
- 3.12** If you've read the New Testament, you'll have encountered these individuals known as the Samaritans. They're a particular group who intermarried with some of the other tribes just north of Galilee. They're not looked on very well by the Jews in Jerusalem, but they have their own version of the Torah, the Samaritan Pentateuch, which does have some minor differences. Unlike having God's holy mountain in Jerusalem on Zion, they have it on a different mountain over in [Samaria]. We also have other places down the road, such as the Masoretic Text.
- 3.13** What I want to do in illustrating this is talk about the physical artifacts and the text being different things. Because sometimes I'm going to throw out dates, and the dates will have to do with the text, and other times the dates will have to do with the manuscripts. I'm going to try to preface that because there's a difference between the physical artifact and the writing that is on that physical artifact. There's a difference between what's sometimes referred to as compositional date and the date of manuscript copies.
- 3.14** For example, this is a Masoretic manuscript on the screen. It's from the ninth or 11th century. However, its text goes back into the BC era. So though the manuscript is Middle Ages, the text is far, far earlier. So when we're talking about these different lines of evidence, the actual data points that we can look at with the Hebrew Bible—sometimes I'm going to be talking about manuscripts, and other times I'm going to be talking about the text.

- 3.15** We also have a number of different pieces of evidence that go outside of the Hebrew Bible. I've already mentioned the Greek Septuagint. The Greek Septuagint was a stream of Greek translations of the Old Testament. It wasn't the only stream of translation, and it wasn't a single thing.
- 3.16** Much like I said, the Dead Sea Scrolls are a library. We need to be careful about how much or how little we make of talking about the Dead Sea Scrolls. The same goes with the Septuagint, because the Septuagint is just a category that we designate for a bunch of literature that existed within the Jewish ancient world that they translated into Greek.
- 3.17** So around the third century BC, the Torah, the first five books of Moses, are translated into Greek. And then over the next few centuries leading up right to the first century AD, eventually, the majority, if not all, of the Hebrew Bible is then translated into Greek.
- 3.18** But it's not done by a single person or a group, or it's done by different—there are different translational streams, there are different translational styles that play into that. There's a couple of other different Greek translations of the Old Testament, which attempt to render a text more literalistic to the Hebrew than the Septuagint offers.
- 3.19** We have to be very careful when we're saying, "Well, the Septuagint includes X," because that might have us understanding the Septuagint like this, as if the ancient author went to their bookshelf and pulled the Septuagint off the shelf. That's not what they would have done. It represents a stream of literature that was simply translated into Greek.
- 3.20** And part of that is exemplified by the Aquila, Symmachus, and Theodotion revisions of the text. So these are groups that happened in the second century AD that attempted to go back and render the Greek a little bit closer to how the Greek actually read—how the Hebrew actually read.
- 3.21** So for example, we have this in English translations. We have some very formal and some very functional translations of the Bible. A formal translation of the Bible is going to render the text as closely to, "If there are this many words in the Greek and Hebrew, we're going to try to get that as accurate as we possibly can," where a functional translation is going to say, "How do I get the point across?"
- 3.22** An example of this in the New Testament that I sometimes give is in the gospels, in the Gospel of Luke, Jesus looks at his disciples, and in a formal translation, you would render the text, "Let these words sink into your ears." That's exactly what Jesus says. He looks at the disciples and says, "Let these words sink into your ears." Some more functional translations translate that as, "Listen closely to what I'm about to say." That is not what Jesus said, but that's what Jesus meant.

- 3.23** The question for translators is always, how do you best render the text? It doesn't mean one is right or the other is wrong. Typically, the Greek Septuagint is a functional translation. It is going to go with the equivalent of, "listen carefully to what I'm about to say," over "Let these words sink into your ears."
- 3.24** So some groups got together in the second century AD and said, "We want something a little bit closer," and produced their own. All this to say, there are streams of Greek translations within the ancient world.
- 3.25** Then you have something called the Hexapla and Jewish revisions. The Hexapla was a document that was put together by an individual where he literally had a number of different Greek, Hebrew, Latin, and writings together. It was the first parallel Bible where he would have the different renderings of the text. Then you had other Jewish revisions later on that rendered the text in a different translation. Then, by the fourth and fifth century, you have the Latin Vulgate, which we mentioned before, translated by Jerome, and you have the Syriac Peshitta.
- 3.26** A Syriac is a version of Aramaic. Jesus would have spoken Aramaic. That was the lingua franca, as far as we can best estimate, of Jesus's day, what they were speaking on a day-to-day basis. There's actually a translation of the Old Testament, and the New Testament, but the Old Testament, specifically, in Syriac, which is the way that Aramaic eventually evolves by the second and third centuries. And there's a translation of that. So this is a very important witness.
- 3.27** So we have multiple streams of lines of witnesses. Some are Hebrew, some are Greek, some are Latin, some are Syriac. And so what this does is it works to help us understand that we have some different Hebrew witnesses, but then we have translational witnesses, and those are very useful to help us look at, how are people understanding these in different languages? How are the Jews in the pre-Jesus period understanding the Hebrew when they render it into Greek, knowing that there's a certain percentage of the Greek diaspora—or the Jewish diaspora who are speaking Greek and not necessarily speaking Hebrew as their day-to-day language? That can shed light on how they actually understand the text.
- 3.28** Let me give you another example, an interesting example of how the text influences things. This is Michelangelo's Moses. Now, I don't know if you've ever noticed before, but he's horned. We continue to see throughout the Middle Ages, Moses being depicted with horns. Why is this? There's a very interesting reason for this. The reason is because there is a textual difference in the manuscript tradition of the Old Testament.
- 3.29** In Exodus [34]:29, Moses comes down from Mount Sinai, and it says that Moses did not know that the skin of his face shone. Now, the idea is that he's in proximity to God, that reverence, that holiness. Then he's got like, by osmosis, he's got that aura. However, the Latin Vulgate says, "And he was ignorant that his face was horned."

- 3.30** Why is this? This is because the difference between the word horned and the word radiant in Hebrew is about vowels. The oldest form of Hebrew had no vowel pointings. The oldest form of Hebrew was, with a few exceptions, all consonants. The vowels, in terms of the written text, were added in the Middle Ages by a group called the Masoretes.
- 3.31** Now, there's a few things going on here. The word radiant and the word horned in the Hebrew are very similar. An added complexity also comes into view when we talk about ancient Middle Eastern literature, divine figures or figures that are close to divinity are frequently described as being horned.
- 3.32** Here's an example. This is a Babylonian lamassu. It's a Babylonian winged bull. It has a man's face. The lamassu are horned. In some of our earliest depictions in coinage of Alexander the Great, he is horned. The name for Alexander the Great in the Quran is Dhul-Qarnayn, the two-horned one. This is interesting. We have this understanding within the ancient world that horns are tied to proximity to supernatural or divine experiences.
- 3.33** So, what's going on with the Hebrew? There could very well be a double meaning that the author intended. The author could have meant radiance, like his face was shining, but with the play on words, the person who is fluent in Hebrew, in ancient Hebrew, would have understood, "Oh, there's a play on words there." There's a proximity to the divine there that they would have understood as ancient or Eastern people.
- 3.34** But whatever is the case, the Latin Vulgate looks at the Hebrew, and Jerome translates that not as radiant or shining, but as horned. Because of that, all throughout the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, Moses is depicted as having horns. So, there's influence of these types of things.
- 3.35** We also have other manuscripts that have been discovered within the last couple of hundreds of years. The En-Gedi scroll was a scroll found in En-Gedi, [Israel]. It comes from around the third century, but it was put in a box, a stone box. Then the room that the box was in burned down. The box became superheated, and it turned the scroll into a carbon roll, almost like a briquette or like a barbecue thing.
- 3.36** For a long, long time, when this was discovered, we just figured we can't unroll it. We don't know what's in it. Now, because of the technology that we're able to use, we actually have unrolled it digitally. We've used CT scans, and because when you do a CT scan, what bounces back gives you a different frequency from the ink and from the parchments, you're able to actually see what the text was when you digitally unroll it. We now know it's a copy of Leviticus.
- 3.37** Then you have other ancient, the Ashkar-Gilson, Hebrew manuscripts, the Berlin Staatliche manuscript, and then Cambridge Genesis, and Oxford's Ashmolean Hebrew manuscript. These are all very early manuscripts that come from the period between, say, the Dead Sea Scrolls and the later Masoretic Text.

- 3.38** But realistically, this is it. Between the third century AD and the eighth century AD, we really have basically nothing in testimony to the Hebrew text, which is in part why the Dead Sea Scrolls, when they were uncovered between 1946 and 1957, were so monumental, because it then pushed back our understanding of the Hebrew text, in some cases, 2,000 years—sorry, 1,000 years, because we had so little evidence.
- 3.39** Now, we had the translations. We had the Peshitta, we had the Septuagint, we had the Theodotion revision. Recently, just to give you another example, this document, Codex Sassoon, was put on auction; I believe it was in 2022. It sold for 38.1 million dollars at Sotheby's. But this is also one of our earliest witnesses. This is in contention for prior to the Dead Sea Scrolls, what would have been considered the oldest Hebrew manuscript.
- 3.40** Right now, what we refer to as the Masoretic Text is something like the Aleppo Codex within the Masoretes. The Masoretes were these very studious Hebrew scribes. They produced the text that for a long, long time before the Dead Sea Scrolls, when we're translating from the Hebrew, we're translating from the Masoretic Text.
- 3.41** But if you think about it, if Moses is somewhere between the 15th and the 13th century BC, that's a long time until we get to the 10th century. So, we have to do a little bit of the tracing of the history.
- 3.42** We do actually have things prior to the Dead Sea Scrolls, though. This is the Ketef Hinnom scroll. It's not really a scroll. It is a silver amulet. It's a silver amulet that someone would have worn on a string around their neck, but it has inscribed on it in what's called proto-Hebrew in this ancient Semitic text, the Aaronic blessing from Numbers 6:24. "May the Lord bless you and keep you. May the Lord make his face to shine upon you." That's found on that, and it comes from the sixth or fifth century BC, so quite a bit before the Dead Sea Scrolls.
- 3.43** However, these are just snippets. These sorts of things we find every once in a while, but it's only something like this. It's only like a section from Numbers. This isn't a copy of Numbers. It can only shed light on particular snapshots of the text.
- 3.44** When we get to the Dead Sea Scrolls, that's when a lot of things change. The Dead Sea Scrolls, 970 approximate scrolls in 10,000 plus fragments. All of these documents, although the vast majority of them are in Hebrew, some of them are in Aramaic, Greek, and some are even in this language, the Nabataean. They come from 11 caves that were dispersed, like I said earlier, across the northwest side of the border between Israel and Jordan along the Dead Sea. That's why they're called the Dead Sea Scrolls, is because they were found in these caves.
- 3.45** Some of them are really interesting because you have things like the 8 Hev, which is a Minor Prophet scroll. It's a copy of Micah. This is one of the examples of a Greek fragment from the Dead Sea Scrolls. But in terms of the conversation we're having, discussing, were the scribes careful? I think we see certain things like this.

- 3.46** Now, that might be hard to see, but though the text is in Greek, when the text falls over God's name, Yahweh, YHWH, the scribe writes that in proto-Hebrew. So not even Hebrew as it existed within the Semitic articulation in his day, but he writes it in the most ancient form of Hebrew, indicating that this is probably a very conservative scribe.
- 3.47** He's doing something which indicates, and we know this from the broader literature of the ancient world, that there's this understanding that in order to not break the commandment, to not blaspheme, to not say the Lord's name in vain, not only would you not say God's name out loud, but you might not even—you would have been very, very careful in how you write it. So, though you're translating the text, that name is holy enough that you would just leave it. This proves that there was a conservative attitude, at least within the group that's producing the Dead Sea Scrolls, at least amongst some scribes.
- 3.48** But did scribes care about quality control? I believe so, and let me illustrate this to you by showing you this. This is the Ashkar-Gilson Manuscript. It has sections from Exodus 14 and 15.
- 3.49** Now, it's really hard to read because we're able to do things like make negatives, we're able to read the text better. But it's very interesting that if you look in the formatting of this text, if you look in the formatting of a text that comes from the seventh century, and then you compare it to the Masoretic Text in the 10th century, not only does the text match, but there are line breaks that are in the exact same place. So whatever is going on, the scribes in that 300–400-year difference are preserving the text right down, in some instances, to where they provide line breaks and spaces.
- 3.50** Not only that, but when you look at Leviticus 8 in the Masada text and then the Leningrad text, look how they match. "Moses said to Aaron and to his sons, boil the meat at the door in the tent of meeting, and there eat it, and the bread that is in the basket of consecration, I commanded, saying, 'Aaron and his son shall eat.'" Then in the Leningrad Codex, 400 years later, "Moses said to Aaron and to his sons, boil the meat at the door of the tent of meeting, and there eat it, and the bread that is in the basket of consecration, I commanded, saying, 'Aaron and his son shall eat.'" No difference.
- 3.51** It contains Leviticus 8, 9, and 10. Between the Masada [Leviticus b], which is a thousand-year difference, we have the exact same wording. We have instances where what I refer to as paratextual features—spaces, line gaps, headings—those are preserved, and then we have the text itself being preserved in a very conservative way.
- 3.52** Dead Sea Scroll scholar, Anthony Ferguson, puts it this way, "Masada Leviticus b has a one-letter difference between it and the Masoretic Text, a difference of spelling that does not change the meaning. My calculation has the Dead Sea Manuscript at 600 words. Of those 600 words, it is in letter-for-letter alignment with the Masoretic Text." It's a thousand years between those two manuscripts. Anthony Ferguson says, "We're

talking about letter-for-letter connections." This isn't true for all the manuscripts. Please don't hear me saying that. But there's enough manuscript evidence to look at like this that we can say, in spite of some of the more wild textual carrying on, we have a very close connection to the preservation of the text.

- 3.53** Let me give you another example. From the Great Isaiah Scroll, 1QIsaa, this is one of the most well-preserved of the Dead Sea Scrolls. Very few of these look like this, but this is one of our only complete copies of an entire book from the Dead Sea Scrolls. In it, at Isaiah [40:6–8], it says, "The grass withers, the flower fades. When the breath of Yahweh blows upon it. Surely the people are grass. The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God stands forever."
- 3.54** "The grass withers and the flower fades" appears twice in the text— I should also mention this took 20 sheep to make. There's a lot of sheep. We have that instance, we have the duplication of "the grass withers and the flower fades." What's interesting about the Dead Sea Scroll manuscript is that we see that the scribe writes, "The grass withers and the flower fades," but then when he goes back to his text, he ends at the second, "The grass withers and the flower fades."
- 3.55** So he misses the section in the middle because his eyes skip. When he's looking at what's called an exemplar, the manuscript he is copying, he says, "The grass withers and the flower fades." Okay, grass withers and the flower fades. But then his eyes go to the second, "The grass withers and the flower fades," thus eliminating that particular phrase. But a corrector scribe has gone back and written—notice this—the text in the margin, and written: "When the breath of Yahweh blows upon it, surely the people are grass."
- 3.56** We have evidence of a carefulness of the text. They're going back, and they're correcting this. Interestingly enough, they leave just enough space in between the lines to do this thing. He goes down, you can see, he goes down the seam of where actually the manuscript is then sewn into the other parchment roll.
- 3.57** Once again, we have instances of this. The scribes are being careful. They're even going back and they're double-checking and they're making sure—whether scribe one and scribe two are different people or the same people— there's a correction that's being done here to preserve the text. We see this multiple times throughout things like the Dead Sea Scrolls.
- 3.58** But then we have other issues that are a little bit more hairy, like how tall was Goliath? Because the Masoretic Text, the Jewish revisers, the Targum Jonathan—which is a commentary—and then the Peshitta and the Vulgate say that Goliath was 9'9". It's a big guy. Most people are big to me, but that's really big. However, a couple of Dead Sea Scrolls, and this Greek Septuagint, and Josephus have him at 6'9", which means he's shorter than Shaq.

- 3.59** What do we do with that? How do we remedy the fact that if I want to look at the manuscript tradition, and I want to argue preservation and conservatism, what do we do when we find differences like this? What do we do? How do we figure out how tall Goliath was? There's a couple of things that we can conclude.
- 3.60** One thing we could look at is, is this an error? Well, there are a few reasons that we could evaluate that. First, in 1 Samuel 17, a scribe copying verse 4 could have mistaken the six cubits, which is the height, 9'9", anticipating the 600 shekels that Goliath's spear is said to have [weighed]. There's this hypothesis that you have this six number that's going on. So could that have affected the wording in there, that he's anticipating the six, and so he then fills that in.
- 3.61** Some scholars have hypothesized that. I don't know if that's realistic or reasonable. What about on purpose? Six cubits—sorry, that being the 6-foot height, makes David more impressive and actually is more realistically a critique on Saul, who, earlier in 1 Samuel 9, says that he was head and shoulders taller than all the people. If Goliath is only about 6 feet, King Saul is also the same height as Goliath. In that way, it's not that everybody's scared of Goliath because he's so tall. It actually says more about the cowardice of Saul. He's not brave enough. The onus in the text appears to be less that Goliath is a really, really big guy and more that he is— he just doesn't lose. He's such a skilled, formidable warrior that he doesn't lose.
- 3.62** Either way, to the average Israelite, Goliath is still tall. Whether we're talking about 9 feet or 6 feet, he's still taller than everybody else. Because if Saul is said to have been head and shoulders taller than everybody else at about 6 feet, that means that we're still talking about way taller than the average person. He's still imposing. The point is less, "What is the size of Goliath with the exact number?" and more, "This guy's formidable."
- 3.63** Even if we go with the textual variant in saying that Goliath is only 6 feet, it actually then works to put a different lens on the king who is willing to send a boy out to fight him rather than fight him himself when he is arguably around the same size. The point of the text is less the exact numerical accuracy and more the point that is being made: Goliath is big, Goliath is formidable, and Goliath doesn't lose. That's why he's being put out as this example by the Philistines to fight.
- 3.64** Let's look at another one. Isaiah 53:11: "After he has suffered, he will see the light of life,"—the New International Version says—"and be satisfied by his knowledge, my righteous servant will justify many, and he will bear their iniquities." This is a messianic prophecy about who the Messiah is going to be. But interestingly enough, another English translation of the Old Testament, the English Standard Version, says: "Out of the anguish of his soul, he shall see and be satisfied. By his knowledge, shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities."

- 3.65** Now, both these translations have evidence on either side. The ESV, the English Standard Version, is actually going with the majority text within the Masoretic tradition, whereas the New International Version is taking into account the Dead Sea Scrolls and the Septuagint. Now, what's interesting about this is the word "the light of life" is a very small word that is easily missed in the text. It would be easy to miss this word. We can see potentially how a scribe has missed it.
- 3.66** Now, does this have a grand-scheme-altering perspective on the messianic prophecy? No. However, it does influence things. I actually think the New International Version, taking into account the Dead Sea Scrolls, is the more accurate one. I think that that's what the text originally said. I think that it should be, "He will see the light of life." Light is a common theme that we see in the Old Testament for the messianic prophecies. It's drawn on. The New Testament authors—John, right at the beginning of his gospel, describes Jesus as the light, and says, "Men hate the light and love the darkness"—that imagery.
- 3.67** But I think what we can see is that even amongst differences that do happen in the text, none of these affect core doctrine, either in Judaism or Christianity.
- 3.68** But the fact that we even know that light is a possibility is because of the amount of evidence we have. If we're looking at this and people are saying, "Well, this just proves that we can't have confidence." Well, no, we can. We can have confidence because even the ESV that doesn't include the word "light" has a citation note at the bottom of the page and says, "Some manuscripts include light." Modern English translations are attempting to be as transparent as possible.
- 3.69** Even the fact that we know these differences exist within the manuscript tradition should give us confidence that we have what the original authors wrote because we're able to pinpoint these things with an incredible level of accuracy—because of, not in spite of, the evidence that we have. We're talking about the fixed or fluid text. I think that we can see that the text is both fixed and fluid.
- 3.70** However, there is enough evidence to actually justify the text being fixed, insofar as we can see evidence of conservative scribes who are attempting to treat this with a level of reverence in a way where they are really trying to preserve the text.
- 3.71** Now, later on with the Masoretes, we get examples of this where you would actually destroy a manuscript if you make a mistake. That's sometimes exaggerated in how often that happens. If you think of something like the Great Isaiah Scroll that I showed you, if that scribe makes that mistake, which includes the divine name, and they go, "Well, we've got to burn the whole thing." Well, that's a giant cost to everybody involved. Twenty sheep lost their lives to make this roll. You're not just going to do that. You're going to have the checks and balances in order to actually preserve the text.

- 3.72** Similarly, though we do see evidence for a fluid text within the manuscripts in things like Goliath's height, I think what we can see at the end of the day is that there are manuscripts, there are textual connections that attempt to preserve the text as well as possible. We even have commentaries of both Jews and Christians who are discussing these things. They're talking about Goliath's height or talking about textual variants that they themselves see.
- 3.73** We see this in the early Christian period. I mentioned Irenaeus. Irenaeus has copies and he says, "Some of my copies say this, some of my copies say this. This is why I think the reading should be this." This is just the nature of everything that's handwritten. Any handwritten document is going to have some scribal error in it. Because if you handwrite things, you're just more prone to making mistakes. You're prone to seeing "the grass withers and the flower fades" and then skipping that line.
- 3.74** We're going to see another instance of that tomorrow when we look at some of these from the New Testament. But once again, does the conversation of a fixed or fluid text mean that then we can have no confidence or reliability in any of it? I don't think that's reasonable.
- 3.75** I think because of the manuscript evidence that we have and because we have things like the Great Isaiah Scroll that push back our understanding of the text of Isaiah from the Masoretes of the Middle Ages to the Qumran community about a thousand years prior. Or we can look at what Anthony Ferguson said, where in some of these instances, we're looking at a letter-for-letter connective agreement. That's pretty phenomenal. Where the differences are, the vast majority of differences have to do with things like spelling. It's the difference between—
- 3.76** I come from Canada. You can forgive me for that. But where I come from, we spell words like colour with a "u." Does that mean that if I spell C-O-L-O-U-R, that that's wrong if we then find it in an instance without the "u"? Well, no. It has no bearing on the meaning or understanding of the text.
- 3.77** These are the kinds of things that we see largely—not exclusively, I don't want to exaggerate the point—but largely within the text of the differences between the Hebrew in the Middle Ages with the Masoretic Text, and then going into the Dead Sea Scrolls. Are readers and scribes concerned with these differences? I think they are. I think they are insofar as they attempt to remedy some of these situations. They're tacit in their admissions that these differences exist. We see scribes talking about differences.
- 3.78** When we discover readings in the manuscripts that differ from, say, the later ones that we have, we discover some earlier manuscripts—very rarely, if at all, in fact, I don't know of any one instance where it completely alters our understanding of the text. Likewise, none of these differences, whether in the Old Testament or the New Testament, have any bearing on a theological issue.

- 3.79** Within modern orthodoxy in Judaism and Christianity, doctrine is not based on any one text alone. If you remove a line from the New Testament that, say, has to do with the divinity of Christ, you don't then remove the divinity of Christ because it's there elsewhere within the document itself. There's no single proof-texting for any of these issues.
- 3.80** And though there are textual variants that are significant and that we do have to weigh and we have to make sure—and I'll talk about some of these tomorrow—we have to make sure that we're getting right, it doesn't have any bearing on completely altering our understanding of the core truths and tenets of either ancient Judaism or modern Christian faith.
- 3.81** And so when we're looking at this, I think acknowledging that there's both a fixed and a fluid text goes a long way in saying that we see this evidence. There are differences, there are scribal alterations, there are also corrections and conservatism that we see throughout the manuscripts, and we see that the scribes are concerned with the actual preservation of this thing, not solely because of, but largely because of the fact that they themselves consider these as divinely inspired, that they're holding weight and bearing that has a significant effect on what we believe for faith and practice.
- 3.82** Though some of the more formal traditions of really attempting to be careful—there's a mistake, we destroy the manuscript—it comes a lot later, even in the earlier iterations of it, we see that there's a carefulness and there's a prescription to attempting to make sure that, though we have documents that fall over the span of thousands of years, when we eventually get to the Middle Ages and we translate something like the King James Bible from printed editions of the Hebrew Old Testament, which largely—and obviously exclusively—go to the Middle Ages, when we discover the prior manuscripts, what they do is they confirm and give us confidence in the readings that we had instead of undercutting our understanding of the text. Thank you.
- 3.83** I'm curious about these scribes that you talk about. I don't know enough about history to know who that was or how that came to be. Were these educated people who were not merely copying pictures of letters, or were they able to read context and syntax? Can you give me a little bit of who they were, how they came to be?
- 3.84** We have a little bit of a difference between Christian and Jewish scribes. Jewish scribes, for the sake of the lecture today, were formally trained in that being your skill. One of the things we see within the Qumran community that we think are largely responsible for a good portion of the Dead Sea Scrolls is that they see, as an act of devotion, the careful copying of texts. There's a formality to it.
- 3.85** If you read the New Testament, you'll see that Jesus is constantly interacting with the scribes and the Pharisees. Now, sometimes that's translated as the lawyers and the Pharisees. The reason for that is it's not a lawyer in the way you would think of it, but it's someone who's an expert in the law. Part of that is because they are copying the

law. They're not just making physical copies, but they're constantly reading and studying. This was a formal job.

- 3.86** It's tricky in terms of trying to really figure out how literate ancient Jews were. I think there's an argument to say that they were pretty literate, especially when we come to how boys were trained to memorize sections of the Torah. But largely, it is a formal job description, although not exclusively. There's an argument about the form and function and competency of Hebrew in Jesus's day because, as I said before, the lingua franca of Jesus's day in the first century in Second Temple Judaism was Aramaic.
- 3.87** That was largely because during the Babylonian exile, when the Babylonians come and they sack Jerusalem and they take a portion of the people back with them—that's the story of the Book of Daniel—they're speaking Aramaic in Babylon. They're 70 years in Babylon. So the generation that's coming back to Israel is actually, it's the kids and the grandkids of the people who went there.
- 3.88** So if you think about immigrants to North America, I know quite a few people who are immigrants from places like Hong Kong or the Philippines or Pakistan who don't even speak the mother tongue of their parents. When those individuals are coming back to Jerusalem, they're rebuilding Jerusalem, they're speaking Aramaic, and that carries on right into Jesus's day. That's largely why the language of the day was Aramaic.
- 3.89** Hebrew is still clearly spoken and used within that time frame. It's very clearly a religious liturgical language. They are reading Hebrew, they are dialoging to a certain degree in Hebrew, and they're writing in Hebrew, even though they're discussing on a day-to-day basis in Aramaic. There's probably a good level of at least base competency in understanding Greek.
- 3.90** Part of that could simply be because they'd been occupied by Greeks and Romans for a long time. If the centurion tells you that you need to pick up his stuff and carry it, you better know what he's saying, or else you're in trouble. We also have instances within the New Testament itself where Jesus is interacting with people, where it's very unlikely that He would have been speaking Aramaic to them. The Syrophenician woman, who he has a conversation with, would probably not have been speaking Aramaic to Jesus. He probably would have been speaking Greek.
- 3.91** When Jesus has his trial before Pilate, it's very, very unlikely that Pilate was speaking to Him in Aramaic. In fact, Pilate would have almost seen that as beneath him to be talking in the language that the regular people are. It's very likely that Jesus is interacting with him in Greek.
- 3.92** Then there's good information to point to the fact that given some of the geographical regions that Jesus was preaching in, and therefore, some of the audience coming in from the Greek-speaking areas north of Galilee, and given the way that the Greek is formulated in the New Testament, that Jesus was potentially even giving the Sermon on the Mount in Greek. That's contested. But if you look at something like the

Beatitudes, they are alliterations. "Blessed are the poor in spirit, blessed are those who mourn, blessed—" They all start with the Greek letter P. Like a preacher or a good public speaker today, you do things to help your audience remember.

- 3.93** It could be argued that when Matthew records that, he's then recording it in a way where then he is making sure that in the Greek, it's translated to help people remember. But I think there's a possibility that Jesus could have even said that in Greek, given that there are people who are said to have come down, who it's much more likely that they wouldn't have known Aramaic and only understood Greek. If the Jewish audience does understand a certain base level of Greek, then it makes sense that Jesus would have been speaking in Greek.
- 3.94** All that to say on the multilingual aspect of the ancient world. The scribal culture is largely formal, although not limited to it. When we're talking about the Christian documents, literacy and scribal ability is varied, and it's a combination of very elite educated people and slaves.
- 3.95** Because you would have slaves. We have instances of slave women in Egypt who were scribes, because it's a lot easier if you just have a scribe on hand. You train this woman to read and write, and then she does it for you every time you need a letter sent. It's this interesting dichotomy of very, very rich, educated men and slave women. Not exclusively women, but we have some of these instances of women. But it largely is understood as a discipline. Within a religious context in Judaism, it probably would have been your occupation.
- 3.96** Which modern-day English translation of the Bible would you recommend and why?
- 3.97** That's what I should have started with. Which is the best translation? The one that I read, right? We have an incredible benefit in the 21st century in the English language when it comes to English translations. We have so many, and they're so good. We're going to talk about this more because I'm actually going to talk about the history of the English Bible, specifically. But it really depends on what you're looking for. When people say, "What is the best translation?" I often say, "It's the one you're going to read." Find the one that works for you and then read it.
- 3.98** There are caveats to that. There are bad translations out there that you shouldn't read. But generally, the mainstream translations are pretty good. This is a CSB, a Christian Standard Bible. When I operate in the formal function as an elder in my church back in Toronto, our church has English Standard Versions in the pews, and so I preach from the ESV. But I've also done some collaborative work with the folks who produce the NIV, the New International Version. It really depends on what you're looking for.
- 3.99** When I talked about earlier with the formal versus functional translations, generally, if you're doing more academic work, if you're doing study, people prefer a formal translation because they want to know, "What's really going on here?" Whereas if you're doing something like, "I just want to sit and I'm going to read it," a functional

translation is going to flow potentially better than a formal translation, simply because of the nature of—if you're always trying to get it as close to the wording, there's going to be a little bit of a stiltedness to it.

- 3.100** I use the illustration sometimes of driving an old stick-shift car. You'll get it, but putting in the gear, sometimes you've got to fight with it. That's what some really formal translations are like. No translation is exclusively only formal or only functional. It doesn't work like that because that's just the nature of translation.
- 3.101** So let me give you an example of this. In Exodus 34:6, Moses is on Mount Sinai, and he's communicating to Moses about who He is. He says that He is a loving God, compassionate, merciful, steadfast, and then in the Hebrew, it says, "And I am long of nose."
- 3.102** No formal Bible translation renders the text "long of nose" because it doesn't make any sense. Every translation, no matter how formal it is, will always say "slow to anger" because the phraseology in Hebrew of "long of nose" is an idiom. It's like the English phrase "hothead." The idea is that the more space you have in your nose—if your nose is really close to your face, it's going to get warm. You're going to get flustered. So, if you have a long nose, you have more patience before—the tip of your nose is what finally gets really warm when you're angry at people.
- 3.103** We run into things like that. Idioms, turns of phrase, idiosyncrasies with languages. Even the most formal translation is going to have to render things functionally. An example of the opposite of that would be in the book of Judges, the theme of Judges is that everybody did what was right in their own eyes. When you get to the story of Samson, who's a really strong guy, who has in the hair, and they cut his hair.
- 3.104** When he wants a Philistine wife, some of the more functional translations have him saying, "Go get me that wife. She's the right one for me," or, "She is the best one for me." Whereas the actual wording is, "She's the one that is right in my eyes." I think actually looking at that is a better translation in the flow of what the author of Judges is actually saying. All of these guys are doing what is right in their own eyes. They're not following what God's commands are.
- 3.105** Sometimes it's really great to have a formal translation. Sometimes it's really great to have a functional translation. Sometimes even the most functional translations are going to be forced to be formal and vice versa.
- 3.106** But I think an ESV, an NIV, an NLT, a CSB, an NET—use all the acronyms—these are really, really great translations. As we're going to see when we talk about the history of the English Bible, that is not the norm throughout most of the Bible's history, never mind English. The fact that we have that availability, the fact that I can show up to various events and I can just pick one to bring, is a real gift within the English language.

- 3.107** Going back to the scribal culture, when they're trying to preserve the text, do we know if their attitude was tilted towards the formal version of the text or the functional/meaning of the text?
- 3.108** When they're doing translations?
- 3.109** Yeah, do we know the culture of the attitude they had?
- 3.110** Yeah, it depends. That's where you see something like in the second century AD, the pushback on the Septuagint streams that are seen more as functional than formal. The Theodotion revision, as one of those major streams, is an attempt to go back and be far closer to the text. We see multiple different instances of this.
- 3.111** Even there's a spectrum, even within the Septuagint, because once again, you'll have copies of a translation of Genesis in the Septuagint, and then another translation of Genesis within the Septuagint, which differs slightly because they're not being done by the exact same person.
- 3.112** But generally, all of these things are a spectrum all throughout the ancient world. But what's interesting about the Septuagint is that it is far more functional than it is formal. It's more thought for thought or phrase for phrase than it is word for word.
- 3.113** And yet we see a lot of the time the New Testament author is quoting the Greek Septuagint in certain places in ways that are far more functional than it is formal. So, there's almost this understanding, even in Jesus's day, that that is still scripture, when they quote scripture and they're quoting it in a way that has a more flowy aspect of communicating the meaning rather than the wording.
- 3.114** Now, sometimes you see the opposite, and sometimes you see instances where, although it's hypothetical, the author will quote the Greek, and then, for some reason, they appear to be quoting the Hebrew and get a lot closer.
- 3.115** Now, what's interesting about the Bible—I might say this when we get to the English Bible portion—is that there's nobody—a friend of mine, Dr. Mark Ward, said this to me one time that there is nobody or very few people, if ever in history, who were fluent native speakers in both Hebrew and Greek simultaneously throughout the Bible's history, which means that everybody has understood the Bible in translation at some point.
- 3.116** And so, because of that, the early Christians were very eager to translate the Bible, and they did it a lot. We have very early translations into Old Latin and into Coptic and into Old Church Slavonic and into various lines of different ancient languages. They had no problem with doing that.
- 3.117** Part of that was the history of understanding that it's more important to understand the meaning of the text than to everybody automatically start learning Hebrew or Greek, for that matter, to be able to understand it, which is the opposite of what you find in some religious communities like Islam.

- 3.118** Islam preserves the Quran specifically in Arabic, and not just Arabic, but seventh-century Hijazi script Arabic. And though I've read the Quran multiple times when I talk to my Muslim friends, they will argue I've never read the Quran because I've only ever read it in English.
- 3.119** That's not the understanding within the history of the Bible. The history of the Bible has always communicated that it's how you understand it more so than memorizing or learning the exact language.

Lecture 4: Textual History of the New Testament

At a glance — Textual history of the New Testament.

- 4.1 Having already covered some of the bases on the canon questions and discussed the text of the Old Testament, what we're going to do is go on to discussing the textual history of the New Testament.
- 4.2 As you know, the Old Testament isn't the only part of the Bible that's relevant in this conversation. Arguably, because the New Testament is a more recent document, we simply have more textual evidence. That is a great benefit. There's a relevant downside to that in that the available data that we have to sift through for the New Testament is just exponentially larger than what we have for the Old Testament. Like I said in the previous lectures, sometimes the data is analyzed and different conclusions are drawn.
- 4.3 To start off the bat, I want to quote Bart Ehrman. Bart Ehrman is a New Testament textual critic. He was formerly the New Testament professor at North Carolina, Chapel Hill. He says this: "How does it help us to say that the Bible is the inerrant word of God if in fact, we do not have the words that God inerrantly inspired?" That, I think, is a relevant question.
- 4.4 You look at the data, and say, you have this long textual history. You have this complex series of copies of copies of copies. So how do we then relevantly interact with the data? Not just as historians, but as myself, as someone, as a professing Christian, believe things like inspiration and inerrancy and infallibility, these historic Christian doctrines. What are the things that we're going to be looking at today?
- 4.5 Part of the conversation is that we have no originals of these documents. We don't have any copies that we can say definitively were penned by Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, James, Jude, Peter, Paul. At the exact same time, that's true for everything within the ancient world. We don't have originals for any individual writing within antiquity, whether that's the classics or whether that's religious literature. It's simply the case that we are dealing with documents that are thousands of years old. Even if we were to have what's sometimes referred to as the autograph, that individual artifact that the author wrote on, it's virtually impossible to actually say that that would have been what the author wrote. Unless we have some, I don't know, scientific and DNA data that we can prove that Plato wrote this and this is his copy, it's virtually impossible.
- 4.6 The other thing is that we are dealing with copies that are done by hand. As we talked about in the history of the text of the Old Testament, hand copying has downsides. People make mistakes. There are things that creep into the text, whether intentionally or unintentionally. That's just the reality, the reality of every document, whether we're talking about the biblical documents, the 66 books, or the 27 books of the New Testament, or whether we're talking about the writings of Plato, Xenophon or Socrates,

or—sorry, Socrates didn't write anything—writings about Socrates, those works from antiquity.

- 4.7 Also, we have to deal with the fact that all the copies differ from one another. This is on a range, and this is on a spectrum of those copies and the mistakes within them being sometimes relevant and sometimes irrelevant, like I talked about yesterday, with some of these copies that we have of the Dead Sea Scrolls. The differences sometimes amount to spelling that has no actual bearing on either the meaning or any way that we translate those documents.
- 4.8 Starting with the Greek manuscripts, we have Greek manuscripts. We have quite a few Greek manuscripts. We also have ancient translations of those manuscripts into other languages, like I talked about. Languages like ancient Latin and Coptic and Sahidic, Bohairic, those variations of Coptic, along with Armenian, Ethiopic, all of these different languages.
- 4.9 And we have citations from early Christian writers. In fact, the complexity of the manuscript data is that sometimes we don't know whether what we're dealing with is, say, a copy of the Gospel of Matthew or whether sometimes these fragments that contain the text of Matthew could very well be a citation from an early church writer, and that's all that's left. There's a blurry line sometimes between, are we dealing with an actual manuscript copy of what was originally a gospel or a letter of Paul? Or are we dealing with a patristic citation, an early church writing that simply quotes that?
- 4.10 When we're talking about the manuscripts, the fact is that we have simply a plethora of data for the manuscript writings of the New Testament, far more copies than we have for any other ancient writer. But the vast majority of those copies are coming in and around the Middle Ages. You can see here you have the papyri copies that are done within that earliest period.
- 4.11 Then as it goes on, you have categories like majuscule and minuscule and lectionaries. Majuscule and minuscule simply have to do with the actual form of the text. Majuscule writing is some of the earliest that we see. They are done in all capitals and in what's called scriptio continua. All capitals, little to no spaces between words and little to no punctuation. This was just the form of the writing that existed.
- 4.12 There are reasons why we have so little early on. First and foremost, age. We simply have the fact that age is very bad on physical documentation. Age is simply bad on anything that we have from antiquity. When we're going to talk about archaeology, I'm going to point out the fact that we have lost arguably 99% of everything from the ancient world. They think they've only really uncovered about 1% of ancient Egypt. It's just a fact that the majority of either actual physical artifacts or texts and literary documents have disappeared. So, the earliest manuscripts we simply have fewer of because of time.

- 4.13 But we also see a rise in particular forms of texts because of things like the invasion of Islam in the seventh century. That wasn't great for the production of texts in classically Christian places like Northern Egypt or the areas that are now Jerusalem, Israel, Syria, parts of the Arabian Peninsula. When the rise of Islam in the seventh century happened and those nations became Islamic nations, the production of Christian documentation went down in those regions, whereas the production of Christian documentation in the [East], in the Byzantine Empire, grew. The vast majority of the textual streams of manuscripts that we have come from that period of time that it was easiest to produce those in the Byzantine era.
- 4.14 I also want to point out that you can see in the later period, even after the invention of the printing press, you still have handwritten manuscripts being produced. Some people just didn't think that the printing press would catch on and continued to handwrite them.
- 4.15 I want you to look at two examples of manuscripts. These are the same passages. The first one is Manuscript P72 from the third century, and the second one is Manuscript Gregory-Aland 323 from the 12th century. What I want to do with pointing this out is to show that there is textual continuity between the manuscripts.
- 4.16 At the exact same time, some people think that earlier means better. Earlier on the whole is a good indicator of getting closer to the original. However, as a principle, earlier doesn't always mean better. If we look at the textual preservation of these two manuscripts and we compare them to what's called a modern critical Greek text, so a text that academically has taken all of the manuscript evidence into account and then, through the process of analyzing the manuscripts and looking at internal and external data—I'll explain a little bit about what that means in a minute or so— comes up with a text that we translate our modern translations from, if you compare these two manuscripts to the modern critical edition of the Greek New Testament that our modern translations are derived from, P72 is 86% identical, whereas Gregory-Aland 323 is 91% identical.
- 4.17 The vast majority of these differences, like I said, are insignificant. However, you can see there that there are some examples where an earlier manuscript may or may not actually be the better manuscript. The manuscript from the 12th century has indications of having a text that actually, in some cases, may predate P72. We know that because of just the mountains of data that we have from the manuscript tradition and being able to analyze that.
- 4.18 But all that to say, an earlier manuscript doesn't necessarily mean a better manuscript. A later manuscript also doesn't mean a better manuscript. We need to take these things on a case-by-case basis. There are some early manuscripts that are incredible. If that was my only, say, copy of John, I think I would be fine. Then vice versa, there are some early manuscripts that I wouldn't necessarily want to be my only copy of the Gospel of John.

- 4.19 Similarly, with the contents, we can see that as you go on, there is quite a range in terms of the preservation of these manuscripts. As we go into the earliest period, most of what we're dealing with is fragmentary. When I throw out a number like, oh, we have close to 6,000 manuscripts in the Greek New Testament, not all of those manuscripts are created equal in their size. Some of them are very small, very fragmentary. They include a few lines of text. Others are near-complete documents. We're fortunate to have some examples like P72 of a near-complete copy of 1, 2 Peter.
- 4.20 But some of our earliest examples are just small pieces, small fragments. In the grand scheme of things, the complete copies that we have are few and far between. And part of that—like I said yesterday—simply has to do with the effort that went into producing what we would consider a Bible today, that having 66 books all in one go. That is an incredibly expensive endeavor.
- 4.21 Let me give you a couple of examples of these. Using some analysis breakdown on how much individual books would have cost, we can look at the documentation. We can look at actually the physical artifact, whether that is in papyri or in parchment or vellum. We can look at the cost of what a scribe would have charged to write these things. Something like the Book of Romans in modern currency would have cost just over \$2,000. That's a lot of money. That's a lot of money in the ancient world, too, especially for the vast majority of people who may not have that cash to throw around. Philippians is \$500. Philemon, which is a very small book, if you've read Philemon, is about just over \$100. And then 2 Corinthians is about \$2,000.
- 4.22 Something like a full copy of these things—like I said yesterday—in our earliest example, something like Codex Sinaiticus in the fourth century could have cost at its lowest, around \$400,000 in modern currency. This is inaccessible for the vast majority of people in the ancient world. I mentioned that the Great Isaiah Scroll probably took around 200 sheep to make. Codex Sinaiticus took around 360. I don't know much about sheep herding, but this is a flock as far as I'm concerned. This is a lot of sheep. This is a costly endeavor.
- 4.23 Like I said yesterday, the difference between a head of cabbage and a leather jacket is the difference between the material, whether you're writing on papyri or whether you're writing on parchment. Codex Sinaiticus, and some of the later bigger codices that we're talking about, are almost exclusively done in parchment. Every page is the equivalent of a leather jacket today. These are expensive documents.
- 4.24 If you are an early church community and you are trying to bring together funds, and you go to the elders in your community, and you say, "We want to buy a Bible. All we need is upwards of half a million dollars." That's a big stretch. It's a big stretch today, never mind in the ancient world. Realistically, most church communities in the first 500 years would have had individual books. They might have had many, but they also might not have. And we can see this in the evidence of the early church writings. Certain early

church writers seem to be more aware of documents than other writings that we now consider the New Testament, simply because of the accessibility.

- 4.25 On the flip side, the Christians were very eager and tenacious to get these things out. They made the process of copying and dissemination widely available. In fact, they did this to quite a degree, and I'm going to talk about that in a lecture forthcoming. But to the best of their ability, if a community wanted a copy of the Gospel of Matthew, let's say, hypothetically, there was a great effort to make that happen. Sometimes that meant that people who didn't even know how to read would copy the material, resulting in mistakes that resulted in not actually being able to read what you have on the paper. Those are easy to spot because people who read generally don't make mistakes that are evidenced when you see certain aspects within the text.
- 4.26 Similarly, when we're comparing copies, even something like I mentioned, the Gospel of Mark, which has some of the least amount of manuscript evidence in the earliest period, still has more copies than someone like Josephus, who I was quoting yesterday, who is one of the most important historians—there's writers—during this particular time at the end of the first century, beginning of the second century. Like I said, something like the Gospel of Thomas, only four copies. Remember, three of those are very, very fragmentary, and then one whole copy from the fourth century. The New Testament simply does come out on top, though the data needs to be calibrated. A lot of the early stuff is fragmentary. Most of the full copies come later on, though with the comparative analysis, we're able to do a good job of sifting through that.
- 4.27 Here's a quote from an individual, Giorgio Pasquali, who is a classicist. This is an individual who studies classics, not necessarily a New Testament scholar, but he says, "No other Greek text is handed down so richly and credibly as the New Testament." This is the reality that we're dealing with.
- 4.28 Sometimes I talk to my fellow academics who do textual analysis on writings of individuals, like Xenophon. I had a friend who once was doing some text critical analysis, analyzing the text and the history of the manuscripts with Xenophon, who wrote a number of philosophical works. He also wrote some biographical material on Socrates. He said to me, "I wish we were having the arguments that you guys in New Testament studies have because you're arguing so much because you just have so much to argue about."
- 4.29 It's like, "What I'm dealing with is very few, and in fact, our most recent copies, our most recent functional copies of someone like Xenophon, come from the 18th century." He said, "If that was the equivalent, if you were talking about 1800 years from Jesus, that would mean that your first copies of the New Testament would come around when the Wright brothers were inventing the airplane. That's a stark difference." Sorry, not the 18th century, but 1800 years after Xenophon, rather. We just have more to deal with. Sometimes that causes issues, sometimes that causes debates, but it is actually a good problem to have, if I can word it like that.

- 4.30 Coming back to Bart, Ehrman says, "The earlier we go in the history of the copying of these New Testament texts, the less skilled and attentive the scribes appear to have been." There's a little bit of truth to this. There's a little bit of truth, but just as I said, earlier doesn't mean better.
- 4.31 I also want to make sure we understand that later doesn't mean better either. Let me give you an illustration in a more modern way. We have two individuals on the screen. Would you say that Michael Jordan is more inferior as a basketball player because he's earlier? Well, I hope not. I mean, this is a debate, obviously, right? But we would say that the reason why Michael Jordan is not as good as King James there is because it has less to do with the fact that he came earlier in the spectrum of professional basketball than it does with actually analyzing the skill. We wouldn't use this argument. We wouldn't say, "Michael Jordan, he's no good because he's older." He's older in the spectrum of time.
- 4.32 Sometimes we have to admit there is truth to these things. When we're looking at P72 and Gregory-Aland 323, Bart Ehrman is not 100% incorrect in what he's saying. The earlier you go, the less there is a systematized overworking after Christianity is decriminalized in the fourth century in, [313] and Christians are allowed to come out of the woodwork and are allowed to do things like produce texts not under the cover of persecution, you do get more of a standardization, and you do get more of the availability of something like Codex Sinaiticus that I showed you, where there's just more of a system in place.
- 4.33 If you're trying to get a document copied in a time where it is hard to do that financially, but also politically, then there are going to be certain things that you might have to compromise on, getting professional scribes maybe to do it, or putting in the amount of money that would otherwise make a more well-rounded copy. But at the same time, there are some really good early text and some really bad late text. The thing is, we just need to take them on a case-by-case basis.
- 4.34 What I want you to look at here—I see I've labeled both of these as English Standard Version. One of these is not. One of these is the New International Version. I believe it's the one on the right. We have two examples of a Bible passage, 1 Thessalonians 2:7. The ESV, the English Standard Version, puts it like this, "But we were gentle among you like a nursing mother taking care of her children." The New International Version, the NIV, says, "Instead, we were like young children among you, just as nursing mothers care for her children." Why do we have a difference there?
- 4.35 Why do we have a difference in wording between "gentle" and "young children"? The difference is that we have differences within the manuscript tradition of this particular passage. This is an example of a textual variant, and it's actually a textual variant, where it could be one or the other, where the evidence externally is on the side of the manuscript tradition with "gentle," but the evidence internally, in terms of the actual grammar and flow of the text, is on "young children." Sorry, I might have said the

opposite. If you look at something like, "Instead, we were like young children among you, just as a nursing mother cares for children," that's grammatically awkward. It's the opposite of what I just said. The "gentle" one makes more sense. A nursing mother is gentle. However, the manuscript tradition is on the side of "young children." "Young children" is what we find most often in the manuscripts, whereas "gentle" is the thing that makes more sense grammatically.

- 4.36** Let me show you this in the manuscripts themselves, because the difference between "gentle" and "young children" is a lot more stark in English than it is Greek. It's the difference between one letter in Greek, the Greek letter nu. We either have the word *epioi* or the word *nepioi*. That's it. It's just the Greek letter nu. There you can see on the screen, you have GA 02 from the fifth century, and it has "gentle," *epioi*, and then you have GA 01 from the fourth century, and it has "little children," *nepioi*.
- 4.37** It is interesting that the word before it, if read out loud, and you add the nu to *nepioi*, is very hard to hear if there is an "n" or not. It could have been a case where someone was reading this and they heard *egenethemen nepioi*, and they didn't know whether the person who was dictating said *epioi* or *nepioi* and wrote what they thought they heard. At the exact same time, it's very easy to miss a letter, especially a small letter.
- 4.38** But you have these examples in the manuscripts where the manuscript tradition is torn. Deciding which reading to take for a modern translation comes down to a decision based on internal and external evidence. Translators must ask the question of whether they believe Paul originally wrote, "But we were gentle among you," or, "But we were as little children among you." Part of the problem is that the manuscript evidence seems to be split on this decision.
- 4.39** It could be that the scribes saw "little children" and thought, "That's awkward. That sounds awkward, so we're going to change it to gentle." It's not impossible. It's speculation, but it could very well have happened.
- 4.40** Even some of our earliest examples have "little children" over "gentle." In an interesting development in Codex Sinaiticus, which is the one that I mentioned to you that cost upwards of \$400,000 to make, the original scribe had written *nepioi*, "little children," and a later corrector attempted to erase the Greek "n" from the front of the word, thus making it *epioi*. But we can see this because the fading of the text as a whole has revealed that there was originally an "n" there.
- 4.41** Even something like Codex Sinaiticus has the original reading, but a corrector has come around and, using their exemplars, their manuscripts that they're looking at, has said, "Oh, I think this is a mistake," and he's corrected it. Or he's looked at the grammatical issue and thought, "Little children, that's complicated. We're like little children, like nursing moms? I think they meant to write gentle. I think they meant to write *epioi*."
- 4.42** At the exact same time, there's another textual variant in an interesting manuscript that doesn't say *nepioi* and doesn't say *epioi*. It says *hippioi*, "horses." "When we came

to you, we were as horses among you." This is a nonsense reading, though it is a textual variant. In this particular manuscript, we jot this down. "Hey, this is a significant variant. This changes the meaning of the text." However, it is a singular reading, and it is a nonsense reading. We know, both because of the date of this manuscript and the fact that this reading simply doesn't make sense, that the scribe made a mistake here. It wasn't hippioi. It was either epioi or nepioi. It's one or the other.

- 4.43** Let's be honest, I think there's room for interpretation there in saying the translation committee of the English Standard Version versus the translation committee of the New International Version are within their rights to make the choices that they deem fit, that they deem proper in those circumstances. Whether Paul meant to say we were "gentle" or as "young children," I don't think it affects any doctrine that I hold or even my understanding of what Paul is even trying to communicate. I think both of those things could work interchangeably at the same time.
- 4.44** But it is a matter of one or the other. When we have these types of variants that are, say, significant, it's always a matter of this word or that word. There is no place, at least that I am aware of in my study of the text of the New Testament, where it is a complete guess. We just don't know. We have to insert something here because the text is just lost. It's never that case.
- 4.45** Let me give you another interesting one here. 1 John 3:1 in the King James Bible says, "Behold what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, and we should be called the sons of God. Therefore, the world knoweth us not because it knew him not." The New International Version translates it like this, "See how great love the Father has bestowed on us that we would be called children of God, and such we are. For this reason, the world does not know us because it did not know him."
- 4.46** It might seem inconsequential, but where did that "and such we are" come from? It's a textual variant, not unlike the one that I pointed out in the Great Isaiah Scroll yesterday, where you have a repeated phrase or similar word ending, where a scribe sees a term.
- 4.47** Right on the screen, the first letter, you can see in orange, it looks like an M-E-N. That's the word *klethomen*. And then the phrase *kai esmen* comes afterwards. *Kai esmen* is the phrase that we translate as "and such we are."
- 4.48** However, the scribe appears to have seen the first M-E-N in *klethomen*, gone back, written that down, went back to the exemplar, but saw the M-E-N at the end of *kai esmen*, and then started on from there, functionally erasing that section. That became whatever that manuscript was or whatever that tradition of manuscripts were that made this mistake, became the majority of manuscripts that eventually got into the text that developed into the base text for the King James translation.
- 4.49** In that sense, we could come up with some conspiracy theory about how the King James translators don't want us to have confidence in being children of God, and so

they're nefarious, and so they eradicated that version of the text to cause confusion. But that's obviously not what's happening. We don't need to jump to conspiracy theories to come up with our conclusions. We can simply look at the manuscript evidence and see that these types of mistakes, when we see scribes looking at similar endings, are common. They happen. Because of the manuscript tradition, we can look at these things and we can see why they happen.

- 4.50** The question is, how many differences are there? Let me give you an example. In John 18 alone, the Gospel of John, chapter 18, we have 1,659 manuscripts, approximately. These numbers of manuscripts fluctuate all the time. We are discovering new manuscripts. Sometimes we're discovering that what we thought were two manuscripts are actually part of one manuscript, so this number is in flux. But let's say for the sake of argument, 1,659 manuscripts. There are 3,058 differences. There are 800 words that are written per scribe.
- 4.51** In order to calibrate this, we need to understand that 40% are nonsense readings, like the hippioi one that I gave an example of. Of those 3,000 differences, 40% are nonsense readings, and 58% are singular readings. They appear in just one manuscript and no other manuscript, which means that of 1.3 million words copied, you have one mistake per 400 words. That might seem like a lot, but with handwriting, it's not actually that many. A lot of these are spelling, not all of them. A lot of these are word order.
- 4.52** Greek is an interesting language in that, unlike English, where word order matters, you can, as long as you have the syntactical and grammatical things within the text, move the words around and have them in any word order, and they have no bearing on the translation of the words coming into, say, a translation like English. At the exact same time, we only have one difference per 434 words copied. Yes, there are lots of differences, but when we calibrate them, they become such a small number in the ones that are actually relevant that it's almost inconsequential if we start throwing around really big numbers.
- 4.53** There's 138,162 words in the Greek New Testament, but who's counting? There are close to between 400,000 and 600,000 textual differences within that manuscript tradition. That sounds like a lot. But once again, we're dealing with thousands of manuscripts, thousands of copies, and they're all handwritten. When you actually start to crunch the data, you find out those scary numbers that sound really big, more differences per words in the Greek New Testament, don't actually amount to much when we actually look at the singular examples. When we're dealing with epioi or nepioi, or we're dealing with klethomens or kai esmens, we can see why these differences happen.
- 4.54** Let's just go on. How many of these differences matter? How many of these affect the reading, and so academic translation committees provide them in citations? We have these sorts of examples. You see John 18. How many actually are impactful in terms of

addressing doctrinal issues? When I go to a church and I hear a sermon and there may be a textual variant in play at a particular passage, how many of those actually influence the doctrinal understanding? Zero. I don't think that's controversial to say because that is the reality.

- 4.55** If you look at something like the number of differences that are cited in important editions—like I said, the modern Greek text that translations are produced from for modern English translations, there are a number of them, and they have different intentions in mind.
- 4.56** The UBS, the United Bible Societies' text, currently we're on the UBS 4, is the translation that's typically used for Bible translators. Bible translators for English versions typically use the UBS. If you have an organization that's, say, translating the Bible into a language that doesn't have a Bible, they're going to be using the UBS. The number of differences within the text or the number of citations from early Christian writers that are relevant are going to be listed on the bottom of the page. It's called the textual apparatus.
- 4.57** The textual apparatus for the UBS, it cites differences that only affect the Bible translation, that only have an impact on a translation committee looking and seeing a "gentle" or "little children," and then making a decision from there. Whereas the NA 28, and actually the NA 29 is supposed to be coming out anytime now, but the Nestle-Aland 28 is the typical edition that academics, that scholars use in their assessment of the actual academically relevant questions about the text.
- 4.58** The textual apparatus, those listing of the variances, the manuscripts, the citations at the bottom of the page, are different than something like the United Bible Societies' text, because they're going to be a little bit more thorough in, say, questions of variances that may not have an impact on a translation committee, but may have an interest for academic research.
- 4.59** You can see there that in those daysthere are a number of other different critical editions of the Greek New Testament. But the number of differences in that, though they're listed differently, you can see that the ones that are translated—that have an impact on, say, something like, rendering the English translation for the NA 28 are very few.
- 4.60** Then for something like John 18, Philemon, and Jude, the UBS only lists 10, 16, and 47, whereas the Nestle-Aland, which is a little bit more thorough, has 173, 39, and 98. If you're actually interested in what some of these are, if you open up an English translation, a modern English translation, and look at the citation note at the bottom of the page, they're going to be listed there. They're going to be cited relevantly. Some manuscripts in whole or in part do not include or say this or have this particular wording. We're very transparent with this stuff in the modern world, whether we're dealing with academia or modern English Bible translations.

- 4.61 I think it's also relevant to look at textual emendations. These are places where translators, where academics have made a decision to render a text in a way that maybe differs with the manuscripts because of their particular looking at the text and saying, "I think they actually meant to do this. I think they actually meant to say this." Looking at a historic version, the Westcott and Hort text in the 19th century was a short-lived, but very influential Greek New Testament that was produced by these two individuals.
- 4.62 They had, in 1881, 60 textual emendations in their text where they said, "I can see the evidence, I can see the textual issues here. I think it's actually this. I think the scribe, for one reason or another, maybe made a mistake or forgot to put this particular text in." The committee of Westcott and Hort have decided to make an emendation based on what they believe is going on 63 times.
- 4.63 The next Nestle-Aland, 13 in 1927, they had brought that number down to 18. They said, "Well, there's really no reason," all the almost 50 others that Westcott and Hort were dealing with. We have actually more manuscript evidence since Westcott and Hort. We have a vast majority of manuscripts that have been discovered. Our knowledge of the text expands. In 1927, that went down to 18. In 2012, when the Nestle-Aland was updated to the 28th edition, that went down to two. The most recent Greek New Testament, the Tyndale House Greek New Testament, produced by Tyndale House over at Cambridge, has zero.
- 4.64 I do have to say that as a model, the translation group or the textual analysis group over at Tyndale House have chosen on purpose to not make textual emendations. The caveat to that is—"We think that this is not even that useful in deriving our text. We think that the data itself can speak clearly, and so we've decided not to make any textual emendations."
- 4.65 But what that proves, and I know a number of the individuals involved in the production of the Tyndale House, I know them personally, and in hearing them in their own words articulate these things, I think they have good reason to say, "We don't think that it's necessary because of the plethora of evidence that we have to even do things like make textual emendations."
- 4.66 But you can see over time how we've whittled down even the necessity of deciding, even with the mainstream version of the text that we translate modern English translations from, the Nestle-Aland, which, by the way, is not—this isn't a Roman Catholic or Protestant or evangelical. This is a group of the leading scholars around the world.
- 4.67 So secular individuals, when I study at the University of Toronto and my professors are atheists, we're still using the Nestle-Aland because that is the standard text that we use. So it's not like there's some preconceived bias to give the benefit of the doubt to

the authors of the New Testament because they're somehow inspired. This is actually the way that they go.

- 4.68** Do these differences have an impact on Christian doctrine? We've already touched on that a little bit. But let's look at something like the gospel—or, sorry, not the gospel, Acts written by Luke. It says, "And we bring you the good news, what God promised to the fathers. This he has fulfilled, too." Then we have a difference within the text. We have a difference between us, their children, our children, and us, the children. The manuscripts are divided on us, their children, on our children, or the conjecture that some, like the Nestle-Aland 28th edition, have decided to put us, the children.
- 4.69** Does this have a difference in the meaning of the text? Sort of. If we say, "And we bring you the good news that what God promised to the fathers, this he has fulfilled to us, their children," or "to our children." Depending on the audience that is viewed in here, they may or may not be Jews. They may or may not be of Hebrew lineage. So there is a difference. By putting us, the children, it solves that issue. However, is this theologically significant?
- 4.70** No, it's not. This is the difference we see within the text. It's not a grand difference that actually impacts even the meaning of the text. It's still talking. You can see the flow of what Luke is saying, even in the book of Acts. Do the differences make an impact? What about are the differences found in important verses? Likewise, I would say no, they're not.
- 4.71** John Frame, the systematic theologian, he says, "Scripture is highly redundant in a good way, such that the doctrines of the Christian faith are never derived from a single text." If you have a particular text that has an influence on the divinity of Christ or the incarnation or the atonement, you're not limited to a single place to derive that doctrine. You have multiple places all throughout the gospels and the epistles and the Book of Revelation that testify to those particular doctrines. Dr. Frame uses the word "redundant," I think, in a way that communicates that scripture has made it clear in the New Testament documents as a whole that the doctrines that are deemed essential for the Christian faith are derived throughout the pages of scripture as a whole, what the Protestant reformers might call *tota scriptura*, scripture within its entirety.
- 4.72** We derive doctrine in the Protestant tradition from *sola scriptura*: scripture is the sole infallible rule of practice and faith for the church. But also *tota scriptura*: don't derive any single doctrine on any single text. Let scripture speak to you as a whole. Johann Bengel, a Lutheran clergyman, put it like this. He said, "In the same way that a grain of gold, no matter how small, is still gold, so the smallest portion of the word which comes from the mouth of God is divine."
- 4.73** So, when we look across the breadth of the manuscript tradition of the text of the Bible, I think what we see is a number of things. We see that early Christians were tenacious in getting the text out. Because they were tenacious in getting the text out,

that resulted in the text maybe being produced in ways that were otherwise not overly professional. And because things are handwritten, that also complicated the matter with some of the things that creep into the text, whether that was intentional or unintentional.

- 4.74 The caveat to some of these is that you do have issues like verses, like the end of the Gospel of Mark or the story of the woman caught in adultery found at the end of the Gospel of John, chapter seven, at the beginning of the Gospel of John, chapter eight.
- 4.75 Those are complicated texts because though they are the only insertions into the text that are more than a couple of words long, both 12 verses, respectively. We can see the manuscript tradition over time. When our earliest copies don't have something like the story of the woman caught in adultery in the Gospel of John, and we discover the earliest copies and find the lack thereof in the text, it doesn't blow up our understanding because because of the rich textual tradition of the Bible over the last 2,000 years, scribes have been aware of those things all the way along. There have been notations by the scribes in the margins to point these things out. The scribes are careful and the scribes are very overt.
- 4.76 Same thing with the citations in the early church writings. Like I mentioned yesterday, we have early church writers who will say things like, "Some of my copies say this, some of my copies say this." Interestingly enough, Irenaeus in the second century has a discussion because he has copies of Revelation where the number of the beast is 666, and some are the copies where the number of the beast is 616.
- 4.77 He discusses this. He says, "My earliest copies say 666, and I think that that is the most reliable." Interestingly enough, we dig up the papyri and what do we find? We find copies where the number of the beast is 616. It confirms the conversation that someone like Irenaeus is having. Because we have both the manuscript evidence and we have individuals like Irenaeus discussing this, now we have a fuller body of working material to actually analyze what the text is. We are able to trace the text back with a high degree of confidence.
- 4.78 If any of you have heard of, say, the telephone game being used as an illustration, for the text of the New Testament, that all we have is a translation of a translation of a translation, and then we have copies that are copies of copies. The telephone game, or sometimes called Chinese Whispers, but I'm a Canadian, so that sounds politically incorrect. It fails actually what we see with the transmission history of something like the text of the New Testament because the telephone game is specifically designed to corrupt the message. You have to whisper. You are only allowed to say it once. There are these rules that are designed to—by the time you get to the end of the group, the message is corrupted.
- 4.79 But that's not what we're dealing with, the text of the New Testament. When we're looking at the history of the text of the New Testament, even though we see some of

these textual variants that I've pointed out, when we analyze how those copies actually get to us today, we find it's not a single line of transmission, like an individual whispering into someone's ear beside them. It is multiple lines of transmission. It is multiple lines of transmission where, if we're to use the same analogy, everyone in this room is speaking out loud to each other about what they have in their particular message.

- 4.80 So, at the end, when we say, "What was the original message?" We're able to all hear what the message was to begin with. There are checks and balances in those ways. Though maybe someone might mishear something and communicate something that might be incorrect, there are ways to actually verify that. Unlike a single line of transmission telephone game, sometimes I like to say that the text of the New Testament is more like a 100,000-piece puzzle.
- 4.81 If you were to open up a box that on the cover said, "This has 100,000 pieces." Would it be more annoying or less annoying if you opened it up to find there were 100,100 pieces or there were 90,000 pieces? They're both annoying, but actually, it's better to have more. Because if you have more, once you start to put the puzzle together and actually see the image of what the puzzle is supposed to be, it becomes clear where there are maybe added pieces, extra pieces, pieces from a different puzzle.
- 4.82 That's what we're dealing with, the text of the New Testament. We do not have 100% of the text of the New Testament. We have 110% of the text of the New Testament. Because we have 110% and we analyze the data, it's easy to see where that 10% is.
- 4.83 That's why scholars like the individuals at Tyndale House can look at the available data and say, "We don't need to make emendations. It's unnecessary." Because even when there are questions about certain texts and their authenticity, the data can speak for itself, and we can have a level of certainty with the text of the New Testament because of what we have that even far exceeds what we can do with other ancient writers, because we just simply have more.
- 4.84 Because the early Christians were so tenacious to get the text out, what it means—and I'm going to be talking about this a little bit later on—is that no one person or no group at any one point in time could have controlled the text because you had very early on, within a couple of centuries, copies into Roman Britain and all over Europe, into North Africa, in the Middle East, and in parts of Asia that can be compared with.
- 4.85 If anyone wants to insert a doctrine or tamper with the text, it's going to be located in a particular time in a particular place. I'll give an example of this later on. But what that means is that our confidence level in the text is actually pretty high.
- 4.86 Though we can read individuals like Bart Ehrman, who I think actually has some good things to say about the text, I think we need to be less cynical about the text of the New Testament than is really warranted by the evidence that we actually have for its textual history and reliability. Thank you.

- 4.87 Is the canon closed? Can it be reopened if we find a lost letter of Paul, or what about new revelation? Do we include those things, some prophetic voices used "thus saith the Lord" language today?
- 4.88 Yeah, a very good question. How open is the canon? When we look at the conversations within early Christianity about the canon of scripture, essentially what is talked about is that the criteria is the proximity to the apostles.
- 4.89 There's a unique period of time where you have individuals who within the first few hundred years of Christianity actually have that connection with the chain of custody to go back. There are ways to do checks and balances on discussing with individuals like Papias or Irenaeus or Polycarp who claim to have known the disciples themselves or have had connections with Paul or heard individuals who had these connections. In this early church period, they are putting together the books that are deemed within that particular church community.
- 4.90 Let's say we were to find a hypothetical letter of Paul. Paul actually writes to the church in Ephesians and says, "Hey, read the letter to the Laodiceans." Well, we don't have Paul's letter to the Laodiceans. Sorry, it's not in Ephesians. But he writes and he says, "Read the letter to the Laodiceans." There have been some documents that have claimed to be the letter of Paul to the Laodiceans, but they're almost unanimously fakes and they're later on.
- 4.91 I think the question we would have to come down to is, do we doubt that the early church did their due diligence in actually compiling the letters and the books that we have there. So, there's a historical question. And is the understanding of inspiration simply an author, or is it related to the book itself? If we were to somehow verifiably find Paul's laundry list, would that be inspired scripture?
- 4.92 I would say no, because in some regard, Paul is less inspired than the writing that he's actually composing in terms of the early Christian understanding of what's going on. The Christians were very clear in the closing of the canon in saying, "These are the books that get us to this community, and there really are no others."
- 4.93 That doesn't mean that there weren't other books. I'll talk about Luke—in the preface to his gospel, tacitly admits that some people are writing these things, and that's why he's writing, because he's writing to create an orderly account, implying that there are some out there that he doesn't think are very orderly. That doesn't mean that there aren't other gospels. Luke almost grants that. Whether he's talking about Mark and Matthew or not, he may very well be.
- 4.94 But there's an acknowledgement of other writings, biographical materials, surrounding Jesus. I think the church was clear in their connection to the early Christian community to make sure that they were getting the ones that had the presence of what they deemed authoritative inspiration and had an actual credible verisimilitude, the appearance of truth and likelihood of going back to Jesus.

- 4.95** The historic Christian position has been, no, you can't add to the canon of scripture. At the end of the first century, at minimum, the requirements to deem something as being included in the New Testament were proximity to Jesus.
- 4.96** Anybody giving a "thus saith the Lord" statement today would likewise have to claim some apostolic authority, which via the criteria of the New Testament, one of the first marks of apostolicity is, do they know Jesus during his lifetime? That's what Paul argues when he argues for his apostolic position. He says, "I've seen Jesus on the road to Damascus, and I've had that verified through the other apostles. I've been given a commissioning by Jesus himself, and I have been verified by the other disciples of Jesus."
- 4.97** So anybody today would have to have those criteria which are impossible to actually fulfill, which is why when you have, say, groups in the more modern era, like The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, which have an expanded—they add the Book of Mormon, the Pearl of Great Price, Doctrine and Covenants, things like that. That's been rejected by historical Christianity because of the understanding of what canon is. The canon is closed. The books that confirm the covenant's promises of God are the ones that are tied to that time frame of Jesus, and nobody has that authority anymore.
- 4.98** Even the book of Hebrews at the beginning says that God spoke to our fathers by the prophets long ago, and now speaks through His son. The idea that the author of Hebrews goes on to say is that the son is Jesus. Jesus gave that authority to the apostles. The apostles gave us these writings. I mean, it's not overtly stated like that, but that's what is going on there in saying we don't have prophets in the same way that we had in the Old Testament because we now have inspired scripture. We actually have something the author of Hebrews argues is better because it is that which is given to us by the incarnate second person of the Trinity.
- 4.99** The external evidence is overwhelming that 1 John 5:7 is not authentic. I asked Dr. Peter Gurry, "Hey, what about those who say grammatically, there's an issue with it not being there," since I don't speak Greek. He said, "You've got to get really into it." But what would you say to someone who says there's a grammatical issue for it not being there?
- 4.100** Yeah, the background to 1 John 5:7 is that you have this text— I should have brought my Bible up here. I don't have it with me right now. But what you have is a text that expands upon a Trinitarian formula. There are three that bear witness, and then it goes on to say that you have the blood and the word and the son.
- 4.101** This is a text that makes its way into the latin of the New Testament. When you have—the base text—I've got to back up. The base text for the King James translation is what are sometimes called the Textus Receptus. There are actually multiple of them, so they're Texti Recepti.

- 4.102** But it's the five editions of a guy named Desiderius Erasmus, then an update by a guy named Stephanus, and then another one by a guy named Beza. Those seven printed editions of the Greek New Testament are the main base text that the King James translators used. The first two editions of Erasmus do not have this particular phraseology in 1 John 5:7, this more expanded, almost Trinitarian formula.
- 4.103** The reason for that is because Erasmus, when he's compiling these things, says, "I cannot find it in any Greek manuscript," and he's not wrong. This text does not appear in any Greek manuscript until the 15th century. The only reason it starts to appear is because it seems to be that this was a commentary in the Latin that eventually made its way into the text.
- 4.104** One thing that's also important to note is that scribes are far more likely to add than take away because they want to make sure that they preserve. It's very unusual that things start to go missing in the text of the history of the New Testament. It's far more likely that they grow.
- 4.105** One of the reasons for this is that if they are unsure that something is or isn't scripture, they're going to put it in just to be sure, just in case. They don't want to lose it. That's why when I say we have 110% of the text, that's part of this conversation. The text grows to where in the Middle Ages, the text is actually longer for various reasons. But part of it is that scribes are very insistent on preservation rather than extraction.
- 4.106** We see this in the Latin tradition of 1 John 5:7. It becomes part of the text of the Latin tradition of the Bible. Erasmus is looking back at the sources and he's saying, "I can't find this text anywhere." He's getting a lot of pushback because he's actually producing a Greek edition of the New Testament in a time where the church is saying, "You only should be reading the Latin anyway." What he's doing is already controversial. But on top of that, he then says, "This text, which is appearing in Latin, is just not in the Greek, so I'm not going to put it in my Greek New Testament." He challenges his interlocutors in saying, "If you find a Greek manuscript, I might just put it in."
- 4.107** It's almost unanimous and known that what they then do is they go and they forge a Greek manuscript that has 1 John 5:7 in the expanded form, and they give it to him, and he concedes and puts it in his third edition, which then makes it in the fourth edition and the fifth edition, and is then copied by Stephanus and Beza, and then eventually used by the King James translators, which is why you have 1 John 5:7.
- 4.108** Grammatically, does it fit? Maybe. I don't think that's impossible. However, the manuscript evidence is just so overwhelming. What's interesting is there are a lot of Trinitarian debates throughout Christian history, and never once does anybody point to 1 John 5:7 in the later Trinitarian formula, which would have been the easy one. At the Council of Nicaea, when they're debating Arius, and he's talking about the Son being a created being of the Father, if they had 1 John 5:7, you bet they would have used it, or any of the other Trinitarian controversies. It would have been a shoo-in, an easy proof

text to point to 1 John 5:7, and yet nobody seems to be even aware of it. There are no citations, and there's no manuscript evidence for it.

- 4.109** There may be—although I think Dr. Gurry is correct—there may be, if you get into the nitty-gritty, some evidence for it possibly being original. But we have to be careful with those, too, because I think there are always interesting ways to analyze the text internally to make it work, but it's a combination of the internal and the external data that should be weighed. The external data is overwhelming against it.

Lecture 5: The Archeological Data

At a glance — The archaeological data.

- 5.1 This is a callback to lecture four. I do have my Bible now. Just pointing out that 1 John 5:7, in this, which is a CSB, a Christian Standard Bible, we have at verse 7, "For there are three that testify," and then there's a citation note. At the bottom, it says that a few late Greek manuscripts and some Latin Vulgate manuscripts add, "Testify in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit, and these three are one, and there are three who bear witness on earth." There you go. The Bible I happen to have is pretty transparent on that issue. Once again, that's what you'll find in modern English translations.
- 5.2 If we continue on our discussion, what we want to look at is the archaeological data, the archaeological data specifically for the New Testament, because just as the Bible is 66 books, the New Testament, specifically, is 27 books, 27 books that span a time of about 60 years within their composition, with nine approximate authors and over multiple countries in one language. That's Greek. This latter section of your Bible isn't just one book like the entirety of the Bible. It is an anthology.
- 5.3 It is a collection of books. And by acknowledging the historical realities of the New Testament and evaluating them on those terms via the evidence we're presenting, it only helps us understand these ancient texts, even as we find ourselves 2,000 years after the most recent ones were written.
- 5.4 In terms of archaeological data, my own preference and interest is in the manuscripts, these tangible physical artifacts that contain the text by which scripture was written on. I sometimes give the joke, to the bemoan of my wife, that I study ancient writing. The earliest form of ancient writing was on tablets. They would inscribe things on tablets. Tablets were eventually replaced by scrolls because that was a higher form of technology. You can fit more on a scroll. Then a scroll was replaced by the book. Nowadays, we scroll through books on tablets. Are we going forward? Are we going backwards? Unclear, but we're throwing everything in.
- 5.5 If we look at some of these things, if we look at the relevant data, not all of the manuscript evidence that we have was discovered archaeologically with the field that is sometimes referred to as stratigraphy, literally sifting through the dirt to find the different strata of the ages that they find themselves in.
- 5.6 Archaeology is not simply digging things up. That's just looting. But it's an actual formal study that looks at the time frames within the different layers that they are situated and then dates them based on that. It's a lot harder when looking at our archaeological artifacts if you don't actually find them in the ground.
- 5.7 The reality with a lot of our manuscripts is that some of them were found in the ground, but a lot of them were found a long time ago, and then, as I'm going to talk

about, rediscovered more recently in places like libraries and formal academic institutions, not knowing exactly what we had to begin with. But the manuscripts are these vessels that carry the text of the Bible to us. There are multiple ones that we could talk about.

- 5.8 We could talk about P66, a late second-century copy of the Gospel of John that preserves for us an almost entire copy of what the gospel looked like 1,800 years ago. We could talk once again about Codex Sinaiticus, the fourth-century codex that is probably our earliest example of what we call a Bible, meaning that it's a single volume, Genesis to Revelation copy that, as I mentioned before, took 260 sheep to produce. A lot of sheep, right? I don't want to bleat around the bush about it, but—thank you.
- 5.9 We could talk about P1, the first page of the Gospel of Matthew dug up from the sands of Egyptian Oxyrhynchus on January 12, 1897, and dated the beginning of the third century. It's the very first papyri to be discovered and cataloged in the modern numbering system that we use as the standard system for ancient Christian papyri.
- 5.10 There's Gregory-Aland 777, a more than 1,000-year-old copy of the gospels, and one of our earliest illuminated manuscripts, which, alongside the Greek text, has these detailed paintings of events throughout Jesus's life. There are so many that we could be talking about, and they each and individually have their own characteristics that I think shed light on not only the text of the Bible, but the history of the transmission of how the Bible eventually got to us today in the original languages that they were written in.
- 5.11 But what I want to talk to you about is a lot smaller than all of those that I've highlighted. I want to talk to you about P52. P52, or what's also known as John Rylands 457, is a fragmentary piece of papyri that's housed at the John Rylands Library of Manchester University in England.
- 5.12 Interestingly enough, it's currently in Texas, in Houston, on loan from the John Rylands. If you want to go see what could very well be our earliest evidence for the New Testament, it's currently in Texas. It was discovered in 1934 by C. H. Roberts, who was a recently doctored scholar from Oxford University. As Roberts was rummaging through drawers full of manuscripts in the basement of the library, he happened to see what we now label as P52. It was a small, fragmentary-sized manuscript, but it was written on both sides.
- 5.13 Because of the script, which was this majuscule Greek— all capitals, no spaces between the words, and little to no punctuation. Because it was written on both sides, it was therefore identified as a book. Now, in the ancient world, Christians did not invent the book, but they popularized it.
- 5.14 We know that throughout antiquity, people preferred scrolls for various reasons, but books were not really utilized to the degree that they are today. One of the reasons for that, particularly in Egypt, was that with papyri, one side of the actual document is a lot smoother than the other side. There's a smooth side and there's a coarse side.

- 5.15** You write on the smooth side, but you very rarely write on the opposite side. So, when you're making a scroll, you can just roll that into itself, and then the coarse side is on the back. If you're taking sheets of papyri and you're binding them on one side, like we would recognize as a book, which is referred to as a codex, you're forced to, if you do write on the backside, write on a surface that's not ideal for actual writing.
- 5.16** However, unlike the rest of the ancient world, Christians seem to prefer the book format, the codex format. We're not entirely sure why. There are all sorts of reasons, but none of them really suffice in terms of all the argumentation. However, if we find a manuscript from the first couple of hundred years after Christianity, and it's written on both sides, even before transcribing and translating the text, it's not a bad assumption to assume that it is a Christian document because of how frequently the Christians did this.
- 5.17** C. H. Roberts finds this manuscript. He sees it's written on both sides. He thinks, "I think this is a Christian manuscript." He transcribes the text, and sure enough, that's what it was. It was a fragment of the Gospel of John containing John 18.
- 5.18** Now, just about a century prior to Roberts making the discovery of P52, a man named Ferdinand Baur in Germany had come up with a theory. Baur had a theory based on his own mentor, who was a guy named Hegel. Hegel, the philosopher, had come up with Hegelian dialectic. You might be familiar with it, having a thesis, an antithesis, and a synthesis. Baur, being a biblical scholar, applies this philosophical system, and he comes up with a dating system for the gospels and the New Testament writings that he derives from Hegelian dialectic.
- 5.19** On this basis, he comes up with a dating system that prescribes John, which he estimates has the highest Christology, has the highest view of Jesus as divine, and also portrays Jesus as both being a very Jewish individual and a very Gentile-like person in his teaching. He comes up with the synthesis and thus dates the Gospel of John no earlier than about 160 to 170 AD, based on his assessment.
- 5.20** This was the standard for the dating of the gospels for basically the next 100 years within rational German scholarship when it came to New Testament studies, that there was a conclusion that the Gospel of John was late second century because of this philosophical reasoning.
- 5.21** Now, almost 100 years later, C. H. Roberts, digging through papyri fragments in cupboards in the basement of the John Rylands Library, finds P52. He finds P52 and he sends it off to the leading papyrologist of his day, people who date to manuscripts, paleographers who study handwriting and papyrologists who study documents in papyri.
- 5.22** They all basically unanimously say, "This thing is second century," and it's early second century. In fact, one of them puts it at the end of the first century, which we don't think is the case. But they all say, "This is second century."

- 5.23** Now, what's interesting is, because of where it probably came from, either the Fayum Valley of Egypt or Egyptian Oxyrhynchus, John would have had to have written, we think, in Ephesus, and then the document traveled around to where it got to in Egypt and been copied into what we now know as P66.
- 5.24** Now, this is 1,700 miles away, so we have to allow for time. We have to allow for the book trade to interact within our timeline of this, which means that if P52 is early second century, or at minimum, just within the second century, what this does is it pushes the dating of the Gospel of John back.
- 5.25** Now, is this bulletproof in this argument? No. There are, of course, people who will date the Gospel of John and its proximity to P52 very differently. Some people date P52 later. However, I think there's a reason why the date of the second century has still stuck as the standard position, and it's because of the actual analysis of the evidence.
- 5.26** In that sense, this fragmentary credit-card-size piece of manuscript evidence had ramifications. It actually put close to 100 years of German rational scholarship to the flames because of all the assumptions that were made.
- 5.27** Now, once again, there are detractors on this. There are people who do date P52 later, but the consensus is the second century, I think, for a good reason. For this reason, a piece of what could be described as archaeological data, though it wasn't dug out of the dirt, it was discovered in a basement of a library, is very relevant for our understanding.
- 5.28** In fact, if you take a late dating of the Gospel of John, like I myself do, and you have P52 somewhere within the mid-second century, it means that the copy of P52 is actually very, very close to the actual inception of the writing, within maybe even 100 years of the actual writing, which is something that not many texts within the ancient world can boast.
- 5.29** Once again, we have all sorts of other pieces of data that we can analyze. You have interesting writings. We've already talked about the Dead Sea Scrolls and Josephus's writings, but also Jewish ossuaries, Jewish bone boxes. These are one of the most important particular pieces of evidence to align on names because the Dead Sea Scrolls use names, particularly in the writings that are not what we would recognize as biblical and just reflect on Jewish practices in those particular groups that wrote them.
- 5.30** But we're given names that are geographically located for places like the first century BC and the first century AD in Jewish communities. Jewish bone boxes are very helpful for this because we have a lot of them. If you've seen maybe paintings of the tomb that on the Easter scene Jesus was laid in, you'll see that he was buried in, according to the gospels, the tomb of Joseph of Arimathea, and he's on this big wooden slab. You often see the body being put on this big wooden slab.

- 5.31** Now, you may have never thought about this, but this is Joseph's personal family tomb. Well, it looks like Jesus is taking up all the room. No vacancy because Jesus is now there. What would happen in ancient Jewish burial practices is you would have a family tomb, you would wrap up the body of the individual, maybe potentially, depending on what your economic status is, with spices and aloes and herbs, not to embalm it, but actually to help the decomposition process and not smell as much. As the body would decompose and the bones would be the only thing left, the family would come back, they would collect the bones, and they would put them in these ossuaries, in these bone boxes, and they would carve the name on the side of the box. Then, not unlike a modern mausoleum today, you would slide the box into a hole in the wall in the family tomb.
- 5.32** Because we have so many of these bone boxes, we have a good indication of what names of particular Jewish individuals were like in particular areas. It's very, very helpful for giving us indications. This is what academia calls onomastic congruence. What we're dealing with here are name frequencies, which is just a fancy word for saying matching names. I'll use an example of this a little bit later on with the gospel, specifically, but we even see some interesting facts with the Book of Acts.
- 5.33** In the last half of the Book of Acts, Luke mentions two names that are completely outside of the data points of name correlation that we should be seeing for the particular geographical areas that he is talking about. Luke mentions 19 Greek names. Two of those names are completely unique: Damaris and Lydia. Now, these are completely unique Greek names. We have no uses of them in any inscriptions or literary documents anywhere within this time period. So they work as an unusual fact. He's throwing out names that we've just never heard before.
- 5.34** However, because there has been such extensive studies on name frequency and popularity throughout the ancient world in the last few decades, we now know that in the region where the last half of the Book of Acts takes place, this northern, Mediterranean, southern portion of Asia Minor, 10% of people had completely unique names. The fact that Luke has 19 names, two of which are completely unique, actually fits the data we would expect to see perfectly if Luke was actually describing real people in the real places, and he says he's accompanying Paul on his missionary journeys in the Acts of the Apostles.
- 5.35** Something like name correlation with name frequency shows the trustworthiness of the New Testament. Ironically, in the couple of instances where there are outliers, given the data we're working with, also happens to fit the data in regards to reliability. We can use some of the archaeological data in things like bone boxes, accompanying the literary data we see from the Dead Sea Scrolls and the writings of Josephus. We can correspond those with some of the naming systems that we see listed in the New Testament.

- 5.36** Because the New Testament books, whether it's the gospel authors writing their biographies of Jesus or the letters of Peter, Paul, Jude, or James, they're making sure they're communicating a level of authenticity throughout their writings. We see in terms of the correlation of statistics with names and unique names in these particular areas that Luke actually gets this very interesting fact right.
- 5.37** One of the most influential ancient writers was a guy named Tacitus. Tacitus was one of the foremost ancient Roman historians. He makes two minor errors, though, in one of his prominent writings. First, when talking about Jesus, he wrongly assumes that Christus is a personal name rather than a title.
- 5.38** The word Christ is a Greek translation of the Hebrew word Mashiach, Messiah. It means "anointed one." To Christ something is literally to anoint it with something. This is not an unusual word in Greek. It actually is used frequently in medical literature. To apply a salve or a balm is often used as christing. But with its connection with the Jewish Messiah, you would anoint the chosen one in ancient Judaism, whether that be the king or a prophet, with oil. That word becomes associated with this particular character.
- 5.39** But Tiberius—or sorry, Tacitus—not being overly familiar either with this term or thinking that the name Christ sounds like the Greek name Christus, makes the mistake of just assuming that this is actually his name. He makes this mistake and he says that Jesus, who was also called Christus during the reign of Tiberius, was executed.
- 5.40** But he also makes another mistake. In the next sentence, he gives Pontius Pilate the wrong title. He says that Pilate was commissioned not as a procurator, but as a—sorry, he calls him the procurator, but Pilate was the governor. He gives the wrong political title for Pontius Pilate. And though he is a very good historian, though the majority of our biographical material for a lot of the emperors prior and during his lifetime come from Tacitus, he is not very careful in this instance.
- 5.41** Pilate was commissioned not as the procurator, but as the governor. And this is backed up by numerous written sources, such as Josephus, his Antiquities of the Jews, as well as a record of what appears to be his removal of handing Judea shortly after Tiberius's death under Caligula, along with the archaeological discoveries. In particular, though, we have an archaeological discovery of what is referred to as the Pilate Stone. Now, this is a very important document, the Pilate Stone, because it has Pontius Pilate's title inscribed in stone. It's a particular stone that talks about this building being dedicated and being produced by the financing of the governor, Pontius Pilate. Right there, we have the term "governor of Judea" dictates, preserved for us.
- 5.42** It's interesting that while Tacitus gets the title wrong, the gospel authors continue to get it right. Luke, in Luke 3:1, it says, "Pontius Pilate being governor of Judea." So, we have, once again, corroborative evidence for the gospel authors getting things like

names right and getting leaders right, even sometimes when other Roman writers don't.

- 5.43** One of the most interesting pieces of evidence we have, and I had the pleasure of being in Rome this last spring and getting to be in the location where this was discovered, is the Alexamenos graffito.
- 5.44** The earliest depiction of Jesus crucified on the cross is not in a relic or in a church or in some icon. It's most likely this. This is a piece of ancient Roman graffiti. It's 1,900 years old or around there. You can go to the Palatine Hill Museum in Rome today and see it. There, etched on the wall in this piece of plaster, is a man on a cross with the head of a donkey. Off to the side, there's a figure with his hands raised in worship. The caption written on the wall says, "Alexamenos worships [his] god."
- 5.45** This is meant to be mocking. There's actually a history of mocking Christians and Jews by saying they worship donkeys. There's a number of reasons why this is that I won't necessarily elaborate into. Roman pagans mocked both Christians and Jews with saying that they were donkey worshippers. Jesus rides into Jerusalem on a donkey, and so they take advantage of this and say, these are just more donkey worshippers. It's meant to be communicating how foolish these Christians are. Not just this accusation of donkey worship, but specifically that they worship a crucified man. It's meant to communicate that it's ridiculous, that it's stupid.
- 5.46** If you go a little bit further into the area of these rooms—just to back up and give some context for this—this was discovered in what was probably, for lack of a better way of putting it, a boarding school for slave boys. We can see that actually on this is that this character, Alexamenos, who's portrayed to the side of the crucified donkey man has a tunic which is cut short, which indicates that he is a poor slave boy. This was the common dress. Another, whether it is a slave boy or not, is saying Alexamenos, he's this silly worshipper of a crucified man. There have actually been found other pieces of graffiti that say things like, "Alexamenos is faithful." So whether Alexamenos wrote that himself or whether someone else is trying to come to his aid or something.
- 5.47** But what does the Alexamenos graffito show us? It shows us that very early, followers of Jesus worshipped him as God. There's no getting around that this is accusing someone of worshipping a crucified man, and the only group that we have within this time period who is worshipping a crucified man are the Christians.
- 5.48** It also shows that Jesus was crucified, and particularly on a cross. Why is this relevant? There's actually debate as to what Jesus might have been crucified on. Because Romans also crucified people on stakes. The term for cross could also be a double up as a stake with Jesus's hands above his head and together. We can see evidence from the gospels themselves. When Thomas doubts that Jesus has risen from the dead, he says, "Unless I see the marks from the nails in his hand," and the term nails there is plural, indicating that there were two nails that were holding Jesus fast, meaning that he was

outstretched; it wasn't on a stake. But this works in the evidence to show that Jesus was crucified on an actual, like a T-formulated based cross.

- 5.49 But going further than that, we have individuals like Marcus Cicero who talk about the idea, why is it silly to worship a crucified man? Well, obviously, people who are crucified are criminals. But crucifixion itself was very controversial in the ancient world. Cicero puts it like this, "The very mention of the word cross should be far removed not only from a Roman citizen's body, but from his mind, his eyes, his ears."
- 5.50 It is a most cruel and disgusting penalty. In fact, the word we have in English, excruciating, comes from the Latin term *excrucis*, "off the cross." This was a penalty that was reserved only for the lowest of the low. If you were a Roman citizen, you weren't actually allowed to be crucified. It was deemed too beneath you. You could be drowned or beheaded, but you couldn't be crucified. It was too terrible of a death.
- 5.51 We see indications like that of Cicero talking about this and just how gruesome, how disgusting it was. It worked in a way as a curse word sometimes in the ancient world. Like, "May you be crucified," thing. We see this mocking scorn. This was a point of both misunderstanding and mockery for non-Christians.
- 5.52 We see this communicated in the biblical documents themselves. Paul, in his letter to the Corinthian church, says, "But we preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to the Jews and foolishness to the Gentiles." Interestingly enough, the words in Greek there are a scandalon, "stumbling block," which is where we get the word scandal from in English, and *moria*, for "foolishness," where we get the word moronic from. Paul is literally saying, this is a scandal to the Jews, and it's moronic to the Greeks. They won't understand this, worshipping a crucified man. We see that from the actual archaeological data.
- 5.53 Archaeological artifacts have their limits. Let me say this. These aren't proofs that the New Testament is true. However, combined with internal evidence from the New Testament text itself and the corroborative data of the artifacts I've highlighted, and many, many more that we could talk about, they testify to and correlate with the accuracy of the 27 books we call the New Testament.
- 5.54 This creates a cumulative case that gives us confidence that when we look back and we pick up our Bibles and read through their pages, we can see at a minimum that it's trustworthy as historically accurate documents. However, whether or not you then choose to embrace the Christian faith depends on far more than historical evidence.
- 5.55 The very quick examples that I've shared with you today are not going to convince you that Jesus is the Son of God. That's a theological position that's articulated throughout its books. That he did miracles, died for sins, rose again to guarantee eternal life.
- 5.56 At the exact same time, the best lines of historical reasoning today can and do, and probably should, I would argue, lead a fair-minded inquirer to the conclusion that the

New Testament contains good and accurate and trustworthy testimony from the time of Jesus by people who are actually claiming to be there and see what they saw—we're going to go into that a little bit more in a subsequent lecture.

- 5.57** But the testimony that has corroborative evidence in the form of tangible artifacts on its side, that the information found within its pages can be weighed against, scrutinized by, and verified with a host of external and internal lines of data show its reliability and accuracy. Because Jesus is no less than a historical character. But the claim of the Bible is that he's also so much more than a historical character, not just a reliable collection of ancient documents, but it's something that contains the words of a man who really did die on a cross 2,000 years ago.
- 5.58** Now, we do have to calibrate our expectations with something like archaeological data. We need to be careful that we're not claiming more than the actual archaeological data merit, because I don't think it's feasible to say that we should find something like archaeological evidence for Abraham. I don't think we're going to find that. The nomadic Bedouin tribespeople that made up who Abraham was probably left nothing. So trying to find Abraham's turban is unrealistic in its actual endeavor.
- 5.59** So, there's a calibration of the data that we analyze to verify something like the historical reliability of the New Testament. Because like I said previously, we simply don't have 99% of what was left by history. But as we're going to continue to see, I think what we have is enough. I think what we have is enough to say that the people that are writing these things are attempting to actually communicate real history when they're attempting to communicate history.
- 5.60** That also merits that we calibrate in understanding that certain things are read to be historical and other things are not. There are genres within the bounds of the canonical Bible. Some of it is prescriptive in that it's telling people to do things. Some things are descriptive in that they are describing what happened in history. Some other things are emotive. Some things are poetic. Some things are meant to invoke emotion from us, like the Psalms, when David is recording his prayers and his psalms about his trials and his sufferings and his times of great joy.
- 5.61** But we need to be careful to—like calibrating the archaeological data—make sure that when we're looking at the text, we understand that it is written for us but not to us. And so in understanding who it is written to, by looking at something like the archaeological remains, it helps us to draw out who the actual original audience was.
- 5.62** Now, I think it is written for us in that it has application to today, and that's why it's been so formative for the Western world over the last 2,000 years, that the Judeo-Christian values that actually built the society of what we refer to as the modern West actually do come from the pages of scripture.
- 5.63** But it's in understanding how the first audience would have understood those things that actually helps us calibrate. When Paul says that it's foolishness and it's a stumbling

block, we can look at how the hang-ups of both the Jews and the Gentiles in seeing something like the Alexamenos graffito, or maybe some of the earlier writings of the Jews, some of maybe the mocking tones that we even potentially find in writings like Josephus about who Jesus and his followers were, that helps us to understand how to apply these things.

- 5.64** So, there's a big caveat to archaeology, because I think some people want to have archaeology be the silver bullet, and maybe even overplay their hand in attempting to find things like Noah's Ark, to go into the mountains of Ararat in Turkey, and assuming that the Mount Ararat that the Ark is said to have landed on in the Book of Genesis is the modern Ararat Mountains in Turkey today. Could that be the case? Maybe. But I think in trying to almost Indiana Jones hunt some of these artifacts down, we might be doing something that actually is not feasible or probable to actually be doing.
- 5.65** At the exact same time, as we've seen in this lecture, and as we're going to continue to see, there are archaeological touchpoints that serve to help us understand who and what is going on throughout history. Those are very, very helpful. So, though we don't have evidence for a large swath of biblical characters or even some questions arise from whether these people actually existed within broader academia, I think, at minimum, we can see that the attempts in the writings of history are doing exactly that. They're writing history, or at least it is what is attempting to be understood as history by the original authors to be able to communicate things that are actually true.
- 5.66** When Luke writes his gospel, he sits in a line of testimony history that is comparative to some of the best history chronographers in his time period. When we compare those—like we're going to in just a little bit—looking at some of the ancient Greco-Roman biographies that we do [have] and we compare it with what Luke is doing, he's not attempting to write myth or an epic poem or assemble a bunch of fables and stories. I think what we see within the time frame and the understanding of that actual writing is that he's attempting to communicate historical reliability in his documents. Thank you.
- 5.67** Are there any other credible accounts or other sources that talk about the person of Jesus outside of the biblical texts?
- 5.68** Yeah. You're jumping ahead because we're going to talk on the historical Jesus, and I'm going to outline a number of those. There are, I think. And as I'll say in—I believe it's tomorrow's lecture—we do have to be careful in how much we put stock in those because they're almost certainly not talking about what they believe about who Jesus was, but what people in their day are saying about Jesus. I mentioned Tacitus. Tacitus writes about Jesus. He mentions Jesus. But he's talking about what the people in his day thought about Jesus rather than this is who Jesus was. That same thing goes with Josephus and a number of others.
- 5.69** We have some detractors who are pushing against Christianity, who are even accusing Christians of following a fraud. There's an interesting passage, I believe it's in the late

second or early third century, that talks about Jesus having grown up in Egypt that we know from the gospels after the Holy Family fled to Egypt. This individual doesn't deny that Jesus actually performed miracles. He says, "Of course, Jesus performed miracles. He had a childhood in Egypt, and we all know those Egyptians are magical people." Almost in an inadvertent way, he works to corroborate— although this wasn't unusual in the ancient world; they believed that people could do things like miracles. But he has less of a problem with Jesus doing miracles, and moreover says, "Well, usually Christians are just following a magic maker who we can tie his magic origin to his childhood anyways." So all of these are later.

- 5.70 Josephus is actually quite early because of the end of the first century. And there are some individuals who will put stock in some of the things that we find in the later Apocryphal gospels, who, not trying to throw the baby out with the bathwater, look at some of the corresponding passages and references to Jesus within the Gnostic gospels and the Apocryphal gospels and say, "Okay, what can we glean from who they might have thought Jesus was that's not included in the Greek New Testament?"
- 5.71 Now, you have to be careful with that because they are constantly trying to insert—like I said earlier— in making Jesus a pagan philosopher. We have to take that with a grain of salt. But Jesus is far from absent from non-Christian material.
- 5.72 I think another thing that we have to understand is sometimes people accuse the New Testament of being religious literature and then demand that we have evidence of something like Jesus's resurrection from nonbiblical accounts. I think what that does is it fails to understand that, like I said previously, it's very recent that we find them in this format. They were individual books. They come from the first century, and they're largely written by groups, some of whom may have never had a crossover with each other in real life. Whether some of the gospel authors had even met other members of the groups who were writing, whether Mark had ever met John or Luke had ever met Matthew, is up for debate.
- 5.73 But these books existed individually, and they exist individually as early source material. To remove them and say, "Well, that's just a bunch of religious Christian literature, and then you have all this other unbiased historical stuff," is actually to fail to understand how we do historiography, how we analyze texts.
- 5.74 Often, removing the category of reliability from something like the gospels because they have Jesus doing miracles also fails to take into account that someone like Plutarch, who was probably the most successful biographer in the ancient world, was a priest of Apollo. So religiously, he has his own biases. In fact, I believe he's one of a select few, a handful of priests of Apollo that even existed at that time. So everybody is working on some presupposition of religiosity or the supernatural world. They believe that miracles can happen. They believe that supernatural events exist. That doesn't mean that they're not reliable.

- 5.75** In fact, Mary's objection to the angel when he comes and tells her in the gospels that she's going to be with child, her objection is a scientific one. "I know how babies are made. I fail the minimum requirements of how babies are made. How can this be?" It's basically what she says. She's not stupid. She's not some pre-scientific individual who just says, "Oh, of course, I believe in angels. Therefore, when the angel tells me I'm going to have a kid, I'm obviously going to have a kid." No, she says, "I don't know about this. I understand basic embryology," at least as could be understood within antiquity. Ancient writers are not stupid.
- 5.76** So, when we look at sources for who someone historiographically is, we looked for the earliest source materials, and ideally by eyewitness or people who knew eyewitness. The demand for external writings, I think, is understandable, but probably misses the script on how history is actually being done because you want as much early eyewitness material as you can get.
- 5.77** Jesus is not a likely character to be chronicled by people outside of his circles, within, say, Roman-occupied Judea. It is very unusual that we have as much writing for Jesus—and I'll talk about this later when we talk about the historical Jesus—because Roman-occupied Judea was the armpit of the Roman Empire. The reason Pilate is there is probably because he was being punished. Because nobody wants to—
- 5.78** They're a very oddball group of religious adherents. They believe in one God, which in the ancient world seems a little bit silly. The ancient world is polytheistic, or at minimum, it's henotheistic. So it believes in many gods, and it believes in hierarchies of gods, and it believes in city-state gods. Your gods could actually be my gods by another name. That's a possibility. One of the reasons why the Greek and the Roman gods are the same by different names.
- 5.79** The henotheistic world looks on Jews and they go, "Those are strange people." And they're constantly uprising because they believe that they're God's people and they're being subjugated by an imperial system. What eventually leads—we talked about yesterday—to the destruction of Jerusalem in 70 AD was because the Romans are just sick of these Jews continually causing trouble, stirring up strife within the empire.
- 5.80** You have Jesus coming from this particular geographical location. Nobody should really be paying attention to him. There are other instances of ancient miracle workers. There are other instances of ancient messianic figures. But for some reason, Jesus dies, and his story doesn't stop there. There are a number of other messianic figures who die, and their story stops. There's a reason why we're talking about Jesus of Nazareth, 2,000 years down the road, and we're not talking about Simon bar Kokhba or Simon bar Giora, these other figures who claimed or at least were considered messianic in some way or another. It's because they died and then so did their movements, or their movement and their followers.

- 5.81** But Jesus continues on, and the movement continues to grow to the point where people like Tacitus, Pliny, and Suetonius are taking note, at least insofar as there are these people that are running around, they worship this crucified guy. It's very strange. So, that would be the evidence externally for the Bible that we have for Jesus.
- 5.82** I'm just curious about the P52. Can you share more on what library was it? How was it found—
- 5.83** The John Rylands Library?
- 5.84** Yeah. Who put that library together? Why did it exist?
- 5.85** The John Rylands Library is an actual library, like a physical building, an academic institution. In the 1800s, the 1860s, there was a movement by a number of individuals who were bucking the trend where usually people went to Egypt to find statuary or megalithic architecture. But specifically, there were two individuals who went by the name Grenfell and Hunt. They had just graduated from Queen's College in Oxford, and they went to Egypt to try to specifically find papyri. For about a decade, they're hunting around Egypt and coming up short everywhere.
- 5.86** Near the end of their expedition length, they go to an area called Oxyrhynchus, which wasn't really thought to have been all that much. In its day, it was quite the intellectual center. But if you compare it to Giza or to some of the other areas where manuscripts had come out of, there really wasn't much to look at, except for the fact that it had all of these mounds that ended up being a garbage dump. So Oxyrhynchus, Egypt was where papyri were being made and being copied and where outside of Alexandria was in its time frame, a pretty significant intellectual hub. They were constantly writing things and reusing material, but then throwing out a whole bunch.
- 5.87** Grenfell and Hunt end up digging up these garbage mounds and finding hundreds of thousands of manuscripts. In fact, over the course of their entire expedition there, they found just over half a million papyri. It ends up being our largest stash of not just biblical documents, but classical documents.
- 5.88** The Egypt Exploration Society, the Oxyrhynchus Collection, is the largest collection of ancient papyri in the world. But there was so much that was discovered that they started to do things like put it in shoe boxes or cigarette containers and just ship it back to Oxford. They were analyzing things. I mentioned P1 was the first manuscript that was discovered at Oxyrhynchus. But they were finding it by the mounds. A lot of it was fragmentary. You're looking at some of the more well-preserved things in order to analyze them.
- 5.89** A whole bunch of this stuff is just shipped back to England. Even if you go to somewhere like the Bodleian Library today at Oxford University and you get permission — I've done this; I've had a number of friends who have done this—to access the Oxyrhynchus papyri, you can pull open drawers and still find the cigarette containers

that Grenfell and Hunt originally put them in. Some of these pieces of papyri are still in there that haven't been analyzed at all, mostly because they're so fragmentary. But so much of this stuff was shipped over that it required the manpower that they didn't have to actually analyze it.

- 5.90** Part of what C. H. Roberts is doing in the basement of the John Rylands Library is he's just attempting to catalog some of it. He's attempting to—"Okay, this is this, or this might be this," but some of it looks like confetti. We know it's papyri. It has a couple of words here or there. This is true for the Dead Sea Scrolls as well. It's a massive undertaking to put them all together.
- 5.91** But in Oxford in particular, although not limited to it, there's just a lot of this stuff which is yet to be published because there was so much of it found. We're still pulling papyri out of Oxyrhynchus today. It's less; they got, I think, most of it, but we're still pulling papyri out of Egyptian Oxyrhynchus.
- 5.92** It's a good assumption for some of the other manuscripts that are found in later places in Egypt to assume that it probably comes from areas like Oxyrhynchus or the Fayum, which is just north of Oxyrhynchus, because that's where so much of it eventually did come from. There's still a massive amount of work that needs to be done, and the Egypt Exploration Society is continually publishing it. The publication of the Egypt Exploration Society's Oxyrhynchus collection happens every few years, and they'll include new manuscripts constantly.
- 5.93** On Joe Rogan's podcast, you had brought up the book *Veritas*, which was really good, by the way. That had to do with forgery, but there was also the scandal of Dirk Obbink with the EES. Are you aware of any other scandals like that, or at least maybe some relating to Old Testament manuscripts?
- 5.94** Yeah. What's being referred to is there was a fragment of a Coptic manuscript that was discovered within the last couple of decades that was labeled the Gospel of Jesus's Wife because it had this very unusual text that talked about potentially Mary Magdalene, although unclear, about a woman who Jesus loved.
- 5.95** This is actually not an unusual thing to find in that the Gospel of Philip has Mary as a very keen individual and actually says the section, there's a hole in the relevant section of this particular manuscript, but with trying to fill in the gaps, making those textual emendations if you get a translation, it usually says that Jesus loved her more than any other disciple and frequently kissed her on the mouth. You have a number of these instances. There's also indications in the Gospel of Mary Magdalene of these attempting to scandalize Jesus by a love affair, having him have a lover.
- 5.96** The Gospel of Jesus' Wife was one of these. It got embroiled in scandal because Karen King at Harvard University staked her career on it, and it turned out to be a forgery. Not only did it turn out to be a forgery, but it turned out that it was a legitimate fourth-

century piece of papyri, but that the text on top had been copied and was a hodgepodge of a section from the Gospel of Thomas.

- 5.97** However, whoever forged this manuscript, their source for the Gospel of Thomas that they used was a PDF version of the Gospel of Thomas known as Grondin's Interlinear. In Grondin's Interlinear, Grondin, who put together this very helpful interlinear text of the Coptic Gospel of Thomas, made a mistake in one place.
- 5.98** There was a grammar mistake that he had incorrectly transcribed into the text. That phrase with that mistake makes its way into the Gospel of Jesus' Wife and ends up being the silver bullet in all of the Coptologists, the experts who are analyzing this and going, "Something doesn't look right about this."
- 5.99** First of all, the text itself in the handwriting, in the paleography, was always a little bit odd. Right from day one, there were a number of individuals who just said, "This isn't right. Something's up with this. This doesn't look like any other Coptic manuscript from this time period." But this grammar mistake always stood out. There were a number of individuals involved, Christian Askeland. But there was one particular person who pinpointed tracing this back to Grondin's Interlinear and tying it almost certainly to the forger having copied from a PDF version of the Gospel of Thomas—which, no PDFs in the ancient world—so this identified it unanimously as a forgery.
- 5.100** This was a big deal. You have this book, *Veritas*, by a New York Times reporter, I believe he was. But it's a great book, if you want to read. He chronicles the whole history of this thing and how it eventually gets outed.
- 5.101** Now, it's very embarrassing for Harvard, very embarrassing for Karen King. She's still teaching at Harvard, but it was a huge hit to her credibility because she came out and announced this as not only reliable but as authentic. When the entire academic community eventually agreed that it wasn't, it was pretty controversial. That's an extreme example.
- 5.102** The one I'll mention tomorrow with Dirk Obbink—you'll have to wait with bated breath—was another one of those scandals. That doesn't happen that often. Every once in a while, we'll uncover things. Usually, the forgeries are pretty clear because we can pinpoint them. There's quite a few medieval forgeries that out themselves.
- 5.103** The Gospel of Barnabas in the Middle Ages, in the 15th century, is a very clear forgery because it seems to have no understanding or indication of the geography of ancient Israel. It has Jesus rowing across a lake to get to Nazareth. Well, Nazareth is landlocked, so there's no lake to row across. At minimum, the author doesn't understand. It has Jesus saying He's not the Messiah, but He is the Christ. It's problematic using the two words that mean the same thing. The author obviously didn't know that the Greek word and the Hebrew word mean the same thing.

- 5.104** But we only have the Gospel of Barnabas in middle-aged Italian and, I believe, Spanish. That was the only witness for it. It appears to be an argument written up in order to validate some middle-aged Islamic assumptions of denying Jesus's crucifixion, which the Quran does in Surah 4:157, and validating Muhammad as a prophet. There's a number of problematic things in the Gospel of Barnabas.
- 5.105** Usually, forgeries are pretty clear on that. Internally in the text, we can analyze the data. But every once in a while, you get someone who buys an authentic piece of papyri from the ancient world on the black market and then tries to write a forged text on top, which is the case of the Gospel of [Jesus'] Wife is one of those.

Lecture 6: Internal Evidence for the Bible

At a glance — Internal evidence for the Bible.

- 6.1 So, dovetailing off of the conversation about archaeology, what we're going to look at is internal evidence for the Bible. There are a few ways I want to go about this in terms of validating how we would make a statement like, "You can trust the Bible." And so, going through the definition of the word trust, what I want to look at is the definitional breakdown of trust as assurance and reliance on truthfulness, credibility, and character.
- 6.2 In the ways that you would open up a dictionary and look at the word trust, I want to analyze some internal evidence that we see within the Bible that would, at face value, give you merit to say that there's a level of credibility and trustworthiness that can be ascribed from the text itself and pulling out some of the historical evidence for what we're looking at.
- 6.3 If we look at the first one in truth as assured reliance on truthfulness, we can see that what I'm talking about here is the firm belief in the truthfulness, credibility, and character based on, is the Bible even claiming to tell the truth? I've already mentioned previously that the preface to Luke's Gospel says, "Many have undertaken to draw up an account of the things that have been fulfilled among us, just as they were handed down to us by those who from the first were eyewitnesses and servants of the word."
- 6.4 With this in mind, Luke says, "Since I myself have carefully investigated everything from the beginning, I, too, decided to write an orderly account for you, most excellent Theophilus, so that you may know the certainty of the things you have been taught." There are various places where the gospel authors give their purpose statements for why they're providing a biography of Jesus. Luke starts off right at the beginning and gives it to you clearly. He says, "There are stories out there, there are accounts," and he is interviewing eyewitnesses. He's making sure that he's doing his due diligence.
- 6.5 Luke's prologue actually parallels other prefaces we see in literary and scientific writings in the ancient world, such as the writings of Demetrius, Galen, Herodotus, as well as, although to a lesser degree, the writings of Thucydides.
- 6.6 You hear some of the things that we can even see within the text. As I mentioned before, he says that he's writing up an orderly account. This could very well be indicating that he's aware of unordered accounts that he thinks need a little bit of cleaning up. If you've ever read the Gospel of Mark in Greek, you actually find that Mark's Greek is very simple.
- 6.7 It's very rudimentary. If you take an introductory-level Greek course, you're going to look at Mark, or you're going to look at something like 1 John because it's the simplest Greek that we find in the New Testament. Mark does things like what's referred to as

parataxis. He continually has this phrase *kai euthys*, which is often translated as "and immediately." Jesus is constantly immediately doing things. In that sense, the simplicity of the Greek is like my 7-year-old when he's telling me a story, and he's saying, "Hey, Daddy, and then I did this, and then I did that, and then we went, and then, and then, and then, and then." It's literally like what we see in Mark's Gospel.

- 6.8 I don't think it's a stretch to say Luke might even be thinking of Mark in looking at the content, there is good, but it's not orderly in the way that it's actually written. [Luke] communicates to us some of the best Greek that we find in the New Testament.
- 6.9 Now, when we find the gospel biographies of Jesus being written, it's really at the height of ancient biographical writing as a genre. This is when we get ancient writers like Plutarch and Suetonius and Tacitus and so on writing biographies of important figures in their day.
- 6.10 This is a key time within antiquity for when we find some of the most comprehensive and some of the most well-written biographies and histories being produced. If we go back in our timeline, we find a little earlier on, the earliest life story accounts we see being written in detail are what we call proto-biography. Now, these are writings that start to pop up about half a millennium behind the gospels, behind the first century. But at this point, what would have been considered biographical would have been the equivalent of things like funerary eulogies. It might have talked about influences that a person had as a soldier or a leader, but it really just amounted to various sayings about the person. They're not overly comprehensive, and they're not meant to really draw out the finer details of those particular individuals' lives. This encompasses writings that we would acknowledge like Thucydides, Pericles, and Aristophanes.
- 6.11 Now, a few hundred years after Jesus, after the first century and the biographical material that we're finding in the gospels and then the other New Testament writings as a whole, we find what are called hagiographical materials. These are stories that tended to include a great deal of accepted embellishment.
- 6.12 It was common practice at this time to exaggerate a little more than normal in order to really capitalize on the saint or the politician you were trying to make an account of. This is why some of the records of the martyrdom stories for the apostles are a little bit tricky to trace in their actual historical reliability, because they're coming from this period of time where embellishment wasn't necessarily uncommon. So, it's very hard to pinpoint historical accuracy with some of, not all, but a good portion of the martyrdom stories that we have for Jesus' disciples, because they're being written a few centuries afterwards, and they have these earmarks of embellishment.
- 6.13 This is also when we get a lot of the Gnostic gospels being written, which likewise have these clues of embellishments, of exaggerating stories. We have a lot of stories that come in these subsequent centuries, talking about the apostles, talking about Jesus, but they just have these earmarks of a little bit of exaggeration.

- 6.14** Now, between those two points of proto-biography and hagiographical writings is where we find what within the classical world is considered the crown of ancient biographical sources. It's during this time that we actually find standards being laid out by individuals like Lucian, who writes a document titled *How to Write History*.
- 6.15** He stresses things like impartiality and detachment and rigor and devotion to truth that characterizes ideal history. Luke, in his gospel preface, exemplifies a standard similar to what Lucian is talking about when we see him saying that he's undertaking the task of writing an account, and to do so, he's doing things like interviewing eyewitnesses and carefully investigating everything from the beginning.
- 6.16** Now, would Luke have known about Lucian's writings? That's a little bit harder to make that direct causation. But at minimum, he's aware of the standards that exist at the time to be able to understand the rigor that is required to connect historical events to the events that he's actually trying to communicate. These are the words of people who, while they might not have first-hand knowledge of the standards laid out by individuals like Lucian, are certainly aware that what you say requires a level of authenticity and trustworthiness, truthfulness to it that can be measured and held in terms of historical quality.
- 6.17** They're doing what we find in other ancient biographies, such as not talking much or at all about someone's childhood. This was a standard practice we saw. In fact, we have some ancient writers who say that if there are portions of their life that really don't lend any credibility or thematic relevance to the thesis of what you're trying to communicate, then don't put them in.
- 6.18** You're just wasting space and paper. And so that's why we find unless there is something truly relevant, you don't add it. We know virtually nothing about Jesus' childhood apart from Luke, who mentions the story of the 12-year-old Jesus going to Jerusalem with his family, and then Mary and Joseph conveniently lose the Son of God. They leave Jesus in Jerusalem and realize He's not come back with them, and they have to go back and get Him. What is He doing? He's teaching the rabbis in the temple. And so Luke deems this relevant. This is communicating that Jesus has been someone of influence right from his childhood. There's something that goes beyond just him being a regular, normal person.
- 6.19** We see these standards laid out by other ancient writers when they say, "Don't waste space. It's not necessary." And so we shouldn't necessarily expect to see certain things. We might want the gospel authors to communicate certain things, but they're writing what we need to know, not always what we want to know. This is how we see ancient biographical writings in their standards being laid out.
- 6.20** Now, this is something that later on in the period where hagiographical material is much more common, other writings actually try to remedy. There's a series, a category of gospel literature called infancy narratives, where we actually get people trying to fill

in the gaps. What was Jesus like between the ages of 12 and 30? Once again, the embellishment comes out of the page where you have childhood Jesus doing things like running into His classmates at school and knocking them over, and they die, and then He raises them from the dead. Jesus's teachers are running around a little bit afraid of Jesus because He's doing all sorts of crazy things.

- 6.21 Now, what we see in the actual canonical gospels is when Jesus goes back to Nazareth, people in Nazareth are like, "Who is this guy? This is Jesus. We know Jesus. Isn't this the carpenter's son?" They say, "Don't we know? Haven't we grown up with His brothers and sisters?" Darrell Bock at Dallas Theological Seminary once put it, and I like this, saying that that phraseology is the equivalent of, "Didn't we go to prom with this guy? Why is He coming back doing miracles? What's going on?" We see these sorts of things where they fit within the biographical framework. The gospels are being written in this exact time window where the apex of the standards of biography intersected with a conscientious notion of historiography.
- 6.22 Or John, in his letter of 1 John, starts that letter by saying, "That which was from the beginning, that which we heard, that which we saw, and that which we touched." In fact, the Gospel of John, if you read Paul Anderson's paper on the Fourth Gospel and the Quest for the Historical Jesus, says that John has more archaeological, topographical, sensory, empirical, and first-hand personal knowledge than not only all the other gospels combined, but he says, comparable and even greater than most ancient Greco-Roman biography written during that period. It's a pretty high statement for a New Testament scholar to say, especially considering that a lot of people view John as the least historical and the most theological. I think that, actually, Paul Anderson is correct in a lot of his conclusions in the data that he looks at.
- 6.23 Now, if we do a comparison, Alexander the Great died in 323 BC. The earliest material we have for Alexander's life and exploits comes from Arrian, who's writing those things down about 450 years after Alexander actually lived. This is actually the norm for most of the biographical material that we have for individuals from the ancient world.
- 6.24 Sometimes we need to understand and calibrate the notion of what we should expect because we live in a hyper-literate culture where you can write things down and record what I'm saying here and now, and you can have individuals who are contemporary recording things about people who are living. But the ancient world didn't work like that. It was far less common for people to be writing things, especially rigorously, about who people were and how they lived. It was far more of an oral culture, and they would pass things on orally.
- 6.25 Though there are some writings that are going on, Arrian, though he is the first comprehensive biographer of Alexander the Great, is working on previous sources that he had. They were just a lot smaller in the nature of what he was working off of. But this is not to cast doubt or dispersions on Alexander the Great. We actually think that a lot of what Arrian wrote is credible and reliable, and we can corroborate it with other

writings from the time about who Alexander was and how his military exploits took place and some of the archeological data.

- 6.26 But all this to say, when we're dealing with some of these individuals, even the latest source material for Jesus is still earlier than some of our earliest source material for most other people in the ancient world. It's just the way that it materializes.
- 6.27 The gospels are not just coming along during a time when biography and historiography are at their apex, but they even sit in their own category because they're being written contemporaneous to the individuals they're chronicling. This is what sets the gospel biographies in a different category.
- 6.28 The gospels are a contemporary biography because they're writing about Jesus in a time when there was a living memory of him, when people who would have actually encountered Jesus during his teachings who could have been, say, in the crowd at the feeding of the 5,000 event, who might have been at the wedding at Cana when he was having his public debate with the Pharisees and Sadducees, people who have seen those things. And so the gospel authors would have known that if they were writing these things down, there could be the possibility of a reader or a hearer of the stories in their gospels that could verify or fact-check those details.
- 6.29 Let me also note that though we categorize these as gospel literature, the idea was gospel, euangelion, being the "good news," that there was one gospel message: that's who Jesus is, what he came to do. That gospel message is according to Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. It eventually gets titled as a literature genre, and then carried on in terms of what we later find with some of the apocryphal gospels, capitalizing on that. But the ancient Christian idea, especially in this period of its infancy, was that there was one gospel, and we have this gospel message recorded by these various individuals.
- 6.30 Now, this contemporaneous aspect of documents being in the lifetime, or at least in the living memory of the disciples, is unusual in the realm of ancient historical biography. A very small minority of ancient biographies were being written when eyewitnesses to those events were actually still alive. That doesn't mean that those are unreliable. This is simply the reality that we have to deal with in ancient literature. Most people are writing far after the fact and looking back and writing about those individuals in the past.
- 6.31 Like I said, we hear the gospel authors do these things to communicate accuracy in a number of different ways. They do things with names, they do things with locations, as well as accurate plant and animal life related to areas within the narratives they're describing.
- 6.32 Let me give you an example of this. In Luke 19:1-9, we have a story of a guy named Zacchaeus, who is too short to see Jesus in a crowd when Jesus came to town. Now, I can relate to this. The story says that he famously climbed up, and the term in the original Greek is a sykomorea. This translates in English to a sycamore fig tree. This

species of ficus did not grow in the northern Mediterranean countries like Italy or Greece or Turkey. In fact, it lacks natural pollinators in those geographical areas. However, this particular species of this tree is notable in one specific area where it became characteristic, and that's Jericho. In fact, in the second century, there's a guy named Rabbi Abba Saul who says that Jericho is famous for its sycamore fig trees.

- 6.33** Now, can you guess where Luke places this story? He places it in Jericho. It's perfectly reasonable to assume that Luke had either been in Jericho and spoken to locals who had heard this story, or he interviewed one of those eyewitnesses that he mentions in his preface to his gospel. Either way, Luke gets this very specific plant life accurate to this very specific geography. It's very interesting that Luke does this.
- 6.34** Let me give you another quick example of trust as assured reliance on truthfulness, from the Old Testament. In 2 Kings 18, you have this story of this individual named Sennacherib, who is king of Assyria and his exploits in interacting with King Hezekiah of Judah.
- 6.35** I also think it's worthy to note that for a long time, our information for a lot of the ancient Near Eastern rulers from places like Babylon and Syria was the Bible. If you were to go back to, say, the thirteenth century and you were to find someone in a monastery or in a university and say, "Who was Sennacherib, king of Assyria?" They would open up their Bible to 2 Kings to tell you.
- 6.36** For a long time, our first-hand sources, our first sources that we had available to us for who these characters were, was from the biblical Old Testament. We relied on it for a long, long time. We still do to a certain degree. I have a number of friends who are archaeologists, and they say when they're looking in geographical regions to dig things up in the Middle East, there are a number of literary sources they take with them, chief of which is the Bible and Josephus, because the authors are pretty reliable in terms of digging out, no pun intended, trying to get to some of where these things may be.
- 6.37** If you go today to the British Museum, you can enter a room that includes a wall relief of Sennacherib, the king of Assyria's throne room from 2,700 years ago. The room originally included a series of floor to ceiling carvings, 40 feet tall depicting the Assyrian conquest of Lachish, which was the second most important city in the kingdom of Judah after Jerusalem itself.
- 6.38** In the year 701 BC, Sennacherib led a vast army against Judah, as both the biblical and historical records tell us. King Hezekiah, who had rebelled against the Assyrians, was now confronted with the world's greatest war machine. So Sennacherib leads a conquest, and he destroys 46 cities across the coast of Israel until finally, he arrives at Lachish.
- 6.39** This was discovered in 1845 in what is modern-day Iraq. The relief describes in graphic detail the gory Assyrian conquest of Lachish, with pictures of soldiers and siege machines, battering rams, rows of sling throwers and archers, finally, climaxing with an

image of King Sennacherib himself sitting atop his throne while the spoils of Judah are brought before him by its captors. And above Sennacherib is an inscription in Akkadian cuneiform, which reads, "Sennacherib, king of Assyria, King of the Universe, sits on a throne, and the spoils of Lachish are parked before him."

- 6.40** In the palace room was also found a clay hexagonal prism with writing on each side. In the writing, among the other war campaigns listed on its sides, we read about Hezekiah, king of Judah, who was not subservient to Sennacherib's authority, but was besieged. Specifically, it says that "Sennacherib shut Hezekiah up like a bird, like a bird in his royal city of Jerusalem."
- 6.41** It's interesting that, though for a long time, our source information for who King Sennacherib was, and something like the conquests in Judea and the sacking of Lachish was the Bible, we eventually dig up King Sennacherib's throne room, and we find this correlative evidence for this whole particular battle. And the subsequent battles that took place, and also what was the siege of Jerusalem. Sennacherib wasn't able to conquer Jerusalem, though he sieged it for a long time.
- 6.42** And so, once again, being cautiously calibrating in our expectations of archaeology, we can look at things like this, and we can say that there's evidence there for the author of the Kings literature, 1 and 2 Kings, attempting to communicate actual history. That doesn't necessarily mean we need to go back and try to find archaeological evidence for every story, but at minimum, it gives us a level of confidence to be able to look at these things and calibrate them and say, there are grounds at face value to give credibility to some of these stories, both in the New Testament and in the Old Testament, because the details can be corroborated by outside sources.
- 6.43** Another thing that's really interesting is we find instances of names that appear to be borrowed. You may not know this, but the name Moses is not actually a Hebrew origination name. Moses or Mosai is an Egyptian name. We have examples of this, like the pharaoh Thutmose, which is the same etymological derivative in the root of that name. Moses was a dynastic Egyptian name. It didn't have a Semitic Hebrew origination. Similarly, Esther is not a Hebrew name. It's a fifth-century Persian name, Istada.
- 6.44** It is interesting that we can look at these types of names and we can see that there's correlation. It makes sense that Moses is named Moses, and that has a dynastic Egyptian origination because the whole narrative story and structure is that this took place in Egypt. When he is discovered by Pharaoh's daughter and given the name Moses, that makes sense. It makes sense that he would be given what is otherwise an Egyptian name. Same thing with Esther. It makes sense given that these are Jews in the diaspora, living in Persia, and they have adopted certain aspects of the language and culture of the day that communicates that they actually come from the time and the cultural context that they're being written in.

- 6.45** There's also other things like what we find in Numbers 11:5. It says, "We remember the fish which we used to eat free in Egypt, the cucumbers and the melons and the leeks, the onions and the garlic." That highlighting should be over melons. I apologize for that.
- 6.46** But what's interesting about that is that this is the Hebrew word *ha batay'im*. Each of the foods mentioned in verse 5, with the exception of the fish, is what we call a hapax legomenon, which means it's a word that only appears once in the entirety of the Hebrew Old Testament. Meaning that each occurs only once in the entire Hebrew Bible, and all of them have good Hebrew-Semitic etymologies except for this word melons.
- 6.47** Now, I'll spare you the philology lesson, but we know that the word that was used in dynastic Egypt for melons, which itself came from sub-Saharan Africa, where watermelons originated, is a near match for the word that we find in the Book of Numbers. When the Israelites leave Egypt after the Exodus, and they're complaining in the desert, and they say, "We used to eat all these foods that are native to this area," they name a number of things, but the usage of the word melons is very interesting because all this goes to show is that Numbers 11:5 is an accurate depiction of foods eaten in a time in the fitting era of dynastic Egypt.
- 6.48** While by itself, it's not a silver bullet that the Israelites dwelled and ate in Egypt, it is corroborative evidence that the Israelite memory of the sojourn in Egypt may have a solid foundation. The fact that the list of foods is Egyptian but contains only fruits, vegetables, and fish, with no mention of meat, adds further plausibility to the listing being a diet of slaves, as far as the archaeological records indicate of the slave's diets in ancient Egypt.
- 6.49** These types of language connections are what we refer to as linguistic loanwords. There are things that we find that indicate that, of course, the Israelites who are living in Egypt or the Jews who are living in Persia are going to adopt certain terms and terminologies that fit this cultural context. I can refer to a "kayak" in Canada, or a "Jacuzzi." These are linguistic loanwords from the indigenous communities in North America that we've adopted in our vernacular, and we see these things.
- 6.50** In regards to internal accuracy, the correspondence of things like linguistic loanwords gives us a picture that the stories we find in the Bible contain evidence of being descriptions from individuals who were actually there, either the author is being there or drawing from material of witnesses who were there.
- 6.51** But then we come to external accuracy. This is the question of credibility. I think we can say the truthfulness in the way that I'm defining it there, I think we can validate, at least at face value, with enough evidence to show that we have good reason to have confidence in it.
- 6.52** But what about credibility? Well, the question is going to be broken down with internal and external credibility. With the question of internal credibility, we're asking the

question as to whether the stories we find in our Bible are not just talking about a time, but have evidence lending to their credibility and being descriptions from factual and actual eyewitnesses during that period. We've touched on that with a few things, but I want to go deeper into the credibility aspect of that.

6.53 Then the external aspect of credibility is asking the question, though the most recent book in the Bible to our own time was written 2,000 years ago, how do we know that it hasn't been tampered with? How do we know that scribes or popes or kings or so on and so forth haven't adjusted things? Looking at the textual history already of the New Testament, we already have some groundwork. But how do we expand upon that further?

6.54 Let's look at internal credibility. I want to talk about something that's referred to as an undesigned coincidence. Undesigned coincidences are instances when you have one or more independent historical accounts, and they interlock in a way that would be unexpected if the story were simply fabricated wholesale. An undesigned coincidence is, in a court of law, what's typically referred to as inadvertent support. There are a number of these throughout the gospels and Acts, and there has been some interesting work done in the Old Testament also with the stories that correspond with 1 and 2 Kings and 1 and 2 Chronicles, two undesigned coincidences.

6.55 But when we look at undesigned coincidences, and we look at something like—I'm going to show you—the only miracle other than the resurrection of Jesus that's found in all four gospels is the feeding of the 5,000. This works as a good test case for us to figure out, are there independent historical details here that interlock in a way that communicate unforeseeable validation to the truthfulness of the story? The answer is yes.

6.56 What I'm going to be drawing upon is a work done by the analytical philosopher, Lydia McGrew, and the New Testament scholars, Richard Bauckham and Peter J. Williams. Richard Bauckham, being originally from [London], and Peter J. Williams, who is part of the team that I mentioned before that put together the Tyndale House Greek New Testament. He's over at Tyndale House in Cambridge.

6.57 Where all four gospels tell the story, three of the four mention the grass. John gives us the detail that there was much grass—very helpful—but Mark comes in with the very unusual off-handed comment that the grass was green.

6.58 Now, here's a graph that takes from some climate research that looks at the rainfall chart of the nearby town of Tiberias. It's just on the other side of the Sea of Galilee. From the place where the feeding of the 5,000 is said to have happened, it's approximately 20 kilometers away from this story. Between the years of 26 and 36 AD, all possible dates for the time when the miracle probably happened are between the last day of March and the end of April—that's what we're looking at. So if this event

really took place at the time recorded, we should indeed expect that after the five most significant months of precipitation, the grass would have been green.

- 6.59** But you might ask, how did you coordinate the time? Well, that's our undesigned coincidence number two in the story. We have this time frame where we can see from meteorological data that climate research actually indicates that this would have been a time frame when it would have made sense that there was green grass.
- 6.60** But if we look at Mark's Gospel, it says, "And he said to them, 'Come away by yourselves to a desolate place and rest for a while, for many were coming and going, and they had no leisure even to eat.'" Mark explains that Jesus went to a remote location in order to get out of the way of the crowds. He writes, "And Jesus said to them, 'Come away by yourselves to a desolate place.' For many are coming and going, and they had no leisure even to eat." This involves Jesus getting into a boat and then going to a quiet place, saying no more about the idea that people were moving around a great deal.
- 6.61** However, John, and John alone, records the time that this all took place. In John's account, he says, "Now the Passover, the feast of the Jews, was at hand." This is not an insignificant piece of information because the Passover is the biggest Jewish festival of the year, when the largest number of pilgrims would have traveled to Jerusalem to attend. John records nothing about the crowds traveling, and yet it is precisely the festival in John that would explain the detail in Mark about people traveling in such numbers.
- 6.62** It's like me saying, "I went to the mall and it was very busy," and then telling someone else that, "I was at the mall Christmas shopping." It makes sense in one account that the mall was busy, maybe not so much anymore. Everybody's on Amazon. But it makes sense in that you can put those two together and you can see that it's Christmas. People are in the malls, Christmas shopping. That's why it was so busy. We have a similar thing going on.
- 6.63** In Mark, the fact that Jesus moved locations indicates that it was not a mere increase in traffic for a few hours, but a more prolonged increase in a movement of people, such as normal occurrences only at festival times. That's exactly what we see. It's here that we have our undesigned coincidence.
- 6.64** John explains a puzzle in Mark. And yet, according to almost all of the scholarly opinion, Mark came first. Immediately after mentioning Passover, John says this. And he says the fact that correlates. Undesigned coincidence number three helps us because John says, "Lifting up his eyes and seeing a large crowd was coming towards him, Jesus said to Philip, 'Where are we to buy bread so that we may eat?'" It may not seem like a relevant question, but why do you think Jesus asked Philip? If we think about it in the grand scheme of things, Philip is not one of the key individuals like Peter, James, and John are. Those are Jesus' inner circle. That's who he's usually talking and dialoguing

with. It's not that he never talks to Philip, of course not. But why is he talking to Philip in particular? And why is he talking about this question?

- 6.65** In the gospels, Matthew is said to have been a tax collector. Matthew understands the economic goings-on of what it might have even cost to buy bread. So if Jesus asked Matthew, we would have had some reasonableness to say that Matthew would have understood what bread would have cost in different geographical areas because he was trying to tax it. And so that makes sense. Judas had to have been in charge of the money bag. So, if Jesus had turned to Judas, Judas would have had an understanding of how much cash the disciples actually had on hand to buy bread.
- 6.66** Why is it that He asks who He does? Why is it that He asks Philip instead of asking some of these other individuals? Well, while the Gospel of John tells us the who, Luke says, "On their return, the apostles told Him all they had done, and He took them and withdrew apart to a town called Bethsaida. When the crowds learned it, they followed Him and He welcomed them and spoke to them of the kingdom of God and cured those who had need of healing." We're given the who, and Luke actually gives us the where. He says it's in the town called Bethsaida.
- 6.67** If we go back to John, we find that earlier in John, we have this statement: "So these came to Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee, and asked him, 'Sir, we wish to see Jesus.'" Now, is that interesting? John tells us that Philip is from Bethsaida. So why does Jesus ask Philip?
- 6.68** Philip was a local. He was from the actual region where this miracle takes place. And so it makes sense that he would have asked him. We have something going on here. Both John and Luke tell the same story. Luke doesn't mention Philip in the context at all, but Luke does tell us the location of the event. John doesn't mention Bethsaida as the setting of the miracle, but does tell us that is where Philip is from. So why did Jesus ask Philip? He was a local.
- 6.69** It's only by putting all of the gospels together that we understand the answer to the question of why Jesus asked Philip in John 6:5. John explains the many people traveling in Mark, and Luke explains the dialogue in John. Even the little detail in John that the boy has barley loaves fits nicely with the nearness of Passover, which immediately follows the barley harvest. This is what we refer to as an undesigned coincidence.
- 6.70** This is a note that none of these undesigned coincidences touch directly on the miracle of the feeding of the 5,000. One might therefore be inclined to claim that the setting was realistic, but the miracle was not.
- 6.71** The miracle, someone might argue, arose as the story was told from one person to another and was exaggerated, that the setting is historical, but the character of the narrative was developed into mythology. But the problem with treating the central part of the story, the miracle, as careless exaggeration, is that undesigned coincidences suggest careful transmission of periphery details. If transmission of the major elements

of the story has been careless, we should not expect the minor elements to be preserved as well.

- 6.72** That's not what we find in oral transmission. We find the first things to go are the details. Things like the grass was green, or the loaf of bread was barley, or there was much grass, or the coming and going. When we have the stories repeated over and over, these are the things that start to fall out of the story. So, if the transmission of the major elements of the story has been careless, we should not expect the minor elements to be preserved as well. The idea that the miracle account arose through careless exaggeration involves an unrealistic process of selective corruption of information in the story.
- 6.73** But let's dig further into the character, because I also want to note that we don't find these sorts of things, like undesigned coincidences, in some of these other gospels that are apocryphal from the later centuries.
- 6.74** All of the nonbiblical gospels fail because they can't validate themselves via this internal evidence. We don't find undesigned coincidences in the gospels that are attributed to Mary, to Thomas, to Peter, or to Judas, because those individuals were long dead, and the credibility of them being eyewitness testimonies is absent.
- 6.75** I want to expand upon this name thing because I talked a little bit about it in the previous lecture, when names don't match up. But there are some really interesting studies that have been done, even in the last couple of years, by individuals like Luuk van de Weghe, capitalizing on the research of Richard Bauckham and Tal Ilan that have looked at a number of different sources, specifically sources that we've already talked about, Josephus, ossuaries, and the Dead Sea Scrolls.
- 6.76** What they've done is by taking a certain time frame and looking at the most popular names in Galilee and Jewish-occupied Judea during this time, they came up with a list of the most popular names for males and females in this region, particularly Jewish names in Palestine. Because Jewish names in Palestine show different frequencies from names elsewhere. When we correspond that with something like the gospels, we find something interesting because we have evidence of what are called disambiguators.
- 6.77** If you look at this, "Simon called Peter"—this is a list of the disciples—"and Andrew, his brother, and James, the son of Zebedee, and John, his brother, Philip and Bartholomew, Thomas, and Matthew, the tax collector, James, the son of Alphaeus and Thaddaeus, Simon, the Canaanite, and Judas, Iscariot, who also betrayed Him." It's interesting if you look at the times when there are disambiguators, when there are qualifiers on their names, they correlate with the most popular names from that research.
- 6.78** Simon called Peter. Well, Simon is the most popular name in this list. Of course, you have it being top—you have it being qualified. If there are two Simons in the group,

which there actually are because you have Simon the Canaanite, also known as Simon the Zealot, you have to make sure you know which name you're talking about.

- 6.79** Andrew, his brother, is in the top 20. So is James, so is John. But Philip is a Greek name. Philip is a Greek name, and so it's a lot more uncommon, and so there's no need to disambiguate it. There's not a lot of Philips. It's a lot farther down on the list.
- 6.80** The same thing goes with Thaddaeus, another Greek name. But Judas is very high on that list. And so Judas is Iscariot who also betrayed Him. Every time we find a disambiguator, it correlates with the most popular names within this particular geographical region at this particular time. And when we don't find, it correlates with names that are not exclusively Gentile Greek names, but almost always Gentile Greek names that were just not as popular. And so we can look at this, once again, the title is onomastic congruence, and we can correlate it.
- 6.81** If we do this with some of the other gospels, for example, we find the opposite. We find that documents like the Gospel of Judas indicate names that are popular in fourth-century Egypt. Why is that? Well, it's because the Gospel of Judas is probably being written in the late third, early fourth century in Egypt. Not, as we see within the biblical gospels from Galilee, from the actual place that we find the correlative data. I think that indicates, in terms of the internal accuracy, something that we can go off of, that a fair-minded person should look at this and say, "Okay, there's something here in terms of early eyewitness information."
- 6.82** But what about external accuracy? This is the question, is what we have now what the original authors wrote? We talked a little bit about this with the textual reliability, but let's go a little bit further. To illustrate this, I want to pick on the King James Bible.
- 6.83** The King James Bible was translated between 1603 and 1611. It was produced, as I said previously, not on written, handwritten manuscripts, but on printed editions of the Hebrew Old Testament. I believe it's the 1541 Hebrew Bomberg text, and then, like I mentioned before, the five editions of Erasmus, and then Stephanus and Beza, with the editions of Erasmus being primary. The editions of Erasmus were based on approximately 31 manuscripts, the earliest of which went back to the eleventh century.
- 6.84** Now, there is some evidence actually that Erasmus actually attempted to correspond with an individual named Bombasius in Rome to have him look at a manuscript from the fourth century, Codex Vaticanus, in order to verify some of the readings that he was looking at. But it's not clear whether the communication actually was successful back and forth. But the earliest of the major manuscripts that Erasmus was looking at, go back to the eleventh century.
- 6.85** But we skip ahead to 2026, and we have 5,000 plus Greek manuscripts, along with being aware of what those 31 manuscripts were for the Greek New Testament that the King James translator's base text was relied on, the earliest of which go back to the second century, things like P52. It's not to say that the King James translation is

unreliable. It's not. In fact, it was for that day incredibly reliable based on the data it had, and it's still a pretty good translation, though we are able to expand upon that in our understanding of just more, both in terms of manuscript evidence and in terms of the linguistic development of how we understand particular words.

- 6.86** As time goes on, we're not getting farther away from the original text. We're actually getting closer because of archaeology, because of discoveries like P52, because of our availability to look at the manuscript tradition over the last 2,000 years and draw out having that confidence of finding the 100% in the 110%.
- 6.87** But let's go to a story that was attempted to be drawn out of me earlier. It's the story of this guy, Dr. Dirk Obbink. Dr. Dirk Obbink was the professor in the Faculty of Classics at Oxford University and the head of the Oxyrhynchus Papyri Project at one point. He was the big kahuna in his field. This was the guy. A few years ago, it came out that he had stolen manuscripts and was trying to sell them. He had stolen manuscripts in the Oxyrhynchus collection from Oxford University and was trying to basically black-market them. When this was discovered, and it came out that he specifically tried to sell this one manuscript, P137, from the Oxyrhynchus collection, it was very embarrassing for the Egypt Exploration Society. It really didn't look very good on them.
- 6.88** In order to remedy the situation, in 2019, they attempted to do an audit of what they had. In a statement that they put out on March 7, 2019, it said that "some twenty New Testament unedited manuscripts have been identified, and over eighty Septuagint and related texts are currently known to us and will be gradually assigned and published." This is interesting. They did an audit of what they had, and what did they find? They actually found that they had more manuscripts than they even actually realized.
- 6.89** Part of this is related to the question that was asked earlier in the Q&A, is that sometimes we have things that are in drawers that have just never been identified, cataloged, or overly comprehensively analyzed. In their attempt to really narrow down getting to what was and wasn't there to figure out—we have an instance of Dr. Obbink trying to sell one manuscript, how long has this been going? Not only did they discover manuscripts that were stolen, but they actually discovered quite a few manuscripts that they didn't even know about and are in the process, even to this day, of being published and being brought to the broader academic community. Publishing takes anywhere between five and seven years from discovery to publishing, so this takes time.
- 6.90** But what this means, as I mentioned earlier, is that the biblical manuscripts in the pipeline that have not been released to the public, and this is happening on a semi-regular basis, give us confidence to see that we are given more and more data. As more and more data is revealed, it doesn't undercut our understanding of the reliability of the New Testament. It confirms it; that between the first and fourth centuries, we have hundreds, if not thousands, of copies of the biblical documents being spread all over

the ancient world. This number only grows as Christianity is decriminalized in 313, the peace of the church in the fourth century.

- 6.91** This means that no one person or one group could ever have control of the text at any one point in time. When The Da Vinci Code wants to assert that Emperor Constantine was actually introducing concepts into the Bible, like the divinity of Christ, that's impossible because there were copies like P66 or P52 that were buried in the sands of Egypt hundreds of years before Constantine or anyone at the Council of Nicaea had been born. So did they dig them up and change them and put them back in the dirt? Very unlikely.
- 6.92** We actually have exact examples of attempts of this throughout history. There was a guy named Marcion in the second century. He was an individual who held that Jesus and the God of the Old Testament were separate gods. His sole aim was to separate the Christian tradition from Judaism. So he deliberately edited his text to remove Jewish references. He held to a, as far as we're aware, because we don't have his own writings, we only have writings condemning him, a heavily edited and redacted version of the Gospel of Luke and selected portions of 10 of the Pauline letters.
- 6.93** However, even if he wanted to, Marcion had no control of what his contemporaries were reading. So individuals like Irenaeus in Lyon, France, or Theophilus of Antioch in Turkey, or Clement of Alexandria in Egypt, or Tertullian in Carthage, what's modern-day Tunisia, were all copying and quoting and reading scripture.
- 6.94** Marcion could have never had the ability to control their copying and disseminating of the books. Anyone after this point would have had to have a level of power and control and systematic oversight of the biblical documents that were being copied, used, thrown out, buried, and reused across the ancient world, that it's just improbable to try to posit if they wanted to change things wholesale. It's just not realistic.
- 6.95** The nature of how widespread the independent text of the Bible had become by the second century meant that there were copies all over the ancient world, all over the empire. When Marcion touts his controlled, edited versions of said books, everyone picks up on it. No one's confused, and he's condemned for it. Right away, he's condemned for his teachings.
- 6.96** The caveat to this is that, in one sense, I would say that your English Bible has been changed. What I mean by that is something very different. Let me illustrate this to you by reading to you Psalm 23 from an English translation of the Bible that comes from the ninth century. Psalm 23 is a very well-known text. "The Lord is my shepherd, I shall not want. He makes me lie down in green pastures." But in an old English version, it reads like this: "Drihten me ræt: ne byð me nanes godes wan. And he me geset on swyðe good feohland, and fedde me be wætera staðum." That's English, right? But it's not an English that we recognize today. That's old English.

- 6.97** And so in one sense, your Bible has been changed, but it's been changed for the sake of clarity, not confusion. This is a good thing. Updates to Bible translations are useful because they allow us to update the language in order for it to actually be comprehensible, readable, and applicable.
- 6.98** I want modern English Bible translations that actually get me to that place. I think that's a good thing. I think that's a useful thing. Although I will say that "The Lord is my shepherd, I shall not want. He maketh me lie down in green pastures. He leadeth me beside still waters," still has, I think, a little bit more punch than "He lets me lie down in"—sometimes it's translated as "in green fields." I'm like, no, I want to lie down in a pasture. That sounds a little bit more calming. But updates to English Bible versions are good things. Change for the sake of clarity, not corruption. I think we can, in analyzing the data, say that there's a level of credibility.
- 6.99** What about character? Let's end on this. When we look at something like the accounts of Jesus' death, it's very interesting that the gospels are unanimous on Jesus' crucifixion and his death. They all have resurrection narratives, although some are a lot shorter than others. But there's this account of Pentecost that happens only a few weeks after Jesus' crucifixion. It's this Jewish festival. It's happening in Jerusalem. We have the city that Jesus was crucified in, having this festival, and we have the disciples going back to Jerusalem, preaching the message of the resurrected Christ a few weeks after His crucifixion and resurrection are said to have taken place.
- 6.100** But they're going to the scene of the crime to do this. Why would they go to the very place where people would have seen Jesus die in order to preach that He was resurrected? If there's some level of corruption or coercion or lying going on, don't go to the place where the guy you're trying to say rose from the dead died.
- 6.101** Go to the areas where people are unaware of that. Go to areas where it's a lot easier to not have people say, "Well, isn't He buried in Joseph of Arimathea's tomb? Why don't we just look?" It seems like there's an aspect of them going back and proclaiming this at ground zero that communicates that they actually believe it happened. That they actually encountered something that gave them the motivation and the confidence to then go back to Jerusalem, to the place where it all happened, and proclaim that message.
- 6.102** Not to mention that you have the martyrdom of Stephen as a warning shot for them. A little bit later on in Acts, their friend Stephen, proclaiming this gospel message, is stoned to death. Now, this is a warning shot across the bow. They now know that there is the chance of physical harm that's incorporated into their particular message.
- 6.103** And what do they do? Go, "I'm not on board with that. I'm okay with telling these stories, but my death?" No, they only become even more empowered. Despite knowing that there is physical harm involved in preaching this message, being ostracized, not only by Gentile communities, but also by Jewish communities, because they're saying

Jesus was the Messiah, that He is God incarnate, that He rose from the dead, validating Himself. This, I think, lends to a credibility aspect.

- 6.104** However, even taking the meta-story of the Bible as a whole, one of the most striking things about the Bible that really sets it apart from other religious texts is the honesty it conveys concerning its heroes. A primary theme of scripture is that the greatest individuals spoken about in and through its pages are broken and flawed.
- 6.105** Abraham was the father of a nation, and he was a liar. Jacob was the patriarch of Israel, and he stole his brother's birthright. Moses led the Jews out of captivity, and he was a murderer. David was the greatest king God's people had ever seen, and at the same time was a serial adulterer. Noah was said to be the only righteous person left on the earth, and he's a drunk. Peter was part of Jesus' inner circle, and when things got tough, he chose to deny he even knows Jesus. Paul, who's commissioned to write more holy scripture than any other New Testament figure before his Damascus road experience, was a legalist and a persecutor of Christians.
- 6.106** It's interesting that when you analyze ancient texts, religious or otherwise, they don't go to efforts to try to make the main people of the story look bad. And yet, that's what we continually find. We continually find that the kings and the prophets and God's chosen nation are rebellious and do wrong and fall morally pretty heavily. That's because the point isn't about any of those individuals in particular. It's pointing to the center point of the story, Jesus.
- 6.107** It's really interesting that even the Gospel of Mark, our earliest testimony from the ancient church, says that Mark was a traveling companion of Peter. If Mark is a traveling companion of Peter, the earliest eyewitnesses for who he is often communicate that he got his information from Peter firsthand and he wrote those things down. Well, Peter, in particular, in Mark's Gospel, is not portrayed really well. Isn't that interesting? All the early testimony says, "Mark wrote what Peter told him." And yet, Peter is an idiot. He's constantly misunderstanding Jesus. He's one of the "duh" ciples. He's not getting it.
- 6.108** It's an interesting fact, whether you're looking at religious literature or even just ancient chronicling accounts, you find that the biblical documents stand out in regards to the communication. You can trust the Bible. You can trust it because of its truthfulness, its credibility, and its character that it displays.
- 6.109** There is enough, I would argue, reasonable grounds to show that all of this should lead a fair-minded individual looking at the evidence to, at minimum, see that the narrative all leading up to the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus of Nazareth is not only intellectually credible, but is existentially satisfying, that it communicates to us what we see within leading and lending credibility to the internal evidence of the Bible being trustworthy. You've been very patient. Thank you so much for listening.

- 6.110** It sounds like you're building a probability model using multiple independent domains to point at a level of confidence. Are there areas where that confidence is low? What do you make of that?
- 6.111** I would say it depends on your presuppositions going into it. If you're going to say that the historical method cannot account for miracles because a miracle is something that is improbable, then that undercuts, may I say, some of the testimonial stories that are included within the gospels in particular. I think there's enough to say that the probability is high in my estimation.
- 6.112** But of course, you have individuals who would argue to the contrary. Individuals like Bart Ehrman, who I quoted a number of times, would say the opposite. He would say that he can't get on board with that and would point to certain aspects which might have a lower-level probability and likelihood.
- 6.113** The census in the beginning of Luke's Gospel is a trickier one historically. It is. It's not impossible to try to find a remedy for it, but you do have some things where you have to look very carefully at the data and actually make sure that things do line up because there seem to be some timeline issues in regards to the census that's called for getting Mary and Joseph to Bethlehem. So, it's not that everything is super clear all the time. There are some biblical narratives and passages that are harder to validate. I would say the census at the beginning of Luke is one of those.
- 6.114** Individuals often point to the lack of material that is available for something like the Exodus account in terms of archaeological evidence of such a large group leaving Egypt at that time. Now, I would say that actually, I think we do have some evidence, and I think that the evidence is actually decent. Once again, that's a very old story. We've lost so much in regards to the chronicling of Egypt to begin with.
- 6.115** But at the exact same time, though Egypt is really good for preserving documents in Upper Egypt, which ironically is lower down the Nile, in places like Oxyrhynchus or the Fayum, it's so arid that we do have just a lot more that's preserved. The areas in the region of Ramesses where the Exodus story is said to have taken place are far more humid.
- 6.116** The particular archaeological area up there is called, I believe it's Tell el-Dab'a in that particular region. The reason I know the particular archaeological area is because there was a library there. But though we know there was a library, the papyrus scrolls no longer exist. They've rotted, and the bindings on the papyrus scrolls are all [that's] left.
- 6.117** We know that there were scrolls. The scrolls have just rotted away because of the level of moisture in the air. But the writing's all gone, which is the opposite of what we find in places like Upper Egypt, where it's just so dry and arid, where the humidity in the Nile Delta causes other complications for written documentation. It's in a place in this area of like Ramesses and Tanis, where it makes sense that we wouldn't have any written record of things that took place.

- 6.118** Also, this is a very embarrassing story for the pharaoh. Like I said, we don't get stories of the failures of the pharaohs. We get stories of the victories of the pharaohs. And pharaohs tend to be very eager to make themselves sound better than the previous pharaohs. I believe Ramesses II is notorious for this, where he commissions so many statues of himself that they can't even keep up with the commissioning. If you go to Egypt today, you'll find statues of Ramesses that were not actually originally Ramesses because in order to keep up with the demand, they start repurposing statues of previous pharaohs and just putting the cartouche of his name. They scrap out the previous pharaoh and then put his name on it. This happens all the time.
- 6.119** Tutankhamun was a citation note in the list of pharaohs and thought to be a nobody until Howard Carter found Tutankhamun's tomb, and lo and behold, he's not a nobody. He's actually quite a rich pharaoh, but there was an effort to try to downplay him in the historical records of the pharaohs. I think there's evidence to the contrary to say that we do have good to say something like the Exodus did happen.
- 6.120** But I think I can see why people would say that there's an unlikeliness to that story in particular taking place. It's not that all stories are clear. I'm capitalizing on the clearest examples that I think give us confidence. That's not to say that there aren't foils to that, but I think there's enough of the stuff that we've looked at today that counterbalances the things that maybe there are bigger question marks or that we need to evaluate a little bit closer. Yeah, good question.
- 6.121** How reliable is genre? How do we determine what genre a book is? Is it historically accurate or more symbolism?
- 6.122** Yeah, good question. How do you delineate genre within a document? Genre is not exclusive, but more or less a modern category or a system. In ways that we parse out genre for something like the Old Testament, I don't think the ancient Jewish communities would have done that maybe in as clear-cut categories as we do today. Now, obviously, there's an aspect of history and poetry, but even what we call wisdom literature, that's more or less a modern category as opposed to an ancient category. There would have been more crossover in the ancient individual's mind with the poetic literature, the wisdom literature, those things.
- 6.123** It's really in attempting to look at what we see internally to derive what's going on. But there's blurry lines. Within some of the historical stuff that's written in the Book of Genesis, you run into then poetic. I mean, even in the Exodus story, all of a sudden, Miriam, the sister of Moses, breaks out in song, and you have a passage that is a song included in the historical narrative. You have poems that are included within the historical narrative.
- 6.124** I often give the example of in Canada, we have November 11. You have Remembrance Day, which remembers what took place in, particularly, although not limited to, the World Wars. There's a poem in Flanders Fields that we hear a lot of the time in and

around that time about a soldier in the fields of Flanders, where he talks about the poppies that grow between the graves of the soldiers. "In Flanders Fields, where poppies grow between the crosses row by row." Now, is that history or is that poetry? The answer is yes.

- 6.125** It happened. It's actually chronicling an actual event that took place in World War I. There were Canadian soldiers in Flanders Fields, and this individual was lamenting how many men had died. But he does it poetically. He talks about the days that they saw sunsets. That's poetic language, but does that disqualify it from being history? Does that mean they didn't see sunsets glow? No, they did.
- 6.126** So, I think there's a calibration that we have to do in understanding that sometimes there are blurry lines, and it's not always clear, set in stone, what genre something is or isn't.
- 6.127** At the exact same time, we do have to look at how literature operated within the ancient world. For a long time, the German rationalists looked at the gospels and said, "That can't be biography. It doesn't talk at all about Jesus' childhood, and it doesn't psychologize him." Because their thinking of biography was not an ancient thinking of biography, it was a modern thinking of biography. When they removed it from that category erroneously, they were doing so because they weren't actually looking at how biography operated within the ancient world. Sometimes the standards change to simply understand what's going on.
- 6.128** One of the clearest examples of comparative analysis of genre and the trickiness of it is Genesis chapter 1. What do we do with Genesis chapter 1 with the six days of creation? Because that can be read as chronological history, but it also has motifs that resemble other ancient Near Eastern origin stories in terms of making a point. If we compare Genesis chapter 1 with something like the Babylonian creation story of the Enuma Elish, we find that there appear to be lines within Genesis 1 that are rebutting some of these origin stories within ancient Mesopotamia.
- 6.129** Because the idea within something like the Enuma Elish is that you have this, the gods are fighting, there's this grand battle, and you have some gods fighting other gods, and then some gods die, and then the earth and the sky are made out of the remains of the gods, and then they decide, "Oh, we need a workforce." So, they take the remains of one of the dead gods, and they create humanity to be a slave race for them.
- 6.130** But ultimately, the conclusion of that, of the destruction of Tiamat and the creation of the heavens and the earth and animals, is that this is all a cosmic mistake. You're the end product of the gods that lost. In terms of purpose and meaning, it's up in the air. Also, some of the things that are out there in the universe, they are actually gods, the sun, the moon, the stars.
- 6.131** Genesis 1 starts "in the beginning God," and only God, and then actually describes things not created and not coming into existence in a purposeless manner, in a chaotic

manner. But God orders the chaos of the deep and says that everything is created good. It's good, it's good, it's good, it's good. At the very end for the thick people in the original audience, it says, "And it was very good."

- 6.132** Then he creates humanity, and He imparts humanity—God does—with His image, which, in the ancient world, there was an idea of certain individuals being created in the image of God, but it was almost exclusively kings. To say that all of humanity is created in the image of God, it's good. Creation is good. It's not actually evil. It's not actually the end result of a mistake. Some of those things that you worship, like the sun, actually, our God created them.
- 6.133** There's almost like an apologetic angle to Genesis 1. When we compare it with other ancient origin stories, because they're not really creation stories, because they assume that matter is eternal. But origin stories, and we look at something like Genesis 1, it is perfectly reasonable to read it as literal six-day creation. I think that there's merit for that.
- 6.134** There's also merit to say that the point may not be the mechanisms by which God creates things, and that there's an angle in saying, in the way that God created everything, it rebuts everything that the pagan nations around them think is truth. "You're foolish for believing in all that stuff. You're worshiping things that God, the creator of the universe, has actually created Himself. This is nonsense." It looks at the Enuma Elish or some of the other ancient origin stories and says, "Guys, you're missing the point."
- 6.135** But in extrapolating the genre, it helps us to understand, to look at, how do origin stories operate in the ancient Middle East? Then how does Genesis, as an ancient Near Eastern origin story, also play into the picture? Then that helps us to maybe, for one of the harder passages, genre-wise, to say there could be a number of genres going on here that are overlapping and it is perfectly reasonable to read in a number of different ways. Good question. Thank you.

Lecture 7: The English Bible

At a glance — The English Bible.

- 7.1 We've discussed the history of the Bible going back into antiquity. And what we're going to do with this first lecture is to talk about the modern Bible, how the English Bible, in particular, got into our hands and the history that goes along with that.
- 7.2 Because the Bible that we have in our hands in a modern English translation went through a long history in and of itself in the English language to get to where we have it in the available and readable translations that we hold.
- 7.3 The American journalist, Kurt Eichenwald, in a Newsweek article said, "No television preacher has ever read the Bible. At best, we've all read a bad translation, a translation of a translation of translations of hand-copied copies of copies of copies of copies and on and on hundreds of times."
- 7.4 Now, we can see at face value because we've already looked at things like the textual history of the Bible. There's a little bit of a straw man in that particular accusation. We don't have a translation of a translation of a translation. We go right back to the original languages, to the Greek and the Hebrew. It's not as if the Bible was translated into Latin and then translated from the Latin into a German and then from German into English, and that's how we got the Bible. That would be a translation of a translation of a translation.
- 7.5 What we have are translations with just one-to-one, going from the original languages into the modern English. But the question remains, why translate to begin with? What is the necessity of going and throughout the history of the church, getting the Bible into a language like English?
- 7.6 As we've talked about, even just briefly, the Bible has a long history of translation. In the 17th century, there was an individual who wrote a theological Latin treatise who said, "Translation is not only permitted and useful, but also entirely necessary, so that it may be understood, read, and heard by all people." Reformational training for pastors was summarized in these types of statements.
- 7.7 Part of the argument was that God gave the Old Testament in Hebrew, but then when it came to the New Testament, it was inspired in Greek, that it wasn't limited to a particular language. It was translanguage. It was translanguistic in that the word of God needed to be understood by all people in all times, in all places.
- 7.8 I've already mentioned previously my friend Mark Ward, who recently said, "God's people have encountered the Bible in translations for almost its entire existence. The very fact that God used Greek for the New Testament, a very different language than Hebrew, means that effectively everyone who has ever read the Bible has done so without the knowledge of a native speaker in its two major languages."

- 7.9** The Protestant reformers looked at the ancient tradition of Bible translation, getting it into the hands of the regular people who could understand it and said, not only can we translate the Bible, but we must translate the Bible for the sake of getting people, regular people understanding what God actually communicates to us. So, though this is a religious movement, it is a movement that we can track to show that these ancient texts are now readable and understandable texts that we have today.
- 7.10** So once again, we're going to be looking at a timeline, and we're going to be breaking things down. You have the earliest English Bibles in the 14th century, and then that leads up right into the 17th century in the Protestant reformational time. We've talked about the fact that there was this divide within the understanding during the Renaissance and the medieval period where prior to the reformers, there were even discussions about things like the canon of scripture.
- 7.11** There were individuals, even prior to the inception of Martin Luther in 1517, nailing his 95 theses on the door, who were having discussions about how the Bible should be understood. That's why we have individuals, what are referred to as humanists, though not humanists in the modern sense. The medieval humanists were individuals who sought to go back to the sources.
- 7.12** So, though they had the Latin Vulgate, and that was the official Bible of the Church, individuals like Erasmus were looking at how the Bible history had been available to them at that time and were going back to the Greek and the Hebrew. Though it was controversial, both the Complutensian Polyglot and Desiderius Erasmus, when he produces his Greek New Testament, do so largely in spite of knowing that that could lead to problems for them or even their own life. Both of them dedicate both of their volumes, independent of one another, to the pope in hopes that the pope would take the academic endeavor of creating a Greek New Testament as a complement, which he does. But there was a risk to that. So this isn't solely a Protestant reformational movement, though the Protestant reformers are the ones that eventually move the needle.
- 7.13** Martin Luther in 1530, says, "Inquire about this of the mother in the home, the children on the street, the common man in the marketplace. We must be guided by their language, the way they speak and are translating accordingly." In other words, Luther's endeavor was to develop a German translation of the Bible that was so understandable that it was analogous to the mother teaching their child on the carpet floor.
- 7.14** Luther did things like go out into the streets and talk to butchers when he was translating Leviticus to try to figure out, what is the just common parlance and vocabulary to talk about killing an animal? How would they use the terms that I'm looking at in the Hebrew to actually communicate what a killing of a lamb should be read as. Or he talked to a number of different skilled individuals, from carpenters to stonemasons, in order to get the understanding of, I want the translation to be understandable for the regular person, like a mother teaching their child.

- 7.15** William Tyndale, prior to Martin Luther, said, "I defy the Pope and all his laws. If God spare my life, ere many years, I will cause a boy that driveth the plow who shall know more of the scripture than the Pope doth."
- 7.16** Tyndale was very controversial in his day, but his motivation was one that he wanted regular people to be able to understand what the Bible actually said. Tyndale lived in a very interesting time period. We actually have records of audits from the Vatican at that time in the region that Tyndale lived to figure out how many Catholic priests could even read the Bible in Latin. The numbers are staggeringly low. In fact, when they ask questions like, "Can you, by memory, tell us the Ten Commandments?" A shocking number of priests could not do that. When they ask things like, "Who said the Lord's Prayer?" A shocking number of priests had no idea. Now, news flash, it's Jesus. But the reality is that there are certain things that were just not available in that day because of literacy levels.
- 7.17** Tyndale, studying at Oxford University, an incredible linguist, sees what's going on. He's reading the Bible in its original languages, and he knows just how influential, how powerful understanding the word of God in the vernacular can be. So, his motivation is that the regular boy in the field will be able to pick up the New Testament and be able to read it and understand it.
- 7.18** Obviously, you have some things that change between individuals like William Tyndale or John Wycliffe, who translate the Bible. Wycliffe is a little bit different, I do have to point out, because Wycliffe, although he comes up with the first comprehensive English translation, he's doing so from Latin. So Tyndale goes back to the Greek and Hebrew because he has that available to him. The Wycliffe translation is translated from the Latin because that was what was available to Wycliffe in the mid-14th century.
- 7.19** But things really start to change because of technological innovations, particularly Gutenberg and the printing press. The printing press changes the game because it changes the availability of literature to actually be produced and disseminated. That completely alters the way that things are spread. This is largely why the Protestant Reformation made moves. It wasn't that Martin Luther was the first person to start pushing back. Even on indulgences, there was an individual named Hus before even Luther, who was pushing back on indulgences. The Hussites were labeled as heretics.
- 7.20** But the reason why their movement didn't get traction to the same degree that Luther's did largely has to do with the fact that Luther's writings were picked up and they were printed. Because of the availability of the printing press and the fact that more people on average were reading or learning to read, and the availability of written material was just increasing, that changes the game.
- 7.21** Now, interestingly enough, Gutenberg died largely poor and never saw the rise of his actual invention, largely because he couldn't—though he was printing things and

getting literature out there, the level of literacy was so low during his day that there was just no market for it.

7.22 When we look at Tyndale's Bible, though, Tyndale was interesting because the way that Tyndale translated the vernacular actually influenced the English language as a whole. There are words that we know today that we might not even realize were coined by Tyndale in his translation of them from the Bible. Terms like "ungodly," "scapegoat." He even coined the term "passover" for the Jewish festival of Pascha. Phrases coined or invented by Tyndale like, "Let there be light." "Am I my brother's keeper?" "The salt of the earth." "Fight the good fight," or "the writing on the wall." These are terms that were used by Tyndale in his rendering of the Greek and the Hebrew that we now just use as turns of phrase. But it's largely because of Tyndale.

7.23 Now, I also want to note that the Bible was influencing language even before something like the availability of the King James translation. I'll talk a little bit more about that later. But we do have writings like this one. This is the last letter.

7.24 Just to back up, Tyndale is put on trial. Tyndale is put on trial because he is advocating for things like getting the Bible in the vernacular. He's also advocating that they shouldn't kill heretics. They should reason with them in order to change their minds. At the time, this seems like a bridge too far for the Roman Catholic Church. So they decide, "No, we're going to kill you."

7.25 But we actually have his last writing. He's in Brussels. He's been in exile. He's awaiting his sentencing. He knows he's going to die. They're going to kill him. Before he's hanged and then burned, he writes a letter that we have from when he was in prison. He says this, "On which account I beseech your lordship,"—he's probably writing to the governor of the particular area that he's being imprisoned in— "that if I am to pass the winter here, to urge upon the Lord commissary, if you will deign, to send me from my goods in his keeping a warmer cap, a warmer coat, also cloth for repairing my leggings, I also ask for a leave to use a lamp in the evening, for it is tiresome to sit alone in the dark.

7.26 "But above all, I beg and entreat your clemency earnestly to intercede with the Lord commissary that he would deign to allow me the use of my Hebrew Bible, Hebrew grammar, and Hebrew lexicon, and that I might employ my time with that study." He's going to die. He knows it. He's basically just waiting for the execution. His last ask is, "I want my Hebrew study resources." Because at this time, he's finished the New Testament, but he's desperately trying to get as much of the Old Testament translated as he possibly could. I think it's very inspiring that his needs are partly physical, he's cold, but also he's saying, "I want to finish this. I want to get the Bible into the hands of the people so badly that my last ask is to give me my linguistic resources in order to translate."

- 7.27** By 1526, we have Tyndale's version that's produced. He's killed in the 1530s, but he doesn't finish his work. He produces the entirety of the New Testament, but he doesn't get very far into the Old Testament. There's another individual who goes by a pseudonym of Matthew, who ends up actually finishing Tyndale's work. That's now today known as the Matthew Tyndale Bible. He knows that this is a costly endeavor, so he doesn't reveal his real name, but he picks up the mantle, the torch that Tyndale leaves in order to finish the work. He does finish the Old Testament, and then he carries on with the translational work that Tyndale had used, and that comes out only a year after Tyndale is put to death. We get the Matthew Tyndale Bible.
- 7.28** Now, interestingly enough, this is the first page, the introduction page of the Matthew Tyndale Bible. Matthew has a picture of the king of England handing the Bible to the people. That's interesting, isn't it? Because he still believes that there's a chance that if he honors the king with saying that the king has the opportunity to give the word of God in its vernacular to the people, and he expresses that in the woodcut that's actually found in the beginning of the Bible, they're still not happy with what's going on with the persecution of translation, but they're still hopeful.
- 7.29** The famous line by Hus, which, by the way, John Hus, Hus means "goose" in [Czech]. As he dies, about 100 years before Luther, he makes the famous line, "Cook this goose and a swan will rise up in my place." Luther is often called the swan of the Reformation because there's the play on the words, you're cooking this goose, this Hus, but he believes other people will take up the mantle of what goes on.
- 7.30** And so there's still an endeavor to influence the powers that be. Tyndale is said to have said when he was being strangled to death, to lift up his eyes to heaven and to pray, "Lord God, change the mind of the king of England." Now, interestingly enough, it's about 100 years after that that the King James Bible is actually commissioned. So prophetic, maybe, but he has the desire for that.
- 7.31** If we go forward from some of the earlier translations, Bible translation, though, it has always been controversial, didn't stop with individuals like Tyndale and Matthew. In 1539, we have the Great Bible. In 1537, we have the Thomas Matthews Bible. In 1535, we have the Miles Coverdale and then the Bishop's Bible and the Geneva Bible.
- 7.32** Then at a certain point, the Roman Catholics concede and they say, "Everyone is reading these translations of the Bible, but they're all Protestant Bibles. We might as well, if we can't beat them, let's join them." They eventually produce an official translation of the Bible in English, which still exists today, the Douay-Rheims Bible, which has its first production in 1582, which is a translation of the Latin Vulgate, specifically not the Greek and the Hebrew.
- 7.33** So, Bible translation has always been controversial because translation requires interpretation. That was one of the major pushbacks on the whole endeavor of translating the Bible. One of the things that the Hussites were accused of in their

endeavors to translate the Bible, or that Tyndale was accused of in his efforts to translate the Bible, is that people will start interpreting the Bible outside of what the priest tells them to believe. That was actually the way that they worded it.

- 7.34** This is what today we might think, yes, people would start reading the Bible and interpreting it and not being influenced by what people tell them they should believe rather than what they can actually glean from the text. But this was controversial in that day. They didn't want the people to be able to do that. They didn't want the people either to be able to see some of the maybe influences that the church was having in the doctrine and the dogma of things like purgatory and things like we talked about previously with the indulgences. There was a lot of proof-texting going on for the indulgences.
- 7.35** One thing that stood out to Luther early on in his reading of the Greek New Testament—he's actually said to have been reading the second edition of Erasmus's Greek New Testament—and notices that the Greek has the word in Matthew's Gospel that's translated in the Latin as do penance, but in the Greek, it's repentance.
- 7.36** So, there's a debate as to whether the word poenitentiam agite in Latin meant do penance in the way that it developed within the Middle Ages or not. In Jerome's day, it could have had more of a connotation of repentance. But by the time you get to the Middle Ages, that particular phraseology is being used, it's being utilized by the Catholic Church to say you need to do penance for the forgiveness of sins. You need to act, particularly in doing things like giving alms to the church or in self-flagellation, those kinds of outward acts of penance. Martin Luther reads Matthew's Gospel and he sees, no, the word is metanoieite, it's repentance. That actually starts to have the cogs moving in thinking, maybe what we've been told on all these things isn't exactly what's going on.
- 7.37** Interestingly enough, when Erasmus produces his diglot, his Latin on one side and his Greek on the other, he changes that word to a different Latin word which more reflects repentance than do penance. So he starts controversially even changing the Latin Vulgate to his own version of the Erasmian Latin that he prints, simply because he also picks up on some of these things that the words have changed in their meaning.
- 7.38** Does anybody happen to know where Shakespeare falls on this timeline? Between 1550 and 1575, you have a number of different Bibles. Does anybody know when Shakespeare comes around? He's between 1564 and 1616. And there are Bible quotes in Shakespeare. But this is prior to the production and dissemination of the King James Bible. So what is being quoted in Shakespeare is not the King James Bible, but is the Geneva Bible, and is the 1560 Geneva Bible, specifically. So certain phrases that you'll find in Shakespeare and plays, which are allusions or quotations of scripture, are not King James English as much as they are Geneva Bible English. Still very much the Elizabethan English of the day, that early modern English.

- 7.39 But it's also pertinent to know that the King James Bible wasn't a translation wholesale. It wasn't necessarily that the King James translators were going back to the Greek and the Hebrew, though they were, as much as they were looking at the Bibles in their own day and they were producing updates.
- 7.40 In this 1560 translation of the Geneva Bible, we actually have for this particular Bible certain words that are crossed out and certain words that are changed in the text, and then commentary notes on the side, because this particular Geneva Bible that I've taken a picture of was one that the King James translators actually used. If you read some of the King James translators' own notes, they say specifically, "We are not trying to make a bad translation good. We are trying to make a good translation better."
- 7.41 Once they get that commissioning by King James to actually put together a state-sponsored Bible, they go through the process of actually attempting to update some of maybe the translational choices, the verbiage, and the wording of the Geneva Bible. So, the King James is not a production wholesale. It's actually an update to the previous Geneva Bible.
- 7.42 Part of the problem that, say, the Church of England and the state had with some of these previous translations was the fact that something like the Geneva Bible was the first study Bible, and that not only did it provide translations, but it was produced in Geneva, Switzerland, which was the hotbed of reformed Calvinism. So, a lot of the notes, the commentary that were written by the producers of the Geneva Bible were Calvinists who were writing extensive, theologically reformed notes in the margins.
- 7.43 This bothered some people in the Church of England, and it bothered King James. They were looking at that and they wanted what they referred to as a cleaner, more pure Bible translation where people just read the text and weren't influenced by the commentator's notes. That's one of the major reasons why the King James translation, although not was produced, was to render a text that would be read by people that wasn't influencing them by the commentary notes, theologically influencing them for a particular angle on how you read the Bible.
- 7.44 I mean, there were other things. There were certain things within the Old Testament that talked about not following the tyranny of kings, that King James also had a problem with and actually asked very kindly—although he didn't have the control wholesale to influence—asked very kindly for maybe those to be downplayed in the translation a little bit. Passages in the Old Testament talk about the king's influence being barbaric. In an era where the divine right of kings was still understood as they have that given to them by God, James was looking at things like the Great Bible, the Geneva Bible, and still being a little bit uncomfortable with how transparent the text was for holding the leaders accountable.
- 7.45 But you can see there, this is the page of the first chapter of Genesis with both a 1602 Bishops' Bible and then the King James on the left, and you see more of those notes in

the margins of how the King James translators were attempting to change things for, as they argued, the better.

- 7.46** There were actually quite a few Puritans who were on the side of maybe even the study notes of the Geneva Bible who were part of the approximately [50]- individual commission. That number fluctuates because the Bible is translated between 1604 and 1611. So, people die, people are subbed in, and the translation committee ebbs and flows. But approximately [50] individuals, some of which were also Puritan scholars as a concession by the king in order to bring them and get them involved so that they also would be happy.
- 7.47** Of course, that didn't please everybody. The first Bibles that were brought over to North America on the Mayflower were Geneva Bibles, specifically because they were Puritans who were fleeing the persecution in Europe and England, specifically. And they saw the King James Bible still as a state-sponsored Bible. It was a Bible that was commissioned specifically from the King, and they were uncomfortable with that. There were numerous Geneva Bibles that were brought over from the old world into the new world. There was one King James Bible that obviously there was someone who was a dissenter that was brought over on the Mayflower.
- 7.48** But even on the anniversary of the United States of America, one thing that's being put on display in Washington, DC, is a number of Geneva Bibles. The reason for that is because that was actually the Bible that was brought over by the Puritans, by the individuals who came over and founded some of that colony.
- 7.49** Interestingly enough, also, if we look at the King James translators' own words, we find that the King James translators were very keen on rendering the language in as understandable a way as possible. And in the introduction to the King James Bible, in a section called the Translators to the Reader, the author of that particular document specifically says, "As language changes, so too does the word of God need to change." Not change as in changing the actual meaning of the text, but changing in what we've seen before: changing for the sake of clarity, changing for the sake of actually being understood. And so, though there are groups today that might advocate for a King James Bible only position, the King James translators would not be King James only. And they expressly say so.
- 7.50** They even say in the Translators to the Reader, by using the example of the King's speech, that when the King's speech is translated into German, it still remains the King's speech. Even, they say, if it's a poor translation of the King's speech. In that way, they say that even a meager translation, meaning not the best translation of the word of God is still the word of God. It might not be the best rendering of the text, but they have this understanding that translation is important and translation is necessary, and translation needs to adapt. But once again, they say, "We do not desire to make out of a bad Bible a good Bible, but to take a good Bible and make it better."

- 7.51** Now, we talked about textual differences that happen within, say, the Greek and the Hebrew. That doesn't stop when things are printed. There are some very interesting examples of this. In 1631, there's a Bible that's known as the Wicked Bible. One of the reasons for this was that the printer for this particular production in 1631, at the Ten Commandments, forgot to put the word "not" in "thou shalt not commit adultery," resulting in a text that says, "Thou shalt commit adultery." Now, there are actually two mistakes in the Wicked Bible. Another one, it says that—it has a mistype where it calls God an ass. That has more of a vulgarity to it today than it did back then. It meant a donkey then, but it's still—you don't call God an ass.
- 7.52** I believe that the printer was put in prison for this particular mistake. But these are very desirable collector's items. I know two individuals who have Wicked Bibles. One of them is on display at the Museum of the Bible in Washington, DC. But they tried to, once they figured this out, destroy as many of these as they possibly could. So they're collector's items today. But all that to say, the issue with mistakes that creep into the text, it doesn't stop when we stop handwriting things. Mistakes still happen. We have numerous examples of this, the biggest examples being those like the Wicked Bibles.
- 7.53** We also have words not just that were coined by Tyndale, but were coined by the King James translators themselves. "A man after his own heart" is a phraseology that was coined by the King James translators. "Thorn in the flesh," "apple of my eye," "at their wit's end," "eye for an eye," "give up the ghost," "holier than thou," "skin of my teeth," and "out of the mouth of babes," are all translation choices by the King James translators. We recognize many of those today as the vernacular of something like English Bible translations has just influenced who we are.
- 7.54** But in looking at the history, we also grant that there are modern Bible translations. They didn't stop with the King James translation. Just as the King James translation was an update from previous English translations, that's true for a lot of the modern English translations today. The Revised or American Standard Version that was one of the more modern Bibles in the 19th century was a revision of the King James Bible. That was part of it. Now, later on, you do get the New King James Version, which comes around in the early '80s, but those are largely updates of the King James.
- 7.55** Interestingly enough, about 70% of the original 1611 King James is Tyndale's text, particularly in the New Testament. That's how influential Tyndale was, is that often the King James translators would just defer to Tyndale because he was such a good linguist. They might update the language, but they would divert to Tyndale because of how good he was, as a linguist, deriving the text.
- 7.56** But we have all sorts of Bible translations today. The New American Standard Bible, the New International Version, and the New King James Version, once again, are all updates to largely the King James Version. New Revised Standard, the ESV, the Holman Christian Bible, which now is just the CSB. They've dropped the publisher's name at the beginning. Then some of the newer ones like the New International Version, and then

the English Standard Version being at least the most recent one that I'm aware of with their 2025 update.

- 7.57** These Bibles are updated. Even then, the translation committees go back and they look at something like the ESV, the English Standard Version, when it was produced in 2001, and they update certain aspects of the text. Often, with a little bit of controversy, but that happens quite frequently.
- 7.58** I think it's a good thing. I think it is, on the whole, an ability and an endeavor by these translation committees, which are made up of men and women who are seeking to be honest and authentic with the text to be able to just simply make it understandable in our day.
- 7.59** But we could ask the question, why so many? Why do we have so many English Bibles? Why not just stick with a Revised Standard Version or a New International Version or an English Standard Version? I mean, it's literally called the English Standard Version. Why then do we continue to have so many translations?
- 7.60** A big part of that is translation philosophy. We talked a little bit about this previously. You have the ideas of a formal versus a functional translation, the way that you're going to render the text. It plays into the conversation in terms of its readability, what you want a Bible to be, how you want that Bible to be read and understood. Is it for study, an academic endeavor, or is this a devotional religious text? We also have the manuscript discoveries. We've talked about that with both the Old and the New Testament.
- 7.61** As we learn more about the text of the Bible with the evidence that we're given, that helps us understand things like that there are certain passages that maybe weren't original that we thought were.
- 7.62** I mentioned previously, when we talked about the text of the New Testament, that scribes are very insistent on keeping the text to the point where they will add things just in case it is part of the original. They want to be so sure that they're far more likely to add something, than take it out. Because of the breadth of the manuscripts that we're able to see, we can pinpoint when those things are.
- 7.63** Remember, the chapters and verses that are in modern Bibles are a later construct. The chapters come around in the Middle Ages, and then the verses come around in the 17th century as the standard verses that all the Bibles we have today have agreed upon using. Though, later artificial constructs, those are good things. There's a reason why, when I say John 3:16, you might all know what that is. It's because we've all agreed that John 3:16 is, "For God to love the world, that he gave his only begotten son." We all know that verse because of the standardization of it.
- 7.64** But what do we do when we find out that there's a particular text that maybe made its way into the King James Bible that wasn't originally there because of the manuscript

evidence? Do we reorder all of the verses in the Bible? Now, you think John 3:16 is John 3:16, but actually mine is John 3:14 or something like that. Well, no, we don't do that. What we do is we simply go, John 3:15, John 3:17, and then there's usually a citation note at the bottom of the page that explains how John 3:16 actually said this. We're using this as an example. John 3:16 is authentic and original.

- 7.65** But we have examples of this. John 5:4 is one of these key examples of a critical missing verse in the Bible. You have this story of the healing at this pool in the temple colonnade, the healing of the lame man. There's a pool that is said to have an angel stir up the waters, and all these sick and disabled people would try to run into the water and be the first to enter into what was believed to be an angel stirring the water, and then they were said to have been healed. And so there was this mad dash there.
- 7.66** But the explanation for that in John 5:4 was almost certainly a commentary in the margin of a Greek manuscript, probably in the fourth century. Well, the scribe sees that, reads it, and thinks, "I don't know if this was original to John, or it's a commentary by this particular scribe. It's clearly telling me what's going on in the text. It's explanatory." So, to be safe, he includes it, and it makes its way into the text, and it makes its way into the majority of manuscripts throughout the Middle Ages, and it makes its way into the King James Bible.
- 7.67** We know, based on the manuscript tradition, that John 5:4 was not original to John. We know that now. So, if you open up an NIV or an ESV or an NASB and you look at that, it's going to miss John 5:4. Now, it's not actually going to be missing. It's going to be at the bottom of your page. It would tell you why it skips a verse. But part of that is that these manuscript discoveries help us understand what is authentic to the text. This doesn't undercut our confidence in the text because we know these things.
- 7.68** Actually, for a lot of them, we've known for a long time. Scribes have done things like put asterisks in the margins all throughout the Middle Ages and say, "You know, this John 5:4 thing, we've got to be a little bit hesitant about this one because it's clearly been an addition." We see those types of things throughout the manuscript tradition.
- 7.69** We also, because of our expanding understanding of languages, are able to grow in how we understand particular words or phrases. There were words in the 17th century that we didn't know what they meant, and so we would transliterate them. One of my favorite examples of these is [1] Chronicles 26:18. In the King James Bible, it said, "Parbar westward, [four] at the causeway, and two at parbar." What on earth is a parbar? Well, the King James translators didn't know either. They translated the Hebrew word parbar with the English letters parbar, and they just left it. Now, because of our expansion of Semitic languages, we know that a parbar is a court. So, if you open up a New International Version, it will say something like, "As for the court to the West, there were two at the court and two at the road, four at the road itself."

- 7.70** It's the understanding of a language. That's not a fault of the King James translators. It wasn't a mistake by them. They were actually doing their due diligence and saying, "We're not sure about this." There are even words that we still have in the Bible, like *selah*. We don't really know what *selah* means. If you read the Psalms, you'll run into, in the margins often, this word *selah*. We think, based on a pretty good, estimated guess, that it has something to do with a musical notation, like a stop or a pause. But we don't actually know. It's one of these words that appears in the Hebrew Bible. But outside of that, there's very little understanding in comparative Semitic typology or etymology. So what do we do? We have the word "*selah*" in English. Those types of things happen, but that has been whittled down considerably because of things like the manuscript discoveries.
- 7.71** Also, theological concerns. Something like the King James translation, there was a theological concern by the Church of England at the time. There was a theological concern because they didn't necessarily want people to be as informed by the Genevan Calvinists as they thought they ought to be. So, the translation largely is produced for that particular reason—I have theological concerns twice. That's interesting. Textual variance in my presentation.
- 7.72** Also, changes in English. We've talked about these. The changes in English wording. The word "*gay*" is in the King James translation. Well, "*gay*" does not mean what it meant in Elizabethan English. In James, it says that we need to avoid the superfluity of naughtiness. Interesting phraseology, but if I read that, I may or may not understand what the superfluity of naughtiness actually is. How do I avoid that in my life if I don't even know if I'm being superfluity-ing naughtily?
- 7.73** Then the last one is a little bit of a controversial one, but it exists, is money. One of the reasons why we have so many English translations is because of copyright. There's only a certain amount of verses that you can publish in, say, if you're writing a book from a particular translation, before you have to start giving money to the publisher. This is a non-popular one, but it is the reality of the world we live in. So, if you're going to produce a work and you want to cite extensively from the New International Version, you may very well have to throw some money at Zondervan. Or if you want to quote the English Standard Version, you might need to give Crossway a call.
- 7.74** These publishers who own these rights to these things have legal stipulations about how much of their verses you're actually able to put in your publication. So, sometimes we get Bible translations where a publisher says, "Well, I want my authors to actually write and use Bible passages as often as they want. So let's produce a Bible translation." Sometimes, unfortunately, that is what happens.
- 7.75** Now, we've already talked about the translation spectrum of the formal versus functional equivalence, the thought for thought versus word for—I should stipulate that while this is a reality and while most of the translations that you think of fall on this continuum, like we said previously, not every translation can be formal in its

totality or functional within its totality. This will change from testament to testament, from book to book, even at times from chapter to chapter and verse to verse, just because of the sake of functionality within the text.

- 7.76** Also, not every Bible translation is created equal. There are good translations, there are poor translations, and then there are really, really bad English translations. I generally would say that the available translations that we think of in terms of the ones that I've been referencing, the modern mainstream translations like the Revised Standard Version, the English Standard Version, the New International Version, those are good translations, but they're produced by translation committees on purpose in order to have no one individual's bias be overtly present in the translation choices of the text. For that reason, sectarian translations that are sometimes just done by one person, I would not recommend that people actually use because the chances of a particular bias are just too strong to be actually creeping into the text. Do not read the Wes Huff translation if it ever comes out. I'm just putting that out there.
- 7.77** Then there are particular groups that have come up with their own translations in order to bake their own theological presuppositions into the text. The most overt examples of these would be the Jehovah's Witnesses' New World Translation, which actually is not a terrible translation across the board, except for all the times that refer to the personhood of the Holy Spirit or the divinity of Christ, and then their translational philosophy goes out the window, and they need to translate things differently because their theological system takes precedent over and above the actual exegetical or linguistic, a faithful, rendering of the text.
- 7.78** So, there are good translations, there are bad translations, and then there are very, very bad translations. Then there, of course, there are paraphrases, which in some sense, yes, it's a translation because it's rendering the text from a previous language into a new language, but it's not really a translation per se. It's an attempt to extrapolate and literally paraphrase on the text.
- 7.79** When people ask me, I would generally say that some people are really against paraphrases. I'm not. I think they can be helpful, but they're like a supplement. They're like a supplement to the genuinely good translations that we have out there. Something like the New International Version is aiming at a fifth-grade reading level.
- 7.80** The endeavors of Zondervan and Bibliotheca with the production of the New International Version, one of their motivations in one of their most recent updates was, can we produce a text for people whose English is their second language that is readable and understandable? In that sense, the argument for paraphrases, I think, is almost unnecessary when we have English translations that are already aiming to be as understandable as well as be faithful when we're rendering the original text.
- 7.81** I mentioned this one yesterday when we were talking. In Exodus 34:6, you have this passage where Moses is on the mountain and he says, "Yahweh, Yahweh, a God

merciful and gracious, abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness and long of nose." This being the example of this is a very literalistic translation. Nobody translates it as long of nose because that simply doesn't make sense. But we understand that this is an idiom, and we understand that because of our understanding of the Semitic language more broadly, we have comparative idioms in other Semitic languages like Akkadian and Aramaic that parallel this. No translation is going to be as thought for thought or as word for word, no matter how attempting they're trying to make that out.

7.82 Now, an interesting quote from Martin Luther here. In stipulating his translation, he said, "I want to make Moses so German that no one would suspect he was a Jew." Now, that can sound controversial, right? Especially because some of Martin Luther's later writings were actually incredibly anti-Semitic. But what he's getting there is less, "I don't want Martin Luther to sound Jewish," and more, "I want him to be so understandable that the jargon of what might come across in the text as ancient Hebrew comes across understandably and phonetically as German." It sounds like a controversial quote. We can maybe take it out of context to proof-text more of Martin Luther's anti-Semitism. I don't think we need to do that. There's lots of other overt things that we can point to.

7.83 But in his translational choice and understanding, I think there's an aspect of this, a kernel of this, that I would want to, likewise, incorporate in how I communicate the Bible. Not that I want to erase the Jewishness of Moses. Of course not. I would want people to understand who Moses was in his cultural context. But I want him to be as understandable as possible so that when I read something like long of nose, I can render it as slow to anger and that be understandable outside of knowing what the Jewish idiom and the Hebraic understanding actually is.

7.84 Once again, so we see the updates, something like Psalm 23 and how the English language changes. This is good. This is a good thing for the English Bible: changed for the sake of clarity, not for corruption. I think that's important. And so, just like the rest of the text of the Bible has a long linguistic history in both its original languages, Greek and Hebrew, the English Bible has also had a long history, and we find ourselves down the timeline in a place where we have the availability of the English translation so readily available that it's almost confusing as to which translation we should choose.

7.85 When someone asks me, "Wes, what translation is the most accurate translation?" It's a trick question. It's a trick question because we have so many good English translations that it's less of a matter of what is the most accurate or best or closest rendering of the original languages, and it's more, what are you trying to get out of reading the Bible? Are you trying to study the Bible? Are you trying to do spiritual devotion from the Bible? Are you trying to teach the Bible? Are you trying to—all of these things factor in.

7.86 Now, there's overlap. Sometimes the answers to those particular desires for a Bible translation are going to be the same Bible, and that's okay. But I personally take a

multi-translational approach because I think that that best suits how to understand what the actual text communicates to us. It helps us.

- 7.87** There's a reason why the English language has changed, and we're not reading the Psalms and looking at something like, "Drihten me ræt: ne byð me nanas godes wan," and we are seeing, "The Lord is my shepherd, I shall not want." I think that's a good thing. We have the benefit, we have the blessing in the English language to have the availability of it today that we do, acknowledging that we stand on the backs of a lot of people who lost their lives, for getting the Bible to us today.
- 7.88** The Hussites were killed and hunted for their entire lives, almost, for trying to get the Bible into the English language. So was William Tyndale, although he was put on trial for heresy by the Catholic Church and not necessarily for translating the Bible. If you look at the history of that, the reason why he was on the run his entire life was because he was doing something like trying to translate the Bible. Because of the availability of printing and because of the availability of the fact that we can stand a few centuries down the road from these people, we can now go on Amazon and have our own pick of the Bible, any Bible that we want. That's an incredible blessing of what we have.
- 7.89** Hopefully, that gives a snapshot of the English Bible, a long history, but a very fun and interesting one in the grand scheme of talking about the Bible as a whole. Thank you very much.
- 7.90** Yes, my question is about contemporary translations into other languages. At the Museum of the Bible in DC, on the same floor as the Wicked Bible, there's a circular room that shows active translations in other languages throughout the world. I was surprised by how few languages are complete. Is there a leading translation or a standardized practice for what Bible is being translated into those other languages?
- 7.91** What Bible is being translated? Yeah, so typically translators will go from the original languages. It's less of a matter of we're trying to take the English NIV and make it into Swahili—there isn't an active Bible translation in Swahili, so this is just an example.
- 7.92** This is often the confusion when people talk about translation of translation of translations, assuming that that's how we got the English Bible, is that groups like, whether it's Wycliffe Bible translators or others, are being trained in the original languages, in the Greek and the Hebrew. They use things like, so I mentioned the different numbers of critical editions of the published Greek New Testament that we have. The United Bible [Societies] produces one that's specifically used for Bible translators in order to—the textual notes that they provide in the textual apparatus at the bottom of the text is curated for understanding where the relevant differences might be in regards to Bible translation, specifically, less for academic interest and study, and more for Bible translation, specifically.
- 7.93** That number in that room at the Museum of the Bible in the goal of getting Bibles in every language in the world has actually shrunk considerably in the last few years. I

think they just celebrated, there was an event that they held in Washington, DC, because there were more Bible translations available than not. The number has gotten considerably smaller, but the Bible is still illegal to be translated in a number of countries around the world. So, Bible translators are working in the underground communities to actually get the Bible in certain languages.

- 7.94** But yeah, to answer your question specifically, it's not translated with the desire to, how do we get something that looks like the NIV into this particular language, but how do we best render the text?
- 7.95** And there are interesting decisions that need to be made. I once listened to a lecture by one of the individuals, years and years ago, a couple of decades ago, who was rendering the Bible into this indigenous Peruvian language. They have to make decisions like: for someone who has never seen a sheep, how do we then communicate this? These are translation questions that even go broader. Do we say that your sins are as white as alpaca fur? Does that communicate the same thing as wool? Or for a group that's never seen snow before, that God washes us as white as snow. What do we do there?
- 7.96** So, sometimes the questions are less, how do we render the text most accurately and go into the realm of what are the things that we even maybe need to replace or understandability, but they don't get us into the danger of actually communicating something that shouldn't be. Those are legitimate concerns that Bible translators wrestle with because there are certain cultures that maybe have never seen a sheep or a donkey. Jesus rides into Jerusalem, the triumphal entry on a donkey. What if you've never seen a donkey before? What do you think Jesus is riding on?
- 7.97** This is interesting if you look at depictions in the Middle Ages of certain animals. When it's clear that nobody has ever seen a whale, when they paint whales, they look like giant sea monsters. Or throughout the Middle Ages, lions were often depicted as big dogs because nobody had ever seen a lion. They had no frame of reference for what that is. So, there are some very strange animal paintings throughout the Middle Ages where it's very clear that this person has never seen that animal. They have no frame of reference to be able to figure out what that is.
- 7.98** When we're talking about Bible translation, what do we do if you've never seen a donkey? Do you still call it a donkey? Maybe, but that might not actually best serve the audience of who you're trying to translate for. In attempting to render the original languages, sometimes you run into issues like that as well. Yeah, good question.
- 7.99** You talked about previously certain translations influencing imagery with Moses with the horns. I think it was Mary with her heel on the serpent. Are there any other instances where the misleading of the translation has influenced imagery or iconography?

- 7.100** I gave the most obvious examples that I could think of. None that come to mind. You do get a lot of depictions throughout the Middle Ages of Hell that take on a lot of the literalistic imagery of fire and torment that also bake into the text some understandings of Greek writings of Hades. But I think those are actually, though there are some stark examples, like Moses being horned, I think those are actually relatively few in terms of the potential misleading categories of how Bible translation comes across.
- 7.101** I'm trying to think of the verbiage and wording, not necessarily in depiction, but in the English language, the word for "love" in Middle English was "charity." That influenced certain things, verses like, "Charity covers over a great deal of sins." Well, when the word "love" actually does develop in the English language, now, if you're reading "charity," but now "charity" in the English language has evolved to mean specifically giving things to people, how we would understand "charity." And now someone is arguing that charity covers over a great deal of sins, that could influence you in terms of your faith and practice. We have examples of things like that. But in terms of iconography and imagery, not too many more come to mind.

Lecture 8: The Historical Jesus

At a glance — The historical Jesus.

- 8.1 We've laid the groundwork. We've talked about the canon and the books of the Bible. We've talked about the textual history of both the Old and the New Testaments. We've done a bit of a flyover of English Bible translations.
- 8.2 What we're going to end on is the historical person of Jesus. The reason for this is because the Bible as a whole, if we're including both the Old and New Testaments, is centering on Jesus. The whole point is that it comes to the culmination of what the prophets in the Old Testament were looking towards, and then the cultural expectation of this figure, of this Messiah who would come. The claim of the Bible as a whole is that Jesus is that figure. He's the one that—right at the beginning— the one who would crush the serpent's head. Looking at that textual variant in the Latin versus the Hebrew, it's pointing to the savior, the person of Jesus.
- 8.3 Now, there was a study in 2013 that was done for the most influential figures in the world. That was quite a while ago, so maybe the stats would have changed, but I think if we were to look at similar information, we would probably get a similar breakdown. Key being that Jesus, by quite a big number, came up as number one. With the most influential figures that were Googled over the decades previous to 2013, "Jesus" came up time and time again as the most Googled historical figure.
- 8.4 I think there's a reason for that. I think that Jesus has sat at the center of a number of worldview perspectives. Even non-Christian worldviews have attempted to claim Jesus as someone who was influential or had the philosophical provenance to be included within their religious and philosophical systems.
- 8.5 But there's a lot of confusion, and there's a lot of attempts to try to figure out: who do we really say Jesus is? That's the question that Jesus asked his disciples. "Who do you say that I am?" And that continues to be the question. As we've already seen, the source information from that comes from the Bible. If we're looking at trying to figure out who is the historical person of Jesus, we go to the source material that comes from primarily the gospels in that biographical information that comes from the first century, but not limited to that. Paul is actually writing before the gospels are even penned. Some of our earliest source information for who Jesus is comes from the person of Paul talking about this individual.
- 8.6 There have been attempts within pop culture to try to visualize who Jesus was, some of the most famous ones being The Passion of the Christ or depictions by, not just Jim Caviezel and Williem Dafoe, but the most recent iterations with the popularity of The Chosen series. People are fascinated, interested with who Jesus was and how we can understand who that character is.

- 8.7** Now, this is a study, this is a field, a discipline that within the more modern era, academics have likewise been trying to figure out and come to answers for. We have a number of different iterations of what we call the field of historical Jesus studies. In the late 17th and into the 18th century, we have what was referred to as the first movement of the "quest for the historical Jesus."
- 8.8** There was an individual named Hermann Reimarus. Reimarus was a German philosopher and writer of the Enlightenment, who's remembered for his deism. So he wasn't necessarily a Christian, but he was a deist. He believed that there was a God, and the doctrine that human reason can arrive at a knowledge of God and ethics from a study of nature and our own internal reality, thus eliminating the need for religions based on revelation.
- 8.9** He pioneers this study of looking at the historical sources and coming up, when we're talking about Jesus, when we're doing this from an Enlightenment perspective, from a rationalist perspective, who then do we come up with as the character that sits at the center of the Christian worldview? But how do we actually find out? How do we sift through the data and find who that actual historical character was?
- 8.10** According to Reimarus, Jesus was a mortal Jewish prophet, and the Apostles founded Christianity as a religion separate from Jesus's own ministry. He had formulated the idea that it was these people following Jesus, following his death, his crucifixion, who arrived at and contrived and made up this mythology around Jesus in order to cope with the fact that their rabbi was murdered.
- 8.11** And so the 20th century theologian, Albert Schweitzer, in his work, *The Quest of the Historical Jesus*, critiques this first attempt at such a division. I think rightly points out that these secular scholars like Reimarus were simply creating a Jesus in their own image; which is easy to do. But transforming the historical Jesus into a modern philanthropist who preached an inoffensive message of love and brotherhood—by removing the supernatural aspect of who Jesus is, particularly, although not limited to, his miraculous life and the miracles that he performed—Albert Schweitzer points out that individuals like the people who pioneered the first quest for the historical Jesus were just creating an image of a Jesus that fit within a modern Enlightenment rationalistic mold.
- 8.12** Now, the second quest, or what's referred to as the No Quest, followed that with individuals like Rudolf Bultmann. This was marked by an extreme skepticism towards any part of the biblical message being reliable. The "No Quest" for the historical Jesus ruled out any semblance of supernatural events, even more so than the first quest did. Even the mere mentioning of such was labeled as mythic embellishment on the part of naive and "pre-scientific" ancient peoples.
- 8.13** This is what C. S. Lewis later on would qualify as chronological snobbery. The idea that because we are a product in the Enlightenment Age, we can look back on people and

just assume that because they didn't understand, say, cosmology or biology or chemistry like we do today, that therefore they're stupid.

- 8.14** This was critiqued, but this was one of the formulations of the movement. The movement was championed by individuals who labeled the gospels as theological propaganda, masked as historical narrative. Bultmann was influenced by individuals like David Friedrich Strauss and William Wrede and Johannes Weiss.
- 8.15** The second quest, starting with natural materialistic assumptions and assuming that the gospels were theological but not necessarily historical, saw the gospel authors not as eyewitnesses, but as individuals removed from the space and time that they purported to discuss. So shoehorning what they saw as ancient mythology into what probably was an actual historic person. They granted there probably was an actual historic Jesus—this itinerant Jewish rabbi who was preaching in Galilee—but as time went on, and in part in order to create a social movement, all of these things that were ascribed and associated with the No Quest for the historical Jesus, labeled those as silly, as things that we have removed ourselves from because of the rationalism of the Enlightenment.
- 8.16** As time went on, though, we had a different movement, primarily put on by the individuals from the Jesus Seminar. Now, this sought to pull back from the hyperskepticism of the past historical Jesus attempts, but started with largely negative assumptions. The Jesus Seminar was a group of about 50 critical biblical scholars and 100 laymen. It wasn't necessarily just scholars, there were actually individuals who had no expertise in biblical scholarship or historiography whatsoever. But they got together, these 50 critical biblical scholars and 100 laymen, founded in 1985 by Robert Funk. This was the Jesus Seminar, which was very active through the 1980s and 1990s and into the early 21st century.
- 8.17** Members of this seminar used votes with colored beads to decide their collective view of the historicity of the deeds and sayings of Jesus of Nazareth. They published their results in a number of different volumes, *The Five Gospels*, *The Acts of Jesus*, and *The Gospel of Jesus*, which were published, respectively, in 1993, 1998, and then 1999. This also included sayings from the Gospel of Thomas, which they would vote on to delineate whether those had any historic value. But it was interesting that the end result of this was done by a majority vote of the group, what they thought was historical and reliable.
- 8.18** The public interest in the Jesus Seminar was further heightened by the fact that in its version of the gospels, there was precious little actual sayings that they concluded on that they thought Jesus actually said that are recorded in the gospels. They used red beads to vote for an authentic Jesus saying. They used pink beads to vote for a Jesus saying something analogous, or like what was actually recorded in the gospels. They used a gray bead to vote for it not being an authentic saying, but reflecting maybe an

idea, a concept that could fit with Jesus. And then black beads for this not being authentic whatsoever.

- 8.19** Now, this got a lot of press because their conclusions were very skeptical in terms of thinking that anything within the biblical gospels actually reflected something that went back to the historic Jesus. There was precious little red ink to be found in the jars of beads that were used for the voting. In other words, the total number of sayings and deeds considered to be certainly authentic was strikingly small. There's probably little red ink in the publisher's balance sheets for these three volumes as well—they color-coded the gospels in their final volume.
- 8.20** The only red, i.e. certainly authentic segment of the Lord's prayer, for example, is the opening "Our Father." Everything else was deemed to be non-authentic. What they could say was in the Lord's prayer, all we can really be certain on that Jesus actually said was, "Our Father." "Who art in heaven, hallowed be Thy name, Thy kingdom come, Thy will be done." All the rest of that, well, that's embellishment. And there was no red ink that appeared in the Beatitudes whatsoever. So the Sermon on the Mount, completely out.
- 8.21** Now, the question raised by the seminar then is: What can we know about the historic Jesus? This wasn't necessarily solely an academic endeavor, although, of course, there were academics involved. But though it was published before the Jesus Seminar, I think it reflects the sentiment when C. S. Lewis comes up with his Lewisian Trilemma. In *Mere Christianity*, C. S. Lewis posits this idea. If you don't know, *Mere Christianity* is a published volume by C. S. Lewis, which was based on his radio lectures that he did for the BBC, and then they were eventually put into print.
- 8.22** But in it, Lewis posits this idea that if we look at the sayings of Jesus, we have three options. Based on taking what Jesus himself said seriously, Jesus is either a liar, he's a lunatic, or he's the Lord. He's a liar, he's a lunatic or Lord. Why did He say that? He said that because the claims and the statements that Jesus made, if we actually take Him at his word, result in Him being a con man who is trying to influence people for His own gain and power, or He's crazy, or He is the Lord of the universe who He claimed to be, the second person of the Trinity.
- 8.23** I think the way that we come out of looking at these, how we evaluate something, I think—in the groundwork that we've already looked at from things like internal reliability and the coherence in the discussions of the books that were relevant going back to the time frame of Jesus and in the textual history— I think we can look at the gospels and see their reliable categories as history and that Jesus actually claims to be God in what we find in the Bible. So take either of these assumptions off the table and Lewis's argument no longer works.
- 8.24** It is particularly these two points that have been called into question in the last half century since Lewis penned the Trilemma by groups like the Jesus Seminar, is that the

gospels are not reliable history and that the claims of Jesus to be God are far more pliable than we might think. There are a number of scholars who would even advocate for this today, that we see certain statements by Jesus, but they might not be as obvious as Christian history has assumed for the last 2,000 years. Now, cards on the table, I think they are.

- 8.25** But that also merits that we posit another L in Lewis's Trilemma, and that's "legend." In that, there is an idea within society that we could take Jesus and we could, like the critique that Schweitzer has on the first quest for the historical Jesus, say, there are groups today that want to make a Jesus in their own image. They do that by picking and choosing what Jesus says to make Jesus into a guru, to make Jesus into a philosopher, to make Jesus into someone who advocates for a person who is a sage teacher who gives us things that we can live by. But ultimately, I don't really think Jesus gives you the end result of just chalking him up to that, I think, if we take him seriously. We don't want to make Lewis sad, so we need to take these things seriously.
- 8.26** What are we looking at with the information? Well, I was asked earlier about some of these external sources to the biblical documents. Now, I will reiterate again that as historians, we're looking at the primary sources, we want to go to the earliest sources, but it is interesting that a number of individuals do talk about Jesus.
- 8.27** We've quoted Josephus a number of times. He's very relevant in antiquity as a whole, particularly this period. But we see things that he says like what he writes in the Antiquities. He says, "At this time there appeared Jesus, a wise man. For he was a doer of startling deeds, a teacher of the people. And when Pilate, because of an accusation made by the leading men among us, condemned him to the cross, those who had loved him previously did not cease to do so." And he goes on to say, "And so Ananus, the high priest, convened the judges of the Sanhedrin and brought before them a man named James, the brother of Jesus who was called the Christ and certain others, and delivered them up to be stoned."
- 8.28** Now, it's interesting that for the majority of Josephus scholarship, there was a consensus of concluding that the works of Josephus were full of interpolations by Christian scribes to assert things in to make Jesus look a lot better. That's actually been brought into question in the last number of years, particularly by a scholar, T. C. Schmidt, in his work—and I think I'm going to have an image of his work—Jesus and Josephus, which was published, I believe, only last year, which actually brings into question some of the assumptions of assuming that Josephus textual history has been tampered with.
- 8.29** He argues that linguistically, what we've often read as a tacit admission when Josephus says things like, "there was a man named Jesus, if it is right to call him a man," and the assumption being that a pious Jew would not have said that, that doesn't make any sense. It's interesting that scholars have looked at that language and they've compared it throughout the Josephus literature, and they've actually come to the conclusion that

there's almost a sarcastic undercurrent to a lot of these things. That what we have read previously as an admission of Josephus saying, "if it is right to call him a man," is actually far more like, "if it's right to call him a 'man'." There's a sarcastic note undergirding it.

- 8.30** But nonetheless, even if we're going to put aside those types of statements, Josephus gives us a lot here in the Antiquities of the Jews. He gives us some information that is very helpful. He gives us the name of Jesus. He gives us the name of Jesus so we know who he's talking about: Jesus of Nazareth. He also gives us the title. He says Jesus's title as Christ. He gives us the name of Jesus's brother, James; and he gives us the fate of James, that he was killed, he was put to death under this particular high priest, Ananus; and that there was a controversy of Christians that led into the second century.
- 8.31** Now, the Christians were an interesting group because, I think I've already previously discussed, that the Jews were always seen as these troublemaking religious minorities that lived in Judea. The understanding of denying that the gods existed was seen as, at minimum foolish, and at most, dangerous in the ancient world. However, there was still a tacit admission within the ancient world that you could get away with it if it was tied to your cultural identity. The Jews were given a bit of a free pass in saying that actually your pantheon of gods don't exist because it's all those ethnic Jews anyways, and they're strange, and they're a weird bunch.
- 8.32** Christianity comes around, though, and it inherits the monotheistic values of Judaism, but it doesn't get the get-out-of-jail free card that the ethnicity stuff had. That causes a lot of trouble because as Christianity starts to grow, and particularly as it moves from a Jewish movement of Jews that believe in Jesus as the Messiah, to more and more non-Jews—Gentiles, Greeks, Romans—being converted, the pass is eliminated.
- 8.33** One of the earliest critiques of Christianity is that Christians were "atheists", and that's the term that's used. Now, obviously, that means something different today; it's a denial of all gods. But the accusation in the early church of Christians being atheists was because they denied "the" gods. They denied the gods entirely. The earliest accusations of Christians were that they were atheists and that they were antisocial. Those things went hand in hand.
- 8.34** The ancient world was inherently religious. A lot of the just day-to-day activities that went on were tied to religious festivals in celebrations or worship ceremonies or various triumphal entries. They were inherently religious in that day. Christians removing themselves from those things, was labeled as antisocial. So though the Jews have a lot of the same religious qualities as the Christians, the Christians fall under a different category because they don't have the benefit of the excuse of it being related to their ethnic identity.
- 8.35** That's when we start to see the Christians become easy scapegoats for particular problems that happen within the Roman society. So The historian Tertullian has this

line where he says, "If the Tiber River," which is the river that goes through Rome, "If the Tiber River is too high or the Nile River is too low, the cry will ring out, 'the Christians to the lions.'"

- 8.36** Part of that is that when there are natural problems that happen, floods or droughts or other natural disasters, and people are trying to figure out, "Why is this happening? Why are the gods doing this to us?" Sometimes they would conclude, "Well, we're in Athens. Our city-state God is Athena. But there's a group running around who says she doesn't exist. She must be mad. If we deal with that, if we send them to the Colosseums or we execute them, maybe that'll have a better outcome for how Athena treats our city."
- 8.37** This makes Christians, in the first few centuries, easy scapegoats for persecution. Now, this is dispersed. It's not empire-wide. The persecution is varied. It gets really bad under the Emperor Diocletian, who specifically outlaws Christian writing, gathering on Sunday, and makes it a mandate that you need to take a pinch of incense and put it on the altar of Caesar and say the statement "Caesar is Lord" in order to get particular paperwork to buy or sell. This is a document that's referred to as a "libellus" in Latin. In certain parts of the empire, if you didn't have a libellus, you were not allowed to buy at the market, you weren't allowed to sell at the market.
- 8.38** It's not solely aimed at Christians, but these particular groups knew that Christians would not do this because one of the earliest statements of faith within ancient Christianity was "Jesus is Lord," right? "Iēsous kyrios". To go into the public square and take a pinch of incense, which is an act of devotion worship, and put it on the altar of Caesar and say "Kaisar kyrios," Caesar is Lord, is seen as a denial of your faith. Christians wouldn't do this. Christians become easy scapegoats and thus are labeled as atheists.
- 8.39** A part of the people who we have writing about Christians is to figure out, what do we do with some of this stuff? There was a particular political leader named Pliny, who is writing to the Emperor Trajan. One of the reasons why Pliny is writing to Trajan is he's trying to figure out what to do with the Christians in this particular area. When he writes to the Emperor, he says, I've taken these two individuals, these women who are referred to as deaconesses in the church, and I keep torturing them and asking them why they're doing what they're doing.
- 8.40** Looking and reading this, it's interesting that I think he could have just asked them. I don't think he necessarily needed to torture them to figure out what they believed. But he says, "They're a strange bunch." He specifically says, "They meet early in the morning and they sing a hymn to Christ as to a God."
- 8.41** Very early on, we get this description of what Christian worship looked like in the second century from one of the detractors who says they're worshipping God. But we also have mentions of Jesus, particularly, like I said, from individuals talking about what

Christians are doing in their day, from Tacitus in the second century, Lucian in the second century, even Thallus at the end of the first century, and then Josephus in the first century.

- 8.42 We do need to be careful not to over-exaggerate, like I said, what other key ancient characters like Tacitus and Josephus are doing. What they're doing is not describing details they themselves believe about Jesus. All they're doing is describing things that the Christians in their day believed about Jesus. In one sense, these are not direct confirmations regarding details about Jesus' life.
- 8.43 However, where the strength of it lies in analyzing some of this external data, this nonbiblical data, is that given that Jesus' existence is not really in any doubt in contemporary scholarship, the remarks of Tacitus and Josephus add to the historical picture of Jesus that we already know from the much earlier sources of the gospels and Paul's letters. They work to maybe create the frame around the picture of what we see as Jesus.
- 8.44 Tacitus, the greatest of the ancient Roman chroniclers, mentions Jesus in passing while recounting the events of Nero's burning of Rome in 64 AD. In one or two sentences, he confirms the title, According to [Christus], which we've seen, confuses as a personal name and describes him as a criminal duly executed in Judea while Pontius Pilate governed the region.
- 8.45 The Jewish writer Josephus offers two short paragraphs mentioning Jesus. From these, we can confirm that the basic facts about Jesus were sufficiently well known in the second century, in the second half even of the first century, for a largely disinterested non-Christian author to report on them, which is a very interesting fact.
- 8.46 Christianity had grown by the end of the first century to a point, or at least they're making waves— how large they are as a particular people group is debated. But people are taking notice of them. They're not nobodies, and actually they're making influences. We have reports of even people in the Emperor's own household converting to Christianity.
- 8.47 Like I said before, the most recent work of T. C. Schmidt, *Josephus and Jesus: New Evidence for the One Called Christ*, is very interesting, very compelling. I think moving the needle on some of this stuff. He actually analyzes some of the community that Josephus would have been part of. Josephus was a Jewish general in the Jewish Roman Wars, and he actually goes on the side of the Romans. He's a turncoat because he sees the end result of everything that's happening. He knows that the Jews don't have a chance, and he actually advocates for their surrender in order for the preservation of the Jewish people.
- 8.48 And part of his writing in what we now have as *Antiquities of the Jews* is an argument against the Romans to say, "The reason why you shouldn't eliminate us completely is because we have an antiquity in who we are as a people group. And so we're worth

saving as a people group because just like you as Romans have this ancient lineage that goes back to Romulus and Remus, so we too have an ancient lineage. Let me tell you about it." He summarizes all sorts of things, stories from the Old Testament and so on.

8.49 But in this writing, one of the things that T. C. Schmidt does that's very interesting is he ties Josephus' connective community right back to the people who put Jesus on trial. He actually argues that Josephus would have known people who were in the trial of Jesus in the Sanhedrin and in the priestly ruling council.

8.50 When Jesus is put on trial and asked, "Are you the son of the blessed one?" The high priest, Caiaphas, tears his robe saying, "You have heard the blasphemy," and commits Jesus to death, T. C. Schmidt, I think, very convincingly, argues that there would have been people in that room who Josephus would have known and who he very well might have gotten the information about who Jesus was in his eventual being condemned to death from the inner circle. Very interesting.

8.51 Once again, we're looking at source material that is very close. We talked already about Alexander the Great, that he died in 323 BC, and the earliest of the comprehensive material that we have for Alexander's life is coming from Arrian 450 years after he actually lived. Yet for the biblical gospels, we are looking at a time frame that's much, much closer. They're being written within only a few decades after His death. Once again, in the time period considered the pinnacle of what ancient biography was, intersecting with a notably rigorous notion of historiography.

8.52 People would have had standards. If an educated Roman was reading the Gospel of John or the Gospel of Luke, they would have had an assumption of what they considered good history. Both, I think comprehensively, Luke and John do an incredible job at making sure that they're labeling people and places and leaders and geographical locations.

8.53 Some of the turns of phrases that we find in the gospels are not merely incidental. Even in the parable of the Good Samaritan, it talks about going down from Jerusalem to Jericho. Well, there's a reason for that. It's that Jericho is literally—you're going down below sea level. It's not just a turn of phrase going down, but the Dead Sea is the lowest place on Earth. You literally would have been going down from Jerusalem to Jericho. It's not just incidental that Luke uses that terminology.

8.54 Also, interestingly, as just a side note, Luke, who is an educated individual from outside of Galilee, continues to refer to the Sea of Galilee with the Greek word "lake." It's probably because he's been to the Mediterranean and he knows what the sea looks like. Whereas the other authors who are indigenous to the area use the word for "sea" because that could be very well likely the biggest body of water that they would have known about. You see these incidental categories that play into the historiography of what's going on.

- 8.55** What about this idea that the gospels are anonymous? That brings into question the reliability of the authorship of these particular documents in regards to us extrapolating the historical Jesus. Well, let me quote Richard Bauckham. Richard Bauckham, a New Testament scholar, who wrote a very good book called *Jesus and the Eyewitnesses*. He says this, "The assumption that Jesus tradition circulated anonymously in the early church, and therefore the Gospels in which they were gathered and recorded were also originally anonymous, was very widespread in 20th-century Gospel scholarship."
- 8.56** "It was propagated by the form critics as a corollary to their use of the model of folklore, which is passed down anonymously by communities. The Gospels, they thought, were folk literature, similarly anonymous. This use of the model of folklore has been discredited, partly because there is a great difference between folk traditions passed down over centuries in the short span of time, less than a lifetime, that elapsed before Gospels were written. But it is remarkable how tenacious has been the idea that not only the traditions, but the Gospels themselves were originally anonymous."
- 8.57** We do need to differentiate between the categories of what's sometimes referred to as formal anonymity and actual anonymity. Sometimes, scholars will refer to the gospels as anonymous, but people will assume what they mean by that is that we don't know who the authors are. But that's not actually what they might mean.
- 8.58** When we refer to the gospels as formally anonymous, what we mean is that if you took the title, the Gospel, According to Matthew, Mark, Luke, or John off, you would not know who the author was. Like I talked about earlier with some of these Gnostic gospels, the Gnostic gospels are going to lengths to make sure you know: "I'm Peter. I wrote this. I'm a disciple of Jesus. I'm very close to Jesus. Don't forget that fact."
- 8.59** Whereas something that actually lends credibility to the biblical gospels is that they're far less concerned with that. The authority comes from the fact that they're talking about who Jesus is rather than who the author is. At the exact same time, you would not know who the author was. I mean, the Gospel of John appears to indicate that the source information is coming from this individual who is referred to as "the beloved disciple" or "the disciple whom Jesus loves," depending on how you're translating that phrase. But you may not know who it is.
- 8.60** So some people look at this, and they say, "Well, that's problematic. We don't even know who wrote these things. If you took the gospel titles off, then you just would have had no idea." That doesn't go very far with people who study ancient biography, though, and I'll tell you the reason for it.
- 8.61** Of between the 90 and 100 biographical type writings we have, 150 years on either side of Jesus, so this 300-year period of ancient antiquity, only two of those biographical writings identify themselves formally within the writings. All the rest are formally anonymous.

- 8.62** Plutarch, who is considered the most important ancient biographer— he wrote 60 biographies, 40 of which we have surviving today—never mentions himself within any of the extant writings, not once. Not only that, but Caesar and Xenophon are not just formally anonymous, but they write in the third person, not unlike what we find in the Gospel of John and the Gospel of Matthew.
- 8.63** Looking at how actual ancient biography operates, what the gospel authors are doing sits right smack dab in the middle of what we should expect. It is not accustomed to identify yourself within the document. It is the standard within this period of the ancient world to make sure that the actual source information and the thesis of what you're writing is being clarified.
- 8.64** If we think about this, even, I think, reasonably in the modern era, modern biographers do this, too. The biographer isn't going to necessarily write themselves into the biography.
- 8.65** We have, I don't know how many, maybe a dozen Martin Luther biographies. I don't know if the author ever, in the body of the biography, starts talking about himself, nor should he. Maybe in the introduction, maybe something like that. But we wouldn't expect this in the modern era, and yet we seem to have this assumption that that's what they should be doing in the ancient world. But the ancient authors don't have that assumption.
- 8.66** Interestingly enough, if you look at Xenophon, he says things like this. He says, "There was a man in the army named Xenophon, an Athenian, who was neither a general nor captain, nor private, but had accompanied the expedition because Proxenus, an old friend of his, had sent him at his home an invitation to go with him." Then Xenophon talks about himself being a very good warrior. Xenophon was a great warrior.
- 8.67** We have this actually in the Torah. It talks about Moses the wisest man who ever lived. If we're going by the traditional authorship, that's Moses talking about himself. But we have these things where these authors will refer to themselves in the third person. For Matthew or Levi to refer to himself in that way in the Gospel of Matthew, it's not unusual. It's not unusual to see this.
- 8.68** Every time we have in the manuscripts a copy where the beginning or the end is preserved, we always have the titles corresponding to the right gospels. Where you would put the inscription, "the Gospel according to," is either at the very beginning or the very end. In that, we would see that if that section is preserved for us, we never have a different title for a different gospel. It's always when you find the text of the beginning of the Gospel of Matthew, you have it being ascribed to the Gospel of Matthew. Nobody's confused about these.
- 8.69** I think it's interesting to say that this was a later innovation, particularly because the manuscripts get so widespread so early, we have to posit almost a conspiracy theory

that scribes who were removed from one another by language and geography and time, all start to agree despite one another on who wrote these documents.

- 8.70** Is that plausible? I don't think it is. I don't think if we have a scribe in Roman-occupied Britain in the second or third century just thinking, "I think John wrote this, so I'm going to put 'the Gospel according to John,'" and someone in Syria doing the exact same thing at the exact same time, and they happen to agree all at once, all at the same time, with no talking to one another. I think there's a reason why we see that type of thing.
- 8.71** It's because whether there was a title on the original document or the earliest evidence is always pointing to: Matthew the disciple wrote the Gospel of Matthew. John the disciple wrote the Gospel of John. Mark was a traveling companion of Peter, and Luke was a traveling companion of Paul.
- 8.72** Once again, looking at Luke's prologue, Luke saying, "Many have undertaken to draw up an account of the things that have been fulfilled among us, just as they were handed down to us by those who were first eyewitnesses and servants of the word with this in mind, since I myself have carefully investigated everything from the beginning, I, too, decided to write an orderly account for you, most excellent Theophilus, so that you may know the certainty of the things you have been taught." Like I said before, Luke's preface parallels other prefaces that we see in literary and scientific literature in the ancient world, such as Demetrius and Galen and Herodotus, and to a lesser degree, Thucydides. But we see those parallels.
- 8.73** With accusations like, "Well, this is myth, this is fable," which was an assumption that was held in previous centuries of the historical Jesus scholarship, if we even simply look and compare it to the opening line of the Iliad, we see a very big difference. "Rage. Sing, Goddess Achilles's Rage, Black and murderous that caused the Greeks incalculable pain, pitched countless souls of heroes into Hades dark, and left their bodies to rot as feast for dogs and birds, as Zeus's will done, begin with the clash between Agamemnon, the Greek warlord, and the godlike Achilles. Which of the immortals set these two at each other's throats? Apollo, Zeus's son, and Leto's, offended by the warlord. Agamemnon had dishonored Chryses, Apollo's priest. So the god struck the Greek camp with plague, and the soldiers were dying."
- 8.74** It's a little bit different than "I'm undertaking to write an account, an orderly account, and I'm interviewing eyewitnesses." One is attempting to be history, the other is attempting to be an epic poem, even though there might be some historical value to [Homer] and the Iliad and the Odyssey. There might be a core in there with the Trojan War, but it's very different when we compare it with something like the gospels.
- 8.75** I think a good comparative analysis with the historical Jesus is to compare Him to other characters that have similar or like biographical material. The easiest example is the Roman emperor, Tiberius. In the public ministry of Jesus, the emperor at the time was

an individual named Tiberius. In the famous story where Jesus is trying to be trapped by the Pharisees and he's asked whether it is right to pay taxes to Caesar or not. He asked for a coin and they give Him a tribute penny and He says, "Whose image is on this coin?" It's Caesar's. This is the Caesar who they're talking about. This is Tiberius.

- 8.76** Tiberius is an interesting comparison, not only because he is the most well known and the most powerful and the most influential individual within Jesus' day. But because, though it's very unusual to have a number of biographers writing things about you, in this time frame, almost exclusively, we find that the individuals with more than one biographical account writing about them are Jesus and Tiberius. Both have four biographies: Jesus having Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, and Tiberius having Velleius Paterculus, Tacitus, Suetonius, and Cassius Dio.
- 8.77** Now, if we look at the manuscript evidence, we see that the earliest manuscript evidence for Jesus comes in the form of these gospels. The Gospel of Matthew coming from the second century, the Gospel of John coming from the second century, Mark coming from the third century, and then Luke coming from the third century in the manuscripts P1, P52, P137, and P45.
- 8.78** Then recently, there was a manuscript that was found that has sayings of both Matthew and Luke included in it, P-Oxy 15:57, which comes from the second century, which probably wasn't a gospel in its entirety, but was a collection of sayings from both gospels. But this is our earliest manuscript evidence, and it is fragmentary because it's early. You see there on the screen P52 being that evidence for the Gospel of John. So only a couple of verses from the Gospel of John, chapter eighteen.
- 8.79** But if we look at Tiberius' written sources, we see something very analogous. Velleius Paterculus, his fragmentary evidence comes from the first century, so it is actually relatively close. Tacitus is the second century. Suetonius is the second century. But then, Cassius Dio, unfortunately, we don't have anything until the ninth century. Now, these are all examples of incomplete copies. There are earliest surviving fragments of once complete copies of books, but over the centuries and the last two millennia, they've left us only partial stages of existence of the actual evidence.
- 8.80** But if we're talking about our earliest complete copies, what classicists sometimes refer to as the functional manuscripts, things that have all four Gospels, that would come from the fourth century. But for Tiberius, the sources look very different. Velleius Paterculus is coming from the sixteenth century. Tacitus is coming from the ninth, Suetonius the ninth, and Cassius Dio, our earliest copy, is from the ninth, whether fragmentary or otherwise.
- 8.81** Now, I show this to you simply to say that Jesus has some incredible source information if we're looking at the manuscript evidence, the source writing for Him. I would caution saying it's better than Tiberius, but at minimum, it's analogous, which is really something, considering that Jesus is an itinerant rabbi from Judea, and Tiberius is the

Roman emperor. And yet we have a very interesting on-par comparative analysis with the source information.

- 8.82** And when we're talking about the earliest complete copies, Jesus actually comes up a lot better, a few hundred years better, especially when we're talking about something like Velleius Paterculus with the earliest functioning copy coming from the sixteenth century. Once again, not to cast aspersions on those writings. I think there's a good textual history that shows that those writings about Tiberius are the earliest.
- 8.83** Interestingly enough, though our earliest fragmentary copy of Velleius Paterculus does come from the first century, and he's writing in the first century, he's actually a paid political propagandist and has monetary incentive to write about the emperor well. So though it's our earliest source material for Tiberius, it's often looked upon as the most skeptical.
- 8.84** This is unusual in the ancient world. You have very few examples of multiple evidences of source information. Jesus is unusual in having Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. Even someone like Socrates only has a few biographers: Xenophon, Plato, and Aristophanes. I sometimes say there was actually another important student of Socrates that wrote about him, and his work is of such low quality that nobody remembers him. He was Mediocrates. It's a joke. Thank you for laughing, though.
- 8.85** It's interesting that if we go back to Luke's preface—and I'm picking on him in particular because there are good examples— he uses a term that is also used by Lucian and Josephus that we translate as "account" or "narrative" that they also use in talking about how to write good history, that you should be writing an orderly account. That's the exact terminology that he uses.
- 8.86** Now, if we go to Luke 3, we find something very interesting because Luke has a missing number of people. He says, "In the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar, Pontius Pilate being governor of Judea, and Herod being tetrarch of Galilee, and his brother Philip, tetrarch of the region of Ituraea, and Trachonitis, and Lysanias, tetrarch of Abilene, during the high priesthood of Annas and Caiaphas, the word of God came to John, the son of Zechariah in the wilderness."
- 8.87** It's interesting that there are close to 22 historical characters and where they actually were in charge of that have been verified via archaeology and/or other ancient literary sources outside of the Bible that confirm that when Luke prefaces John the Baptist's ministry, he exhaustively lists everybody he could possibly list, and they correspond correctly with who those people were and where they were writing.
- 8.88** Now, about 100 years ago, the Lysanias, who was tetrarch of Abilene, that one was the questionable one because Josephus actually talks about a Lysanias who's tetrarch of Abilene. Josephus puts him earlier than this. He put him in the first century BC, I believe. For a long time, scholars said, "Well, this is a mistake by Luke. Luke's trying to do a really good job, but he's making a mistake here. It doesn't really fit. We know from

Josephus that this person was earlier." Until we discovered an inscription stone that says, "Lysanias tetrarch established this street and other things," that comes from between AD 14 and AD 29, which indicates that whoever this Lysanias that Luke is talking about, maybe it's Lysanias II, maybe it's the son of the Lysanias, Josephus was talking about, or maybe Josephus got it wrong because the archaeological data confirms that there was a Lysanias during this time in this place.

- 8.89** But Luke is exhaustively talking about these things. We see this throughout the gospels is that time and time again—we looked at some of those internal things, the undesigned coincidences, the ancillary details—people like the author of the Gospel of Luke, they're making sure that their audience knows" What I'm writing about is history. I'm not attempting to write mythology. I'm not attempting to write an epic poem. This isn't folklore. I'm talking about a real person at a real place at a real time."
- 8.90** I think Luke and John do this most comprehensively because I think their targeted audience is potentially a different group than Matthew and Mark. But they're going to the lengths of establishing that groundwork so that in their day, but also 2,000 years later, we can look at this information and we can say, "Okay, there's something here. We can go off this."
- 8.91** Similarly, I think the second part of that quest for the historical Jesus was putting into question Jesus's own statements about His divinity, that these things need to be excised from who we see as the historical Jesus character. That He really wasn't actually claiming to be God.
- 8.92** I think that comes down to this question we find in Jesus asking His disciples in three of the gospels, but particularly right in the middle of the Gospel of Mark, we have Jesus turning to His disciples and saying, "Who do you say that I am?" I would argue this is the entire theme of the Bible. Who do we say that Jesus is? There's this mystery character in the Old Testament. At least in the first century, we have this cultural expectation that someone is going to come.
- 8.93** Jesus goes and He talks to the Samaritan woman at the well and she says, "We know that the Messiah is coming, that He's going to teach us all things." There's this expectation, even in Jesus' day, something's going to happen, someone's going to come, they're going to save us, He's going to save us. So, Jesus asked, "Who do you say that I am?" I think that's the question He's trying to fish from the disciples, but that's the question that I think is relevant when we approach the Bible.
- 8.94** Yes, the Bible is a collection of historical documents, but the Christian claim is that it's no less than that, but it's much more than that. Because Jesus isn't just another character like Tiberius or Socrates, who no doubt have been influential throughout history. Socratic philosophy is still popular today, but not in the same way that Jesus of Nazareth is popular. I think it's because of His claims.

- 8.95** There are many claims that we could look at throughout the gospels, but I think one of the most interesting ones that is found in all four Gospels is the claim of Jesus calling Himself the Lord of the Sabbath. Now, there's a bit of an aside here. In John's Gospel, he says, "My Father is working until now, and I am working." But it's the same idea as in Mark.
- 8.96** Jesus is accused of working on the Sabbath because His disciples are picking heads of grain when they're coming from Him teaching and they're eating it. And so, under the Mosaic law, the Pharisees consider this work. You're milling the flour in order to eat the grain. Jesus looks at His detractors and He says, "My followers can do this because I'm Lord of the Sabbath."
- 8.97** Now, there's a number of things that are in play with that particular title. But one of the most interesting ones is when we read intertestamental Jewish literature, so literature that's being written between the end of the Old Testament and the beginning of the New Testament by, say, groups like the Sadducees and the Pharisees or the Essenes. We have these theological treatises that talk about what it means to rest on the Sabbath.
- 8.98** One thing that they talk about is among the various ways and reasons why it is right for God's people to rest on the Sabbath, one of those is an acknowledgement that God is the only one who has the ability to create. We create six days a week in our reflection of bearing the image of God, but we pause on one day a week to acknowledge that God is the only one who actually is able to work, to create.
- 8.99** And that God, in one way, though He rested on the seventh, there's an ongoing action of God continuing to work in that He's continuing to make the sun rise in the morning, and He's continuing to give life and breath to every living creature on earth. He's continuing to make plants grow from the ground and bring the seasons and have them in working order. That is part of God's ongoing creative action because He is the Lord of the Sabbath.
- 8.100** When Jesus looks at his detractors and He says, "I can do this because I'm Lord of the Sabbath," and when they get very mad at Him, part of what we miss, because we aren't living in an ancient Jewish context, is that one of the things that would have been heard when Jesus said that was, "Don't worry about it because I'm the guy who makes the sun rise in the morning." That's a big claim. That's a claim of divinity, if I ever heard one. Because you wouldn't claim that if you didn't actually mean to claim an act of divinity.
- 8.101** Now, Jesus never comes out with a statement and says, "I am God." I think we shouldn't expect that. It would have been a foolish thing to say. Actually, I don't even think the Jews would have cared, although there would have been an aspect of them being very uncomfortable with blasphemy. But any old person can claim to be God. What Jesus does is He ascribes to Himself the names and the attributes and the deeds

of God. He honors the attributes, the names, the deeds, and then ultimately describes Himself as being able to sit on the seat of God.

- 8.102** I'm borrowing that from two scholars Rob Bowman and Ed Komoszewski, who wrote a book. The recent update was called *The Incarnate Christ and His Critics*, where they come up with this acronym, HANDS, H-A-N-D-S, the honors, the attributes, the names, the deeds, and the seat of God. In going through the ways that Jesus does this.
- 8.103** Because Jesus is not just saying, "I am God." He's using terminology that is understood to have been God. He's claiming to be God in a Jewish accent is what he's doing. His audience understands that. Then He does the miracles. He walks on the water, which Job says only God does. He heals the blind and the lame, which is what in Isaiah is said that God does. He says, "I'm the good shepherd," which in the Psalms is who God is. Time and time again, He walks on the water. These are things that are associated with divinity.
- 8.104** Right down to the trial at the end of Mark's Gospel, when He's put on trial, they say, "Are you the Son of the Blessed one?" And he says, "I am. And you shall see the Son of Man riding on the clouds of heaven," referring to Daniel chapter seven, where we have this figure, the Son of Man who's coming, who's being given authority by the Ancient of Days to have dominion and power and honor and glory.
- 8.105** It's interesting that the high priest tears his robe. We have recorded for us in the Levitical law and then some of the Mishnaic writings that it's not appropriate for that priest to tear his robe except for one reason, and that's blasphemy. That's exactly what we see happening. But the thing about Jesus that's recorded in all four Gospels, about Him claiming to be Lord of the Sabbath, is that it is a divine claim.
- 8.106** Once again, when we look at the manuscripts, we see something very interesting. We see that the manuscript evidence that's been preserved for us continues to show this textual accuracy that we've touched on already a little bit. It continues to communicate to us that though we're removed by almost 2,000 years from the manuscript tradition, we can look at what we have and we can look at its preservation in something like the manuscript that's on the screen for you, which is P66, which is one of the earliest near-complete copies of the Gospel of John.
- 8.107** Right at the beginning, what we see is that it says— and we can all read along together on the screen, right? I'll change it for us—"In the beginning was the word, and the word was with God, and the word was God, and He was in the beginning with God. All things were made through Him, and without Him was nothing made that was made." That's how it reads, and it reads that way for a reason. That's exactly how your English Bible will read today.
- 8.108** That's not to say there aren't textual variants within P66 itself. There are, and the scribe of P66 was far more concerned with making a pretty manuscript than making an accurate manuscript and has to go back and make close to 300 corrections of his own

writing. But in John 1:1-14, there are no differences between a modern critical text and the Greek text of what we think of as John, chapter one.

- 8.109** In his letter to the Corinthians, Paul affirms monotheism and therefore upholds the faith of his ancestors. But he does an interesting thing. He quotes from the Shemá, "Hear Israel, the Lord is God, the Lord is one God," which has been said every morning and evening by Orthodox Jews, arguably from the time of Moses to today. But he includes Jesus.
- 8.110** In his iteration of the Shemá, he says, "Yet for us there is one God, the Father, for whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist." In doing this, Paul both affirms monotheism and therefore upholds the faith of his ancestors, but as well as embeds the name of Jesus into the very definition of God in scripture found in the creedal formula of Deuteronomy 6:4. Without creating a division, he includes both the Father and he includes Jesus. I think he's carrying on that tradition of what we see from what Jesus actually said in his own words.
- 8.111** So, I think from the historical data, though there is skepticism within the academic world about the historical Jesus, and though we have echoes of groups like the Jesus Seminar, which still make influences today, I think over the last few days, what we've seen via the historical analysis of the reliability of the Bible from its canonicity to its textual history, to even the transmission of the English Bible, is that when it centers around the historical Jesus, there is good reason to believe that what we have now is what the original authors wrote, and that it is the preserved words that communicate an accurate early and eyewitness picture of who Jesus is. Thank you.
- 8.112** One of the claims of the text is sufficiency, all sufficient, and so it goes beyond reliability that it's enough. What do you make of that and what's its scope?
- 8.113** Yeah, I think, historically, in my own tradition as a Reformed Protestant, the idea of sola scriptura, that scripture is the sole infallible rule of faith and practice for the church, the sufficiency of that is that in what it is attempting to communicate to us, it does effectively. That doesn't mean that everything is clear, but the sufficiency of the understanding, what do I need to know?
- 8.114** Well, the gospel is what I need to know of who Jesus is and what He has accomplished that I can't in His finished work on the cross. That doesn't mean that everything throughout scripture is clear, but it means what is meant to be clear is clear, and I do not need to add anything to it. The sufficient work of Jesus on the cross is full in its nature and scope.
- 8.115** We even see this working in the text of the Bible itself when Paul writes to the church in Galatia and he's talking to this and he's saying, "You have the gospel while you're adding circumcision to it; you are telling Gentiles who are believing in Jesus as the Messiah that they now need to be circumcised; they need to become Jews."

- 8.116** He uses the strongest words in all of the New Testament for them and says that in invalidating its sufficiency—because the gospel is sufficient only in its entirety. Add to it, it's no longer the gospel. Take away from it, it's no longer the gospel. He says, "You're doing one thing, and that's all you need to do." You're requiring, you're binding someone's conscience to needing circumcision, and so therefore you're nullifying the gospel.
- 8.117** In that sense, you see almost like the sufficiency of scripture outworking in also the sufficiency of God's own acts. When Paul writes to the church in Corinth, 1 Corinthians 15, and says, "I'm passing on to you what is of first importance." This is generally agreed to be a creed that actually predates Paul that was given to him. He says that Christ died according to the scriptures, that he was buried and that he was raised on the third day, according to the scriptures, his argument is presuppositional in that it's pointing back to the sufficiency of scripture.
- 8.118** We should have been seeing this because scripture is sufficient and actually able to communicate who the Messiah would be. And though we've been misinterpreting it for a long time, we now understand it—hindsight's 20/20—in that the sufficiency is now brought out to us. And so that scripture is sufficient and Christ is sufficient and salvation is sufficient insofar as what it is aiming to be clear on, it's clear on. And so there's no need to add or take away.
- 8.119** This is one of the issues with the Protestant Reformation. When the Reformers were looking at the church, one of their contentions was that you are unnecessarily adding things to the salvific work of Christ on the cross, and you are invalidating its sufficiency with something like indulgences, that Christ's work is sufficient to save people.
- 8.120** When the angel comes to Mary, he says, "You're going to have a son, you're going to name Him Jesus because He will save His people." And Luther looks at that and he says, "Well, what are we saying about needing to burn off venial sins in purgatory? If Christ has saved us, if in Romans 8, it says, 'There's no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus,' what does that mean if we have this added doctrine?"
- 8.121** Now, the caveat to that is that if it was just, Paul says, "I aim to know nothing but Christ crucified," well, there's obviously more than that because he wrote a lot more than just that. He wrote a lot of letters expanding upon what that all means. That doesn't mean that the gospel isn't simple in salvific work, but it does mean that, though it is no less than that, there are things that we do need to make sure that we're maintaining clarity on in order that the sufficiency actually comes through.
- 8.122** Why did you choose the path of proving the historical reliability of the Bible?
- 8.123** I wasn't really—and no fault of my parents—not educated comprehensively on this stuff. So, in trying to figure out where my faith journey lay, when I started to learn things about the history of the Bible, I was just fascinated. I was fascinated by the

history of individuals who labored over copying and preserving and getting the text to where we are today.

- 8.124** You look at some of these manuscripts from the Middle Ages, and these scribes are writing things in the margin. "As the sailor sees the shore and rejoices, so I rejoice to finish the Gospel of Mark." You see the character of the individuals throughout history that have been involved in this story. It's not detached. These aren't just lifeless physical pieces of papyri and parchment. There's a long span of history and tradition of people involved in this process.
- 8.125** I think it speaks to the faith of Christianity that I claim to hold and that God ties himself to saying, "I'm the God of your fathers. I'm the God of Abraham and Isaac and Jacob." It's personal. Just being really fascinated with having the opportunity and the privilege to, in some cases, hold some of these documents of history in my hands and think about what it took to get it to me today, that the Bible didn't fall out of the sky with the leather cover and gold edging on the pages.
- 8.126** I'm very thankful that I have one with a leather cover and gold edging on the pages, but that's not what it looked like. I would be naive to assume that that's what happened or that it was dug up on golden plates in the forest somewhere. I would be naive, I think, to think that that's how divine inspiration or historical accuracy actually played out.
- 8.127** As I went further and further down that rabbit hole, I found more and more interesting facts and pieces of data that ultimately confirmed what I actually thought to be true. As I studied these things, even the textual variants, looking into 600,000 differences within the manuscript tradition, that didn't undercut what I believe. Ironically, all those differences, the nitty-gritty of figuring out these mistakes in the Greek that the scribes were making over 2,000 years, actually encouraged me that I can do this in the 21st century and see the history there. It doesn't undercut what I believe. It actually emboldens me and gives me confidence.
- 8.128** What are some other theological bias translations that have attempted to alter the person of Jesus, historically based off of the work you've done?
- 8.129** Are you asking me to name names? I think there are—I mean, obviously, I would say the Joseph Smith translation. In terms of the historical veracity, I actually don't even know that many members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints who actually use the Joseph Smith translation. Typically, they use the King James translation. I don't know wholly the reason why that is, but the Joseph Smith translation is bad. I mean, that's putting it lightly. He wrote himself into the text of Genesis. It's not even pretending to really deal with what we find in the Greek and the Hebrew.
- 8.130** But there are more modern translations. There's one referred to as the Passion Translation, which was done by an individual. I believe his name is Brian Simmons. His methodology in his "translation" is, at minimum, silly. He claims divine revelation in some of it and continually in his translation notes refers to the original Aramaic. There

is no original Aramaic. It's only in Greek. The Aramaic that we do have is a translation from the fourth century from the Greek into Syriac Aramaic. To refer to the original Aramaic is a nonpoint; there is no such thing.

- 8.131** There are examples of these which are poor translations. The Mirror Bible is another one which is just not—it's not that it's not a good translation. It's just that it's so bad that it might as well be labeled in a category of its own for non-use entirely. Fortunately, there are very few of these.
- 8.132** Like I said before, it's not that when a single individual produces a translation, it's the worst thing in the world. I think sometimes they're very interesting. David Bentley Hart has his own translation. N. T. Wright has his own translation. But I don't think either of those individuals are attempting to then subvert some of the mainstream translations. I don't think that's their purpose in doing that. I think what they're putting out into the world is maybe an exercise in how they would themselves communicate these particular texts, in how they would render the languages. But if you were to talk to Hart or Wright and say, "Your Bible is the only Bible I read," not knowing exactly, I think they might be like, "You probably shouldn't do that." They're wise and intelligent enough scholars to know that there's a reason why we use translation committees.
- 8.133** But any translation that is done by a single individual, I think, is always going to have the preconceived bias of that individual in some degree. It's not that a translation committee wholesale solves that problem, but it does a good job of it.
- 8.134** That's why the differences between most of the mainstream translations is very minor. You do have the "little children" and "gentle" examples that we used, that I illustrated in the previous lecture. But the difference between the English Standard Version and the New American Standard Bible is largely semicolons. That's it. There's more than that, but I think it comes down to that or specific preferences.
- 8.135** The Legacy Standard Bible is largely just an update to the New American Standard Bible, but does things like has chosen to render the divine name. Instead of going capital L-O-R-D, it says Yahweh. That's a point that they've purposefully chosen to do. But on the whole, I think the number of translations that are sectarian translations that should be avoided are few and far between and are easy to see and label, fortunately.